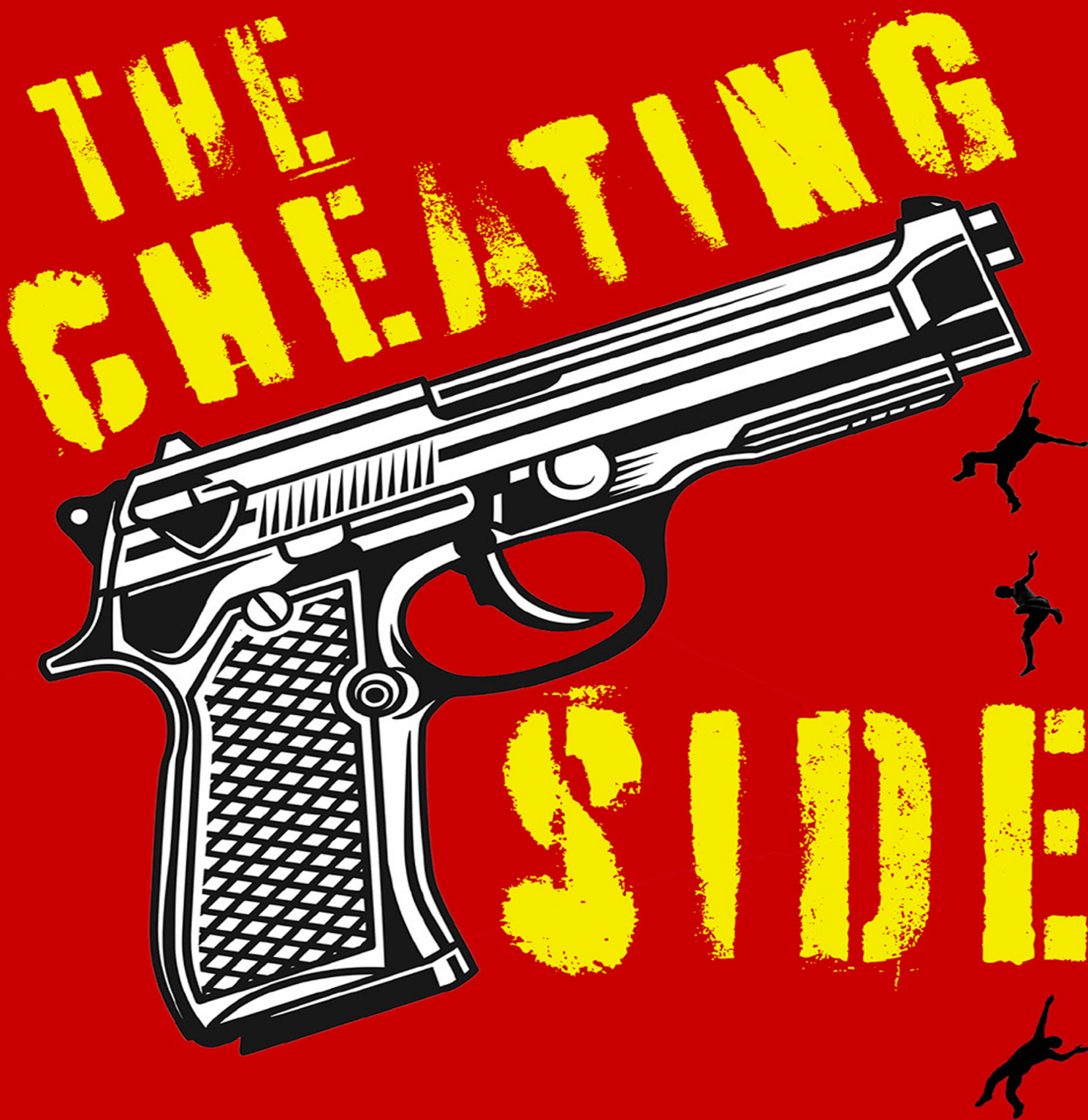


"Appelman writes with soul and swagger. *The Cheating Side* ignites from the very first page and burns everything in its path. A truly breathtaking read."

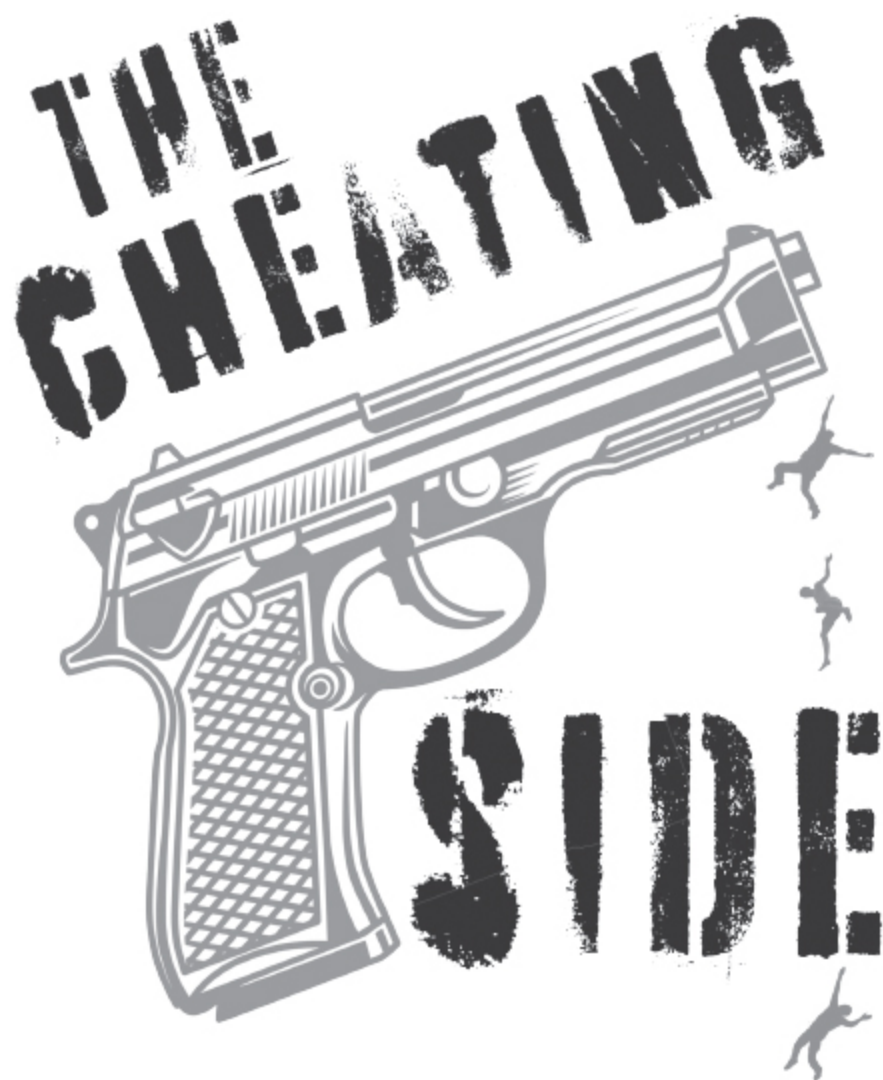
—Alex Gansa, creator of Showtime's *Homeland* series.

J. REUBEN APPELMAN

AUTHOR OF *WHILE IDAHO SLEPT* AND *THE KILL JAR*



J. REUBEN APPELMAN



ALSO BY J. REUBEN APPELMAN

While Idaho Slept
The Kill Jar

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Praise for *THE KILL JAR*

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**THE
CHEATING
SIDE**



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Those who live, live off the dead.
—Antonin Artaud

*for Adilyne and Jackson Sugar,
and for Astrid and Asta*



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ONE

Jimmy awoke under electric blue skies on the forward deck of a fiberglass sport fishing boat at sea. It must have been midday—the sun flared against his retinas and water vultures circled a hundred feet above, burning into the coronas. The birds looked like black shadows crossing from other planes of existence, the way ghosts sometimes seemed to dart between the corners of unfamiliar bedrooms those years Jimmy'd been drinking.

There were no sounds at first but the waves knocking against one side of the boat. Then Jimmy heard the blood pounding in his head from ear to ear and remembered his broken tooth, a molar that'd made a splintered-wood sound cracking from his jaw, like a door jamb kicked through.

Until this week, Jimmy hadn't had a drink in fifteen years, but there were two empty bottles of tequila on their sides nearby, and when the bow of the boat lifted each rolled backward like those .45 casings that'd spun across the tile flooring of his small apartment overlooking Playa Los Muertos—*when, only this morning?*

Three men in black ski masks had busted through his door like in cartel movies dragging the woman named Isabella from Jimmy's bed and taking her. Jimmy adrenalized-awake, instinctively flipping toward his 9mm in the drawer of the nightstand but then hit with an electrical stun in the solar plexus—the nerve endings in his chest constricting, his heart momentarily seizing. He'd briefly smelled what could have been the ethanol-scented air off the bay or his own flesh searing. One of the men had turned back into the bedroom on his way out, firing two shots above Jimmy's head, a warning to stay the fuck down.

The fishing boat now lurched horizontally, then settled. Jimmy tried to stand but discovered his wrists zip-tied to the chrome railing. Both his arms were numb, suspended overhead without blood flow. That would explain the pain traveling through his

neck. His fingers bloated and alien-seeming and without sensation, one of them still discolored where a wedding band had kept the sunlight at bay for fifteen years, a whole lifetime ago. The imprint of that raw deal had girded his finger all this time.

He was six-foot-one and highly trained, but what did that matter now?

Jimmy struggled to one knee and peered across the bow to a half mile of saltwater between him and Puerto Vallarta. Nothing good awaited him on land. About a dozen people wanted him dead, although at this point it was hard to remember details through his tequila headache. He barely remembered getting onto the boat.

From his periphery, Jimmy felt a cooling shadow cross his stubbled face and thought one of the water vultures must have descended. Then he turned and saw the cauliflower-shaped toes of Tio Flores taking purchase against the deck. Flores in yellow board shorts stained with blood; the black hairs on his upper legs thick and bristling but stopping short of Flores' shins where well-over a half-century of elastic socks had rubbed them to a shine.

"Found the money, Jimmy," Flores said, and Jimmy knew there must be bodies floating behind the boat somewhere, maybe already ballooning with saltwater.

"Not all of it," Jimmy told him through a parched mouth. Could barely get the words out.

Flores raised the .32 in his hand like a TV remote, like to turn Jimmy off.

"Most is sometimes enough," he said.

Jimmy slumped back onto his rear. Less than an ounce of plastic held him zipped to the railing. He could eventually break free, regain his strength somehow, but right now Flores had Jimmy's number. Jimmy ran his tongue over his lips feeling the skin crack open like asphalt. The hot sunlight slanted across both of them and the sea rolled harder.

"How long are you gonna stand there?" Jimmy asked. Then he realized that Flores had only been waiting for the waves to settle so he wouldn't overshoot.

Jimmy choked on thoughts of his son and daughter, both in their twenties—the boy an infantryman left-over in Afghanistan, a beautiful kid with brains as big as his guts, and the girl, two years older, living under an assumed name in New York City after death threats followed an article she'd penned for the *Times*. Both his children on the edge of darkness, both stronger than Jimmy'd ever been, yet neither of them knowing the whole Jimmy.

He might've divulged everything, if given the chance, but the sun that was just goddamned spiteful at sea cast no do-overs across the horizon, only scalding, "fuck you, it's over" laughter in the face of last regrets. Jimmy closed his eyes thinking of the brightly burning oven door we all passed through in the end.

The boat dipped forward again and one of the tequila bottles shot past Jimmy's feet as fast as the two and a half decades of raising his kids. Two more dips, one bottle rolling backward and forward again—the other bottle lodged under a life preserver—and then the boat rested as calmly as if shored upon a pat of butter.

He winked at the sun with his left eye, flakes of dried blood crumbling away, hoped his daughter would remember the combination to the floor safe hidden beneath hardwood planks under his refrigerator back in Boise. If she couldn't remember, his son would know how to crack it. That's all Jimmy could ask for now, that his children unlock whatever secrets he'd left them, inherit a little cash to make them comfortable.

A wisp of cool air crossed the boat. Jimmy closed his eyes and remembered the smell of primrose through the open windows of his home in Boise's North End each spring. He opened his eyes again as Flores stepped forward, his shorts rising with an adrenaline erection.

"Jesus," Jimmy whispered just before his left armpit burned with the slug exploding from Flores' .32.

The blood down Jimmy's left side ribcage felt like a layer of sweat cooling him as it wetted the crème-colored linen shirt he'd pulled from a market in Havana three years ago, the vultures circling lower now as Jimmy remembered traveling with his son, the boy on leave, the two of them smoking cigars and drinking cold

bottles of San Pellegrino outside a café. The cobblestone alley beneath their wrought iron table had seen war, murder, lovemaking, and years of soccer balls kicked back and forth by skinny, brown-legged kids. Havana had been good, the memories like skywriting in that blue expanse above the boat.

He closed his eyes and felt the second shot from the .32 before he heard it, two of his ribs separating from the slug as sure as the M-80s he'd popped-open pears with in the orchards west of Boise as a kid, sure as a baseball cracked into left field.

Jimmy heard two more shots but was drifting into something like sleep and couldn't tell if the sound of gunfire originated from the .32 or from fallen sticks breaking beneath Jimmy's own tennis shoes as he ran through a woods along the river as a boy, a pearl-handled switchblade in the back pocket of his jeans, a wad of stolen cash rolled up and squeezed into his right fist like a racing baton, such was the dream he entered into now.



Just a month earlier Jimmy had been driving two hundred and fifty miles into the desert east of Boise to investigate the theft of a 1961 Impala rebuild worth over \$250,000 and owned by the daughter of Idaho State Senator Grisham Greasley.

And what a shitshow, Jimmy'd thought. That investigation placing him squarely in the crosshairs usually only well-practiced fools or the overly brave wandered into.

The Impala had been boosted from an auction house on the pier in Monterey, California the night after failing to sell at its spec value, a common occurrence when classic car investors lost their ass to a market shift then hired one of LA's two grand a night "Pennzoil pirates" to hop the fence and disappear the vehicle for a fraction of the insurance outlay. The timing made the insurance company suspect the theft was a setup like the ones they saw frequently, the senator's daughter maybe drowning on the rebuild price. Jimmy working the case as a private investigator was on contract with the State Farm outfit in Boise to handle their

field work had been sent a secure link to the file, including surveillance footage from Monterey that proved useless, as all exterior camera lenses had been gauzy with summertime spider webs, distorting the imagery.

According to initial claim documents, Senator Greasley's daughter was forty grand in debt to the vehicle's rebuilder, a scrap metal exporter named Tio Flores who lived on an eighty-acre automobile graveyard halfway between the town of Blackfoot and the neighboring Fort Hall Shoshone-Bannock Reservation. Blackfoot itself, named when 1800s-era fires ripped across the high desert and the Indigenous walked the ashes in their bare feet, still seemed a place of mourning for white intrusion. Some believed ghosts haunted the landscape. Jimmy thought that was probably true.

His investigation into the theft was to be cursory, as Senator Greasley's association with the case had rattled the insurance adjuster—he'd called Jimmy's cell after uploading the claim documents, asked Jimmy to chronicle only glaring red flags, then hung up on Jimmy like getting rid of an ex-girlfriend.

Grisham Greasley was well known in the northern part of the state, even prior to his political career. In his twenties, he'd made his bones in the timber industry and answered to either "Gee-Gee" a reflection of his initials or 88 that not only mimicked Nazi SS imagery but was also the symbol of an entrenched white supremacist faction outside of Coeur d'Alene where Greasley's family still owned a thousand acres of forest that included a razor-wired compound of homes and outbuildings—aerial imaging of the property showed concrete gun towers at two locations.

In the late 1980s, two of Greasley's cousins did brief prison time for the aggravated sexual assault of a University of Idaho forestry student from New Jersey. Both cousins were murdered behind bars, revenge for their attack on the young student, a niece of the Jersey mob boss who'd sent her to help the Mafia carpetbag their way into the North Idaho lumber boom. Greasley's cousins had smelled the olive oil on her skin a mile away, they'd joked

before tying her over a stump. By Christmas at the prison in Orofino they were worm food.

In the 1990s and for years afterward, many of the dozens of properties the senator owned throughout Idaho started to burn down at an unusually high rate. To insiders, the fires looked like arson, Greasley liquidating them to shift his cash. This was common practice before insurance companies filled their rosters with private investigators like Jimmy.

The senator never got charges put on him, but the rumors lingered and became the smell Greasley carried into a room—same as the other, more malodorous rumors circulating in the 2000s that Greasley was somehow connected to a rash of young women missing from reservation lands.

Jimmy made good time across the desert, entered the Fort Hall Reservation north of Pocatello with time to kill before meeting Flores outside of Blackfoot ten miles away. He usually neglected to eat until suppertime but felt cravings for a meal and strong coffee, hoped the reservation's casino would have what he wanted. Its tacky exterior like a Chuck E. Cheese dropped into the desert, a splash of neon across the entryway overwhelming his senses—he was mildly autistic, never really thought much about that until bright lights or loud sounds bounced like a jackhammer in his brain. To Jimmy, the casino's signage radiated like starburst, not the way sunshine sparkled through cloud cover but how galaxies collided.

Inside, the cigarette smoke and fruit-scented air freshener reminded Jimmy of the perfume worn by some of the exotic dancers in his Alcoholics Anonymous meetings. The too many of them he'd attended. And too many of the same types of women sitting across from too many of the same types of men as Jimmy, blank faced from lack of excuses for the feelings of emptiness they'd fought.

He ate a cheesesteak on stale bread at a laminated tabletop near the rear of the casino, noticed how the slot machines no longer feigned opulence these days—now grotesquely covered in Japanese anime and Simpsons cartoon characters. A few of the

regular gamblers were tied to them umbilically via Players Cards leashed directly from their hip to the machine. It was fucking depressing.

He was swallowing burnt coffee grounds from the bottom of a Styrofoam cup when he recognized the lanky kid pushing a custodial cart—not a kid anymore but Jimmy’s daughter’s age, twenty-five now, a former classmate of hers.

Jimmy’s skin crawled.

The boy’s name was Brody Hawkstellar, son to Senator Greasley’s press secretary, Evelyn Hawkstellar. In the tenth grade, Brody had called Jimmy’s daughter a “morally impoverished faggot” after she’d come out as queer in the school newspaper. Then Brody’d stalked her after school, walked behind her for blocks, whistled “Dixie” the whole time, an anthem to Confederate bigotry regaining popularity a century and a half later, even in the North, where no children of Idahoans, hip as it’d become for the white disenfranchised to wear a Confederate flag on their ballcaps, had any rightful claim to so-called Southern Pride beyond their unfathomable fear of sexuality, gender, and color. Not that Jimmy’d been counting, but it wouldn’t take many more idiots to feel like Idaho was popping at the seams with them.

His children sometimes felt claustrophobic beneath the fog of racism that settled into their valley for years at a time, usually surrounding Federal elections. Jimmy’s daughter had come home from school distraught that day, bruised her knuckles punching through the plaster in her bedroom before telling Jimmy what’d happened with the Hawkstellar boy.

In a rare fit, Jimmy surveilled Hawkstellar for two days, hoping to get video of the kid trafficking weed—it was known he’d purchased a Ducati motorcycle with drug money. Jimmy’s thought had been to get the boy jailed and bribe somebody on the inside to shake the stupid from him.

Sensibly, Jimmy’d returned home to his daughter instead. Finally, and tearfully, he’d hugged her at the kitchen table, too fainthearted or practiced at discretion to reveal his own similar leanings. Jimmy’s *versatility*, he imagined, was deeply rooted in

the experience of being raised in his mother's derelict motel where everything under the sun happened inside those rooms. Jimmy learned to accept uncomfortable parts of decent-seeming men who otherwise carried reputations of indecency. Jimmy's own sexuality fit nicely on the list of metaphorical fuck-yous in his back pocket all these years. On the other hand, he'd also seen men's skulls caved-in, careers shitcanned, homes firebombed when outed. He'd assimilated to protect his children and had not second-guessed his discretion even once. Besides, in the closet was where *everyone* kept the good stuff, their guns and money, maybe a few photographs from past lives. If only *good* were compatible with *safe*, he'd often thought.

Regardless of what'd steered the needle, for Jimmy and his daughter to be true to themselves, he could have said, they would have to be incompatible with a society that rewarded spiritual cowardice. The weakest of our citizenry rose to the top, he'd need to admit to her, but instead kept his mouth shut all these years.

Jimmy watched as Brody Hawkstellar pushed the large custodial cart with its yellow saddle bags and lifted the ashtrays one-by-one from their tabletops, tapping butts into a steel drum on the bottom of the cart. The boy scratched at his right leg.

Jimmy caught a flash beneath the hem of his work pants as Hawkstellar looked up, scanning the room out of what seemed like boredom. He eventually met Jimmy's gaze.

"Mister Chinden!"

His eyes had mint-green irises, his skin like the only light it'd seen outside the casino was prison-issue halogens. He extended a hand and Jimmy instantly regretted taking it, the boy's spectacularly long fingers like a talon reaching almost to Jimmy's wrist.

"That's either a parole monitor or a small caliber piece under your cuff," Jimmy said, riding the boy hard and maybe unfairly, before he could catch himself.

"Neither one would surprise you, I suppose. It's like I can read your thoughts, Chinden!"

"What happened to 'Mister'?"

The boy held his breath. Then he said, “The way I figure it, when I’m nice to a man right off but he pokes at me anyway, I don’t have to say shit else than what I feel like.”

Jimmy knew he was right. It’d been years, and the way Hawkstellar wore them on his skin was punishment enough, the boy with injury in his eyes, glossy from whatever time he’d done.

“I apologize. I still see you as the kid who had a problem with my daughter.”

He waited for Hawkstellar’s reaction, remembering the boy at eleven kicking a soccer ball at Ann Morrison Park. The boy had innocence in his eyes back then. Like all kids in summer, probably wanted ice cream every night, that’s it. Jimmy’s daughter’s team waiting to practice, the sun a twenty-seven-million-degree ball of wax above the field. The freshly cut grass smelling strong. By middle school, most of the kids in the North End had started drinking, by high school a quarter took opioids and weed, then amphetamines for their SATs. What had happened to the hundreds of other kids Jimmy’s own children had matured alongside, everybody scattered now?

“I hoped you’d forgotten about who I was back then. High school’s almost eight years ago.”

“I’m cursed with a long memory,” Jimmy admitted. “You’ve had a hard run?”

“The hardest. I saw a reel on Instagram about life expectancy at most is two rolls of pennies with fifty apiece being years. For felons, you cut that in half. One roll of pennies ain’t shit, I guess.”

“How many of those have you done inside, if I may ask?”

Hawkstellar scratched again at his ankle monitor then said, “Four years total, but it was three different stints. I guess in your day that’d be a three-strike life sentence.”

“Those were harsher times.”

“I doubt it. In this climate, they’d put me and your daughter away in the same breath, just for being what God made us. It’s being different that gets you time. In my case, I guess it’s bipolar or some shit. Manic this or that. You put a chocolate cake in front of me, I’ll eat half in ten minutes then throw the other half at a

mirror. I might be a little crazy, but there's good odds that part of my brain ain't on me alone."

Maybe Hawkstellar had been made wiser by prison. How many hours had he clocked standing on the porridge line in the desert south of Boise at the State Correctional compound? The area illuminated like a stadium at night, nothing but sagebrush and dark black emptiness beyond the halogen risers. Sometimes the roar of A-10 Thunderbolt jets on practice sets from the Air National Guard broke up the midnight skies, but that was it.

"Anyway, it's a surprise to see you on the res," Hawkstellar added, eyes mirroring Jimmy in a glint from the overhead lights.

"I'm working a car theft," Jimmy said. "I guess we're both surprised. Aren't you paroling far from home?"

"It was my mother's idea for me to learn the family business from a legitimate angle, given my penchant for *illegitimate* ones. She says the Californians and Texans moving to Boise make even Christians go back to prison just for the peace and quiet. I'm better off on the res, according to her."

"You're Native?" Jimmy was confused—the boy looked like he showered in bleach. And Grisham Greasley had a terrible record with Idaho's Indigenous people, so a Native-born Evelyn Hawkstellar as his Press Secretary should have been controversial.

"My mom is half Shoshone. That's a state secret." When he paused, Jimmy saw scarring at his orbital sockets where he'd taken beatings. "I'm off in ten, so I'd better scoot—but it was *interesting* to see a face from before. I guess you never know who people become."

"That's an honest way of saying it," Jimmy said.

Hawkstellar pushed his cart away. To either side was a nickel-slot machine with a Gates of Hell motif—the two machines framed Brody Hawkstellar as he leaned forward to dump another ashtray. Stood again, animated flames flanking him across the industrial plastic.

The tall, pale-skinned boy with bones poking from his collar appeared as if donning a cape of fire. The hair on Jimmy's neck stood up.

TWO

Jimmy stepped out of the casino at midday, the sky heavy with storm clouds. A plume of smoke was rising from the foothills outside of Blackfoot, maybe ten miles across the high desert scrub. The effluvium was hot and black, like from an oil fire. It widened beneath a cumulus shelf.

He crossed the parking lot to his vehicle, shut himself inside, and called the Blackfoot Fire Department via 911, reporting to a young woman in their dispatch unit what appeared to be either a simple illegal burn or the beginnings of the next accidental scorch of twenty-thousand acres.

The gunmetal clouds through the truck's tinted windows looked certain to bring lasting showers, the first in a month. It'd been fire season all summer long and rain would be appreciated.

"It's either a pile of tires or somebody's rig got torched," Jimmy speculated to the dispatcher.

"Can I get a callback number?"

Due to the nature of his work, Jimmy's caller ID had been set to block.

"My apologies," he told her. "I'm a PI out here working a car theft." It was good to alert dispatch to his presence while doing cases in rural areas, as the Ada County plates on his truck made him an outsider—sometimes property owners sent dogs after him without warning, then the police. He provided his callback, then set his phone on the dash.

He had over an hour to spare before meeting with Flores, the rebuilder of the Impala. All Jimmy'd need from him was the value of the parts, allegedly sourced from original models and repurposed into Greasley's daughter's rebuild. There were only a couple dozen originals of this particular '61 Impala, an SS convertible, so fifty years later the hubcaps alone could be worth a thousand apiece. According to insurance documents, even the

screws holding the dash together were inherited from original models. Jimmy would request receipts from Flores, an apparently meticulous craftsman who'd have kept and stored them if the rebuild was legitimate. Without those receipts, the insurance company would contest the \$250,000 claim.

He rested his eyes a few moments. When Jimmy opened them again, he noticed an unmarked long haul semi-truck, a fifty-footer, parked behind the casino with Brody Hawkstellar closing the rear gate like he'd inspected a load.

Hawkstellar jogged to the passenger side of the cab and pulled himself in. Then the semi did a wide-slung, slow U-turn behind the casino, exited past the tinted windows of Jimmy's snow-white Ford F-150 pickup truck. Hawkstellar and the semi's Hispanic driver, ballcap pulled tightly and shielding his eyes, looked as serious as a Seal team.

Jimmy wrote down the plate number to the semi, guessing that Brody Hawkstellar was in the shit. Then he closed his eyes again and dozed for forty minutes, the tinted windows like a blanket he'd grown accustomed to wrapping-around his body through the long years of pretending to be something he wasn't. He had no dreams, in half-sleep felt the presence of cars rolling quietly past him in the parking lot, woke fully with a start as if he'd caught himself tripping over a curb. The clouds seemed hulking, almost gelatinous as they rolled westward.

He put the truck into gear and was halfway to Tio Flores' property when he got a call back on his cell from an arson inspector named Sandy Billings with the Blackfoot Fire Department. Billings had been Jimmy's contact on a few residential fires over the years, the insurance companies requesting Jimmy get final inspection reports from Billings before processing a homeowner's claim. He'd never met Billings in person, only spoken to him over the cell a half-dozen times. The man's vocal cords sounded like a slab of fish skin charring in the smoke.

"That stolen car you're looking for happen to be a '61 Impala owned by the Greasley family?" Billings asked, coughed into the

phone. "If so, we caught one just like her playing with matches. The fire you reported? She's it. Sweet little rack, if you don't mind your meat blackened."

"You're confusing me," Jimmy said. "The vehicle I'm after was stolen from California."

"Well, she came home. Just follow the smoke, Chinden."

"I don't understand..."

"City boys often don't." The man hung up on him.

Fifteen minutes later, Jimmy pulled his truck to a stop a mile into the scrub beside a dry, pebbled creek rimmed with sage. Sandy Billings, two Blackfoot police personnel, and a three-man crew from the Blackfoot Fire Department loitered around their vehicles while the Impala sizzled along the creek bed like charred fish skin.

Sandy Billings wore reflective aviator glasses and an open-collared shirt that revealed a burn scar dominating the contours of his neck with misshapen ridges of skin like a topographical map. Jimmy stole a second glance as the man approached while rolling his shirtsleeves. The scar was eerily similar in size and shape to the five-fingered grip of a man-sized hand around his throat, causing Billings to appear choked at the neck by his own discolored flesh.

They shook, and Billings said, "Nice to meet you in person. Looks like they drowned the darling in gasoline. After dispatch told me you called, I came out here and first thing we did was call Tio Flores. There's only one guy in eastern Idaho who builds classics like this, so we didn't have to think hard. Flores sounded as confused as you."

"That's a \$250,000 car," Jimmy told him. The white-walled tires looked like molten globs of marshmallow and black molasses. The windows had exploded outward.

"Maybe yesterday," Billings said.

The air smelled seared and thick, floral with burnt gasoline.

The clouds above them were almost black. Jimmy wondered why anybody would do a torch job with a storm coming—there was no logic in that. The vehicle, like most luxury or rare automobiles

stolen from the West Coast, should have been making its way to the Middle East in a shipping container out of Long Beach.

What was it doing back home, in Blackfoot?

“I’d like to pop the trunk,” Jimmy told him.

“Let’s hold hands, do it together while it blows us to kingdom come,” Billings scoffed. “Christ, Chinden, the keys are in the ignition but Bomb Squad’s on the way before we can touch her. Least if we wanna’ keep enjoying the comforts of this world from the side people walk on.”

Billings had pronounced “Bomb Squad” with an almost Cajun dialect, vowel-heavy and liquid. The sky was getting darker by the second, clotted like cottage cheese.

Jimmy retrieved his surveillance camera from the F-150, began videotaping the damage to the Impala, trying to beat the rain. Billings must have seen some bad action, from the look of his scar, maybe in the Gulf circa 1991, which would fit his age. He might have been stomping-around Iraq in his late twenties with fireworks in the sky, American television cameras broadcasting the carnage twenty-four hours a day. Made sense for him to be jumpy about popping the Impala’s latch.

Would Jimmy’s own son come back with a turkey neck squeezed by fire? Jimmy pushed the thought from his mind, along with the many other darker ones he disassociated from every day just to get through the job.

He took five minutes of interior and exterior video then used his iPhone to snap over a hundred still photos in a grid pattern beginning at the Impala’s rear, moved up the quarter-panels on the driver’s side and continued clockwise around the vehicle. He would photograph the engine compartment once Bomb Squad arrived and postpone his meeting with Tio Flores until the next day. Tonight, he’d stay at a hotel in nearby Pocatello and catalogue his footage.

The Impala might prove to be worth its insured value once the hood was popped but sometimes a classic car rebuild looking beautiful on the outside turned out to be, in parlance Jimmy’s

daughter would rightly scold him for, “just a nice piece of ass with no heart.”

Jimmy’s report would cover the original theft claim filed by Greasley’s daughter and now the arson investigation. The insurance company would need a chronicle of all damage to the Impala, and Jimmy would still grab the rebuild receipts. Now that the vehicle was no longer missing, it’d be easy enough to compare Flores’ accounting to the actual parts—whatever was identifiable after the fire. If the receipts didn’t add up, Greasley’s daughter would be flagged for insurance fraud, falsifying the value of her loss. Worse, she might face charges for falsifying the Impala’s theft in its entirety, if it shook that way.

Jimmy had seen the charred engine key jammed into the ignition, two others hanging beside it like mismatched earrings. One of the keys was an oddball, short-bladed, a stocky red knob for heavy torquing—obviously a locker key; he had run his fingers along rows of them as a kid. The other was for the trunk.

He looked toward the sound of tires on dirt and saw what he assumed was Blackfoot’s Bomb Squad arriving, a lone female officer in black ballcap, driving a white F-150 like Jimmy’s, dust shooting from tires so new Jimmy could see their tread from thirty feet away.

The driver parked her rig and stepped out. She wore a Glock sidearm and tactical boots. Was dark-skinned, maybe Shoshone. Mid-thirties with jet-black hair under her cap. A stride that told Jimmy she could handle herself.

Billings lit a menthol cigarette and took a quick drag. Blew the smoke as she approached.

“Ayita Smith, meet Jimmy Chinden—insurance guy,” Billings said, winking at her. “Known him by telephone but never in person. A tall motherfucker until he blows the lower half of his body apart. I told him we had to wait for your arrival.”

“Because you told him I was Bomb Squad, I’m guessing?”

“Nope.”

“That’s not entirely true,” Jimmy interjected. When he shook Ayita Smith’s hand it felt warm. Her blue-green eyes looked like

polished turquoise, almost incandescent with the overhead clouds blacking out everything else.

He felt embarrassed by his attraction to a colleague. Noticed the ring finger of her left hand absent a wedding band. Things were going in slow motion for him now, the first time in years he'd felt dizzyed by a woman.

And thank God she was no longer making eye contact with him.

She scrutinized the Impala from a distance, walked toward the burn spot while pulling on latex gloves, Jimmy and Billings trailing behind. She leaned into the vehicle and took the keys from the Impala's ignition then returned to the scorched trunk, saying to Jimmy, "I think you're being made an example of Mr. Chinden."

The three of them stood by the Impala's trunk now.

Billings lifted one of his legs then ground the three-quarters-unsmoked cigarette into the sole of his boot, snickered under his breath like he'd told himself a slightly raunchy joke. He tucked the mentholated butt into his shirt pocket.

Ayita Smith studied the three keys in her hand on the simple keyring and said to Jimmy, "For starters, nobody likes being called an insurance guy, am I right?"

"In the wrong company, it can have distasteful connotations," Jimmy agreed. Billings puckered his lips like sucking on a lollipop, like he knew something Jimmy never could, country boys cherishing what they considered their special knowledge of "the real world," even with the empty land out there shrinking on them.

"So, I think that was Sandy's way of telling you, Mr. Chinden, to eat shit," she continued.

Jimmy watched her unloop the mismatched key from the keyring.

Then she added, "You probably have not deserved the arrogance of Mr. Billings, much in the way you haven't deserved to believe that I have unusual experience with explosives."

Billings took the cigarette back from his shirt pocket and compulsively lit it again. The hot coal of it seemed like a "fuck you" to Jimmy and Ayita Smith both, and to maybe the whole

world. Billings' teeth looked dark as an oil rag when he bit down on the butt, grinning.

Jimmy smelled the menthol drift with the moisture in the air.

Ayita Smith said to Jimmy, "I'm a detective, and I'm not much else. Although Sandy here likes to call me his 'bomb' squaw—as if to say I'm a hot Indian, never mind that language being neither tasteful nor legal in any workplace."

Ayita Smith paused for a second and examined the Impala's burn perimeter. She looked upward at the clouds ready to dump rain within the minute. Jimmy thought he saw a quick flash of light across her cheekbone. On a bluff two hundred yards away, there might have been a piece of glass catching whatever remained of daylight and refracting it toward them. He imagined his son behind a sniper's scope seven thousand miles across the sea—wanted to wave to the boy.

Ayita looked back at Jimmy as if Billings were no longer present, said to him, "Sandy has often told me he can't decide whether he likes the hot part of me or the Native part more. What do you think about that, Mr. Chinden?"

Jimmy told her, "I think a man who speaks like that shouldn't be around women for a living."

He looked at Billings now and couldn't refrain from sizing the man up. Maybe five foot ten, fifty-eight years old, half burned. Jimmy could see himself in the man's sunglasses. Wondered if Billings carried a gun on his person and where it was concealed, if so.

Billings grinned through his oiled teeth, stepped forward and tapped Jimmy on the sternum with a broad-knuckled forefinger, saying, "I misjudged your sense of humor, Chinden. I was only fucking with you. There is not a Bomb Squad needed for a simple automobile fire. Do you accept my apology?"

Jimmy had a visceral reaction to Billings touching him. Felt heat rising to his face the way a fever spikes. Intuited that an ancient poison lay dormant beneath the skin of Sandy Billings, as one intuits his own murder before it occurs or the way wild beasts abandon their landscapes in the hour before natural disaster. He

stepped backward, and in that motion first-noticed Billings' tattoos that peeked from beneath the biceps-rolled shirtsleeves on each arm—bulging with his muscles were the talons of matching Nazi swastikas with inferior, prison-style ink.

Out of distaste for the images, Jimmy instinctively turned away.

That's when he saw Ayita Smith drop the key with the bulky red knob into an evidence Ziploc. The number "189" was etched into its plastic grip. She folded the baggie and stuffed it into the rear pocket of her jeans, just behind the hip where her Glock was holstered.

She inserted another key into the Impala's trunk.

The lid popped open and Jimmy stepped forward.

Inside the rectangular hollow of the trunk was the twisted corpse of a man Jimmy recognized. His wrists and legs were bound by bloodied ligatures. His body was folded into the shape of a seahorse. Eyes bloodshot, frozen in fruitless stare.

The man was Rudolph Hillcrest, a hard money lender, what people called a loan shark but for the mortgage industry. He was infamous in Boise for his lack of scruples. A man Jimmy'd himself often wished dead. Maybe even wished him dead right now, looking at him dead already.

Hot blood still leaked from the back of Hillcrest's head as freshly as new paint pouring from a tipped-over can.

Jimmy felt dizzy.

A low-lying breeze, having gathered itself from a half mile away, briefly swept at his pant legs. Orange-colored dust grazed the tips of Jimmy's black 5.11-branded tactical shoes.

He leaned over briefly. Held onto his knees to steady himself.

Thought he smelled his mother's perfume on the air, sweet like the minutes before rain.

THREE

The rain came en route to Pocatello, a short drive away. Jimmy gripped the steering wheel like a tank gunner as the storm swept over his windshield.

The idea of Rudolph Hillcrest had felt like a too-heavy chain around his neck for twenty-seven years. The man a scumbag who'd stolen Jimmy's childhood home—a motel in Garden City, on the cheating side of Boise—after the murder of Jimmy's mother in the 1990s. Jimmy had put up a brief fight but was too young to compete with Hillcrest. “Radar,” they'd called the man in Boise's business circles, because of his uncanny ability to hone-in on the desperate.

The insult wasn't only that Hillcrest had swindled Jimmy but shaken Jimmy's hand while doing it. Jimmy spending almost three decades wishing he'd broken the man's wrist in that moment, cracked it into fucking pieces.

It was hard to deny that Hillcrest had a well-deserved bullseye on his back after destroying the fortunes of dozens of would-be real estate developers. His model of lending newcomers millions in hard money at rates the market couldn't justify, then stealing back their developments after a few initial months of missed payments, wasn't illegal but was dirty, the cold-blooded kind.

Jimmy's mother was no developer but wasn't free of the original note on her motel, the only thing of monetary value remaining in her life. She had paid off \$225,000 of the initial \$275,000 borrowed from another lender when Hillcrest Financial assumed the remaining \$50,000 debt in a backroom deal only six months before laying claim to the property. Then the market jammed his mother up with vacancies, Hillcrest raised her rates, and things spiraled.

Even if Jimmy didn't like the brutality of murder, he'd never lost sleep over bad guys like Hillcrest showing up as a corpse. But

this was the first time one'd been delivered right into Jimmy's arms. His problem now was making sense of it.

Ayita Smith took possession of the Impala, Blackfoot impound loading the vehicle onto a flatbed to beat the rain. She'd ordered both Jimmy and Sandy Billings from the scene. The theft and arson investigations were now trumped by a homicide case.

Jimmy would get the documents from Tio Flores tomorrow. Even if the receipts matched the Impala's parts, the insurance company would now use Hillcrest's murder to delay their payment on the claim, citing need for a parallel investigation. Greasley's daughter would be up shit's creek if she needed her payout anytime soon.

Jimmy checked into the Clarion hotel off the highway in Pocatello. Requested a second-floor room with two beds—he'd never liked how king-sized mattresses felt in the lonely hotels spanning his career, making his isolation more obvious. He locked himself inside the room and briefly watched through the sliding windows as rainwater cascaded over the glowing signage of an Applebee's on the other side of the elongated parking lot. Closed the shades and took off his shoes, sat on the bed nearest the windows and read the Impala's inventory list on his laptop. Couldn't focus. Kept seeing Hillcrest's brain matter splattered against the rear wall of the Impala's trunk.

A saltwater sting rose from Jimmy's throat. It tasted like mortality. We were all just bodies, he thought, born into the world with hearts the size of an apricot and the rumor of souls. Jimmy's children no different. The standard journey of living was to have a very limited set of "experiences" then depart with few traces left behind, existence a mere game whose rules maybe nobody knew until it ended.

The digital clock on his nightstand said 5:32 p.m., which meant 7:32 p.m. in New York. Jimmy wondered where his daughter was, if she'd eaten dinner, who kept her company as she explored the city. What the lighting was like in the coffee shop they might have found themselves in. What his daughter *felt* sitting there staring into somebody's face.

She'd had a girlfriend in college, a well-mannered mathematics major whom Jimmy had liked for a would-be daughter-in-law. But since graduating they'd pursued other lives. Jimmy's daughter overcome by a social activism transcending her desire for romance, she'd claimed, even if Jimmy suspected each of us sought our twin, no matter the world unraveling.

Jimmy's eyes grew heavy. He slept for twenty minutes, awakened suddenly to the rain slashing at the windows of his hotel room. His heart was racing, his reptilian brain having alerted in dream—Radar Hillcrest, Brody Hawkstellar, and Sandy Billings sat on bar stools around an examination table of polished sheet metal. Greasley's daughter was faceless, slicing into the body of an apple pie she'd served on delicate plates made from the small tombstones of birds.

Now Jimmy reflected on the friction points in what'd begun as a simple car theft case. Only Tio Flores' involvement seemed innocuous, a procedural point of contact—get the receipts and get out had been the original plan of action.

Jimmy stood for ten minutes under a hot shower and resurfaced with an impulse to run a background on Flores. Sat on the bed in his towel and entered what he knew into his laptop. The claim docs provided Flores' date of birth and home address, enough to access Flores' social security number through the TransUnion database, where Jimmy ran Flores for assets, liens, and judgments.

In addition to his large acreage in Blackfoot, Flores appeared to own several semi-trucks equal in size and style to what Jimmy had seen Brody Hawkstellar driving away from the casino in. Jimmy also found a series of odd civil judgments against Flores—from 2007 to 2012, he'd been sued thirteen times for nonpayment to building supply companies, and he'd defaulted on a 2017 debt surpassing \$185,000 owed to an entity listed as Home Finance Corporation, which Jimmy found to be a rural mortgage arm of Hillcrest Financial. Tio Flores, it appeared, was almost \$350,000 in arrears, over a third of that money owed to Radar Hillcrest. Tack on interest, Jimmy thought, then all the stress that comes with it.

Based on the loan holders and years associated with the judgments landing squarely in the thick of the sub-prime mortgage scandal that had crashed the economy, Flores appeared to have built a home or two on speculation then been unable to offload them when the real estate market collapsed. Jimmy had seen this before from a dozen builders who'd lost their shirts. The lumber and supply companies chasing them down first, then a skyrocketing credit card debt applied toward subcontracting bills, and finally the mortgage holders pinning the owners to a cross.

Things were different now. Housing in the state was booming again and hedge fund marauders from the coastlines were shaking all the apple trees, buying everything that fell to the ground. Billionaires were carting Idaho investment properties into their portfolios by the bushel, catapulting valuations. Jimmy's children might never afford a home, if prices kept climbing.

It was nearing dusk when Jimmy put on a hooded sweatshirt and stepped out for a late dinner, jogging from the hotel's parking lot across a manicured patch of grass to the Applebee's.

Hurrying inside, he slapped the rain from his hoodie. Took a seat at the bar. Ordered barbecued wings and a soda water. He was wiping the sauce from his fingertips with a heavy napkin when Ayita Smith came through the front doors wearing black yoga pants and a turquoise, water-resistant runners' jacket that matched her eyes. She carried a black tote bag over her shoulder, hair pulled into a knot at the back of her head, her face wet with rain. She waved off the hostess and approached Jimmy at the bar.

"Would you like company, Mr. Chinden?"

His heartbeat quickened. "I would."

She sat down beside him. Ordered a vegetarian burger and light beer. Jimmy pushed his plate of chicken bones aside, nursed his soda water as an old Bob Seger song, "Roll Me Away," played through inset speakers above the bar. He caught the fragrance of Ayita's dampened skin, sage and sweat efflorescent from her neck.

"Forgive my appearance," she told him, gesturing at her yoga pants. "I spent the better part of today with the medical examiner then needed to unwind. I hope showing up here like this wasn't too

presumptuous. I noticed your Ada County plates at the hotel when I was driving by, so I parked my truck beside yours. If I don't get too drunk, I'll remember which one is which."

She breathed deeply, exhaled. Sipped from her glass of beer before adding, "We don't get a lot of murders to begin with, so this one was certainly special. There was flesh torn from the roof of the victim's mouth, consistent with a handgun forced into his throat. We removed a pair of .45 slugs from the rear seat cushions, but no casings were left behind."

"He was shot twice?" Jimmy asked.

"It defies logic, I know. You shove a .45 down the hole, fire once and there's brain matter spraying out already. What's twice, a photo opportunity? The last murder I had was a knife wound. Nothing to know, except the deep ones can kill you and the shallow ones usually don't."

"Any prints left behind?" Jimmy asked.

"I've said more than I'm allowed. Ask me something personal instead," she told him. "I don't usually have conversation with my dinner. It's nice."

"Okay," Jimmy chanced. "You aren't wearing a wedding band, so there must be a story in how you came to receive your Christian surname."

"Right to the point," she said, smiling. Her turquoise eyes looked electric. "My grandmother was Cherokee. I guess you could say my grandfather raped her and put a ring on her finger. Hence what you call my 'surname.'"

"My apologies for the lazy question," Jimmy said. He hadn't thought that through. Ayita Smith's ancestral story was similar to the half-million original Africans abducted to this country with descendants named Johnson now.

"Don't apologize."

She surveyed his face. She'd no doubt developed a knack for spotting signs of deception on the job. Was measuring how much to humor Jimmy's poorly concealed advances, maybe.

"I think your intention was probably a simple inquiry into my marital status, since I confided that I usually eat alone," she

finally said. "You saw that I wear no ring. It was natural to wonder if there's a white ex-husband named Smith running-around with a square jaw and vendetta. That's the investigator in you, which I recognize."

He felt embarrassed. She was right in her assessment, the faint creases to the sides of her eyes tightening when she smiled directly at him now, her retinas radiant.

"You've caught me off guard," he told her. "A long time ago, it was me with the square jaw and vendetta, I guess. A bad marriage brought out bad things in me. I'm cautious because I know how it goes down." As a roll of the dice, he confessed, "I haven't been with a woman in years."

"Neither have I," Ayita told him. She laughed reflexively, a timbre to her voice like drizzled honey, wavy and sweet.

Ayita took a twenty-dollar bill from her tote bag, set the money on the bar.

Then she turned to Jimmy and said, "It's okay to be forward with me. I do police work for a living, so I'm good at figuring out what men are thinking, whether they want me to or not. That's probably why I've never been married, but it's also why I trust you, Jimmy."

They left the Applebee's together, crossed the parking lot with shoulders flexing against the rain, walked up the hotel stairs—all in a silence that seemed fitting of long-acquainted lovers, not two investigators wrapped into a murder case together. When Jimmy opened the door to his motel room, she quickly tapped a forefinger against his shoulder, as if checking for heat, careful not to burn herself brushing past him.

She crossed the threshold, saying, "I don't want to make love, or even kiss, if I'm honest. I just wanted the company, if that's okay."

"It is," Jimmy said thankful for the release valve on the psychological pressure often accompanying unexpected intimacy. At the end of the day, Jimmy'd only wanted the company, too, caring less over the years about sexual conquest than intimate connection.

She checked to make sure the bathroom and a small closet were empty—Jimmy’s habit, too—then returned and cut the lights by the door. Slipped off her wet shoes and jacket, same as Jimmy. They crossed to the bed nearest the window.

Jimmy watched her nervously. The light from outside fell in the shape of dappled raindrops onto her skin. Like something out of a movie, Jimmy thought. Haunted and beautiful at the same time. Maybe that’s what a good woman did to a man—made him feel there were ghosts in a room but the kind you held onto instead of wishing they’d leave.

Ayita laid down with her head heavy against the pillow and added, “Can we lie here like this or would that be weird?”

Jimmy didn’t answer. Lay beside her, hoped his actions would replace the need for words he felt too stupid to find. Ayita’s body felt warm in his arms, the downpour outside reverberating through the room. They were fully clothed, entwined atop the forty-dollar comforter. It made Jimmy think of the way teenagers pressed themselves to each other sideways on green lawns in the years right before knowing sex. Calmed him.

Beside Ayita’s body, Jimmy felt he had come home.

Eventually, the heaviness of their breathing settled. The rain eased. After a while, Ayita said, “I can’t see you well.” She contorted her body, flipped-on the brassy nightstand light then turned back to Jimmy, adding, “What do we do now, compare bullet scars?”

“Maybe let’s talk about your homicide,” he said, still coming to grips with Hillcrest reemerging as a carcass after all these years.

“That sounds like you have a devious plan for me,” she laughed.

He suddenly imagined her absence from the world—although they’d just met that day, he wanted her to live for a very long time.

“You’ll want case updates for your own investigation,” she added. “I get that, and I wish I could tell you more. But protocol doesn’t allow me to speak to any of it yet. For what it’s worth, I’d like to tell you everything I know, once I’m allowed—although maybe not in bed.”

She slipped her hand around Jimmy's back and pulled herself closer to him, pressed herself against him hard. Jimmy could feel the full-body warmth again, no creases between them. She lingered momentarily, then suddenly inspired jumped from the bed.

"I'm not leaving, but there's a very old joint in my truck, and I wouldn't mind smoking it!"

"I won't turn you in."

"Or over?" she teased.

"No promises," he smiled, watched her pull her damp jacket over breasts that filled her yoga tank. Then he added before she could zip up, "What I wanted to say about your homicide, you don't have to speak to. But you should know I ran a financial on Tio Flores, the Impala's builder, before dinner. He's got judgments back to 2007, over three-hundred and fifty grand, a hundred and eighty-five to your vic."

"That's good information," she said. "But I grew up here, and I can tell you that Tio Flores doesn't need to murder a guy over a hundred and eighty-five grand. His property is worth several million. All he'd have to do is split a few acres and dump it for California money to dig himself out."

She was right. The West Coast was starting to look like a proving ground for Armageddon, the whole place on fire and more millionaires than anyone could count arriving almost daily in East Idaho to buy land they could drop a prefab and generator onto for "backup property."

"But I don't imagine Hillcrest was killed over a business decision," Ayita added. "Based on the ligatures, this was a personal issue. Besides, 2007 was a century ago in real estate time. Most of that debt's likely been written off."

"Shame has a long memory," Jimmy said.

"Well, don't make me ashamed to jump your bones if I decide to before morning." She pulled on her athletic shoes and added, "Be back with that joint. You want to smoke with me?"

"In another life," he said. Wished he could indulge. Knew himself better than that. One hit or drink, didn't matter from

what, and a month down the chute Jimmy'd be staring at himself in a motel mirror with eyes the color of Maraschino cherries in syrup, wondering his own name.

She took the key card from atop the polished bureau and started to leave but turned back.

"There's something about you," she said. "To look at you, the cut of your jib is a cop's, but most cops only learn to love two things, getting home without catching an infection from one of the junkies, then getting back to work by morning. You're different. You'd rather hold me. You make me feel safe, and I didn't even know I didn't before."

"I'm not a cop anymore."

"You're not a lot of things, I think. I like that about you."

She slipped out. The door shut with a metallic click.

Jimmy stood from the bed and walked to the plate glass window, drew the curtains to each side and watched Ayita exit the building. The rain had stopped completely now, the pavement black and shiny as petroleum.

She crossed the parking lot toward their vehicles thirty yards out, each of the F-150s backed up to the grassy median that ran between the hotel and the Applebee's.

Jimmy watched her with a longing tinged by familiarity, like finding new affection for a girl he'd known since childhood.

Maybe she was feeling the same thing, he hoped. Ayita had wrapped herself against his body before leaving the bed, held onto Jimmy but to something else, too—some memory of her past haunting her, maybe, causing her to love feverishly and pull away at the same time.

Jimmy could understand that. Love, as he'd experienced it, was sometimes terrifying.

He pressed his forehead against the window and watched Ayita approach his vehicle accidentally, the closest to her path, their two white pickup trucks looking similar under the parking lot's dim overhead lighting. She stopped short and looked up at Jimmy.

He shrugged, and for some reason waved at Ayita with one swipe of his hand from left to right. Ayita smiled and mimicked his

gesture in a wide arc, like a woman lost at sea alerting a ship to her presence. Jimmy felt the same way, didn't know which of them was rescuing the other.

She met Jimmy's eyes a beat longer. Then she pivoted and walked around the front of his vehicle, cutting toward her own.

The cloth reflectors on her athletic shoes shimmered in the darkness. Ayita reached out her arm, squeezing the key fob in her hand.

There was a wide and tall burst of light, the way a planet combusts in a movie.

The roar of Ayita's vehicle exploding shook the plate glass window Jimmy stood behind, and the Applebee's emblem looked like a molten fruit suspended just above and beyond the flames.

FOUR

Jimmy Chinden hadn't always been Jimmy Chinden.

As an infant, he'd been abandoned in the well-heated lobby of a small motel on Chinden Boulevard, back then a tract of massage parlors, auto repair shops, and fenced-off towing lots just west of Boise proper. As Jimmy was told, the motel owner had returned from her bathroom break to discover Jimmy swaddled inside a milk crate on the mud-stained, carpeted floor, a note that read "James" Scotch-taped to his diaper.

When the woman picked him up, she noticed Jimmy weighed around ten pounds, had all of his digits, and was properly proportioned to become a reliable man. For reasons she hadn't yet understood, she locked the motel lobby and cradled Jimmy in her arms all night, fed him whole milk from a coffee spoon when he cried for a breast, hoped to God she'd be the only woman Jimmy ever thought of as his mother in this life.

She had assumed Jimmy'd been dumped by one of the many sex workers frequenting her rooms, so "Chinden" as a surname fit nicely. Although she never legally adopted him, she found Jimmy a Social Security number on the black market, raised him as her own—Jimmy knew no other home besides the motel, watched cartoons within a fog of cigarette smoke in the back office until he was five, was thereafter enrolled in what was then the low-income Garden City school district.

By age eleven, Jimmy was helping his mother run a blackmail grift, videotaping the men she referred to as "weekend warriors," well-dressed and arriving with women of the trade. He wore black and hunched in the shadows across the street on Saturday nights, an RCA camera big as a telephone book on his shoulder, the VHS tape inside it humming like a cash machine as he filmed the cars that rolled up the curb cut and bounced toward street-level rooms with red doors smudged by the fingerprints of husbands and

business executives, pederasts, perverts, and drunks—all of them lonely-seeming.

Jimmy wrote down the plate numbers of the cars, crept in the shadows behind the motel to film through creases in the polyester curtains, whenever his mom would ask. During the week, his mom would run a man's license plate through a friend at the DMV, obtain an address and cross-reference it for marital status. She'd send Jimmy on his bicycle in the pre-dawn hours to discreetly seek out the man's automobile at home or workplace, deposit a tidy envelope containing a note and small lockbox key beneath the man's wiper blades—in a handful of polite words, the note succinctly explained each man's predicament, kindly requesting that one thousand dollars, a manageable figure, be exchanged for the VHS tape via locker at the Greyhound station downtown.

The scam never led back to Jimmy's mom. The angle of footage was from across the street or behind the rooms, so to his mother's stooges the blackmailer could have been anybody. Letter-sized envelopes of twenties and fifties arrived regularly, tucked into their Greyhound lock box, its key left behind with the station attendant by each new mark, each knowing better than to simply take the VHS tape and run. They'd be too worried about copies, regardless of Jimmy's mother falsely assuring them otherwise.

The station attendant, an elderly woman, received a reasonable percentage on the back end. The two women worked well together and with purpose. As Jimmy got older, he began to suspect they were driven by more than money, although he never asked because it seemed to him that his mother had secrets from a time and place too painful for her to explore.

As a teenager, Jimmy resided in one of the motel rooms by himself, continued the grift and made very few friends, due primarily to the nature of his accommodations. Sometimes succumbed to the lapses in judgment that accompanied a growing boy living in a house of prostitution. His first sexual experiences were managed by street walkers, young women not much older than he, who taught him how to touch, talked at length about

their often-horrific upbringings, made love slowly and deliberately while looking into Jimmy's eyes.

On more than one occasion, Jimmy'd been thinking about their johns when he'd climaxed, wondering why some repulsed him with their gelatinous midriffs and others seemed pretty, the way he thought of women. Still thought that way about men, nearly each disgusting in the nude but a very few almost graceful in the way he thought God might've intended, when men wore animal hides and chased their supper through the forests. Queerly to himself, he often acknowledged this general distaste for the awkward male fuselage, questioning isolated incidences of stubborn attraction that sometimes spooked him into prayer but more often simply brushed past his consciousness like wind on the skin.

When he was seventeen, the summer after graduating from high school, Jimmy's mother handed him a paper grocery bag with \$75,000 in it, told him she'd enrolled him at Michigan State University, pressed the keys to a 1981 Mercury Grand Marquis into his hand.

"I didn't even take the SAT test," Jimmy said, confused. He'd been a poor student, barely graduated, no plans for his future. "And thank you for the car, but where the heck is Michigan State University?"

"That's where you go when the school Provost makes a guest appearance in our cache of tapes," she told him. "I need you to get a safe deposit box and take out your tuition three times a year. You'll have plenty left for living."

She hugged him hard, crying into his shoulder when she said, "I love you," and Jimmy felt her trembling. For the first time, he noticed that his mother was only half his size, her hair now like cotton candy, her thrift store cashmere sweater hanging loosely across thinning collar bones. *How old is she*, he wondered.

At Michigan State University, he studied criminal justice, the only subject Jimmy had any experience with. On more than one occasion during his years away, he felt an unresolved tension between himself and other male students—his romantic crushes remained on young women, although Jimmy was learning

something about the nature of sexuality that unsettled him, prompting long hours in the gym.

On one occasion only, at The Peanut Barrell after drinking a four-dollar pitcher of beer in thirty minutes, Jimmy tempted fate by placing his fingertips on the wrist of a fraternity pledge slugging water beside him at the bar, a gesture that ended poorly for both when the young man, with a fist like a cinder block, broke Jimmy's nose, and in return Jimmy broke the young man's jaw. Afterward, Jimmy found himself looking out the window from the back of a police car as it drove up Grand River Avenue toward the precinct to book him on charges of disturbing the peace. Outside, Jimmy observed the gaggles of co-eds roaming the sidewalks, and in the alley behind a restaurant called Beggar's Banquet a young woman in an Alpha Chi Omega sorority sweatshirt forced her hand down the chinos of a well-known athlete Jimmy later saw on the cover of *Sports Illustrated*. They were straddling a puddle with their eyes closed, pretending the world didn't exist.

The police car jostled over potholes as Jimmy closed his eyes too and felt the only way to get through a life architected for what people now called "heteronormative" behavior would be to sacrifice the parts of himself that didn't fit. Life was *about* this sacrifice, Jimmy'd decided—conscientious people had always annulled their quirks in service to a greater purpose, standardizing the world, and their wants with it, for the comfort of the majority, internalizing what police work externalized: Law enforcement, Jimmy'd learned in class, was moral housekeeping. What the Christians in his dormitory sometimes called "keeping the floors polished," in case God visits.

The summer after graduation, Jimmy was tooling around Lake Michigan, car camping out of his Mercury and smoking cigarettes, when he tried calling his mother from a payphone and learned of her murder—she'd been raped in the back room of the motel lobby, shot in each eye with a .22 pistol. Jimmy knew that his mother's murder had been recompense for their blackmail gift.

Felt it in his gut.

To this day, as an oath of loyalty to the woman who'd given her life for his, Jimmy'd not gone looking for his birth mother, easy as it would've been. He chose to remain grounded solely in that few-mile stretch where the motel had existed and his childhood memories formed, regardless of the dulling anonymity he sometimes felt from having no sense of heredity—in the twenty-seven years since his mother's homicide, Jimmy's ignorance of a deeper family lineage was accompanied by an almost biological familiarity with the criminal underworld. The majority of convicts "had no people," as was said, because of this were maladjusted, prone to misbehavior and loneliness.

Jimmy understood them.

From the center of the heartbroken American family, the tentacles of criminality spread outward. Jimmy had pursued those tentacles as dutifully as if chasing down his own longing for attachment, first as a Garden City cop for six years of the 1990s meth boom, in a cruiser doing gang work in Treasure Valley, followed by two decades riding what he called "the ghost rail," that shadow-path of psychological trauma populated by ex-cops, soldiers, and addicts, the air putrid with flashbacks of oxidized blood that on bad days could seem as particulate as fog.

No amount of intimacy with the dead, however, had prepared Jimmy for the sight of Ayita's exploded torso. Her midsection looked like a puzzle piece with shapes blown away, the remainder of her parts separated from their match, scattered across the bloodied concrete.

Jimmy had pulled on his shoes in the back of a squad car while the Pocatello PD taped off a grid, Jimmy waiting to give his statement.

A second bomb was found beneath his own F-150, the truck's computer likely hacked, the bomb's blasting cap wired to interact with Jimmy's key fob signal, same as Ayita's. Both trucks had been rigged to blow. Although Jimmy's vehicle had caught fire out of proximity and been rendered a total loss, the incendiary device thirty-six inches beneath his steering column was faulty, remained intact. It was removed for study by the Idaho State Police. Maybe

they'd find a fingerprint or digital residue left behind in the cloud by the hacking of his truck's mainframe, but probably not.

Rigging both vehicles defied logic, but frequently criminals had their own mathematical reasoning. As a baseline, it was easy to surmise that either Jimmy himself, Ayita alone, or both had been the intended quarry. Targeting both vehicles suggested haste, scarier to Jimmy than a professional hitter. The perpetrator would be an amateur with newly obtained high-level skills, as dangerous as a pro but, lacking precision, sloppy with collateral bloodshed.

He was dizzy and overwhelmed by the stench of his vomit in the police cruiser transecting with memories of Ayita in bed. Her murder evoked the violent demise of his mother. Neither of these two women he'd loved had been graced with allowance for goodbyes, although he immediately realized the foolishness of assigning his brief attachment to Ayita as more than dopamine and adrenalin based. *His feelings hadn't the time to approximate love, had they?*

Beneath the electricity of physical touch, he'd at least felt for Ayita the way staring into the face of another animal felt while hiking in the woods, a quietness surrounding the two bodies as they happen upon one another, each suddenly making eye contact with the shared souls of themselves.

Jimmy'd had an eerily similar feeling decades before while watching the windows of his mother's motel burst outward with flames shortly after Hillcrest took possession. He'd stood in the dark with a feeling of familiarity washing over him, the blaze a surreptitious yet meaningful friend Jimmy would see again one day. The glass and framework of the motel had popped-open with sudden ulceration, the fire stampeding across the L-shaped rooftop, the sky starless and dry in the minutes before but then undulant with smoke. The smell of gasoline was on Jimmy's clothing for days afterward, clung to the hairs in his nostrils for weeks, it'd seemed.

Why Ayita's murder brought back these memories of his mother's motel, Jimmy was too ashamed to admit.

Now the flashing Pocatello PD squad car lights painted the concrete like a strip club. The rain returned hard. The parking lot outside the cruiser sloped to a drain gully and Jimmy watched Ayita's blood flow downward with the rainwater and dilute to the color of terra cotta.

Sometime in the future, droplets of Ayita's blood might precipitate from the sky, having evaporated from the ground to fall again, all life in liquid form forever recycling itself. Even now, it was possible the sheen of rain cascading down the cruiser's windshield contained the particulate of the many dead who'd passed before, maybe even Jimmy's mother among them.

Across the parking lot, an 18 x 20-foot canopy had been erected as a short-term command center for state and local PD working the scene. Beneath the canopy, lit by tripod-mounted telescoping lights from Home Depot, a folding banquet table was covered with a painter's tarp, where two Pocatello crime scene investigators stacked the collectible portions of Ayita's body. He could barely look at the carnage, his vomit threatening to rise again.

If there was a debt of her own Ayita's murder had offset, it must have been brutally entrenched. In time Jimmy might learn of it, but a paywall often guarded the ultimate truths, and the price of that paywall, he suspected, was usually death.

Pocatello's responding officer, a detective named Braxton Gooding, maybe Jimmy's age and with a head like an upturned toaster, opened the cruiser for Jimmy, ushered him across the lot to a set of folding card chairs beneath the canopy. They hustled through the downpour, Gooding's rain slicker heavy and black as an inner tube.

Jimmy sat with his back to the banquet table, shivered. His hair and neck were wetted by the rain. He inhaled a familiar, multi-dimensional aroma. In corpses left to rot, there was decomposition, feces fermentation, the souring of maggot infestation. In combat deaths, akin to this, gunpowder seared the flesh, turned the air acidic. Metaphysically, death changed the scent of everything nearby.

In his first year as a cop, Jimmy'd been witness to a drug-fueled homicide at one of Garden City's 34th Street rentals, a young woman taking a bullet to the back of her head from a .38 pawn shop throw-down the moment Jimmy arrived on foot. Nearby cherry trees in full blossom had suddenly distorted to appear thinner, took on the characteristic fragrance of fried electrical lines as the woman's soul crossed over, the physical world malleable, Jimmy's senses overlapping as time and space became mercurial, as if he'd low-dosed on psilocybin.

Jimmy experienced something similar now, Gooding taking the chair opposite and asking questions Jimmy could hear and respond to but whose pitch and timbre were accompanied by an almost metallic-seeming whir that filled his ears.

Through the din, Jimmy explained his purpose in Bannock County, including his meeting with Billings and Ayita at the scene of the Impala fire and the related discovery of Hillcrest's body in the vehicle's trunk. He provided only the necessary details of his meeting with Ayita at Applebee's, tactfully referring to their time in his motel room afterward as consensual adult companionship.

Gooding got the point, his eyes flat as church wafers when he said, "I've heard all I need tonight." He placed his hand delicately on Jimmy's shoulder, adding, "My cousin runs the Enterprise shop. He'll arrange a rental vehicle for you in the morning."

Gooding searched Jimmy's eyes one last time, too long for protocol, told him, "I have a feeling you're not usually this pale. Try to rest."

Jimmy knew that Ayita would have been questioned internally for physical contact with him, even if non-coital, during an active investigation to which he was an ancillary witness. But Gooding, box-jawed as he was, seemed discreet, unlikely to exploit transgressions of the flesh in his report.

That's when Jimmy remembered Gooding's face—the shape of his head and the wafer-flat eyes that softened when he cupped Jimmy's shoulder to comfort him were suddenly unmistakable.

From how many years ago now?

He remembered the man without his shirt on, the red carpeting beneath bare feet in a cinderblock motel room on the outskirts of downtown Boise, bedsheets reeking of cigarette smoke and balm, the pomegranate-colored Cabana Inn sign across the parking lot on thirty-foot-tall poles and the headlights of passing traffic filtering across the bedroom through muslin drapes gone sheer from age, experience, and embarrassment.

Jimmy's pulse was racing now, his face suddenly hot with alarm and adrenaline, the skin beneath his cheekbones tingling as if in combat.

He had not known the man was a cop, had known very little about him to begin with—maybe an hour of conversation at a bar before Jimmy paid the tab and walked out just a few steps in front of the man, both of them boozed to the gills. When Jimmy later tried to remember whatever words they'd shared, he couldn't.

Had Gooding recognized him?

Jimmy hoped not but couldn't focus on that. Beyond the canopy, Sandy Billings' Blackfoot Fire Department Chevy Silverado splashed through potholes until the headlights of his truck swung onto Jimmy, bathed his face in halogens so bright Jimmy squinted his eyes to a razor-thin crease.

Billings stopped his rig just short of the command station, stepped out hard and quick across the pavement, his truck still running with the driver-side door left swung-open.

He briefly stared open-mouthed at the banquet table with Ayita's body parts.

Then he crossed the distance to Jimmy, took hold of the placket of Jimmy's shirt and twisted it hard. The shirt torqued against Jimmy's chest and he smelled the fumes of alcohol on Billings' breath, the cigarette smoke on his clothing.

"If her lady parts weren't in pieces, I'd insist on a fucking rape kit, Chinden."

Jimmy recoiled from the man's vapor and instinctively applied a rotational wristlock, grabbing Billings' hand and twisting it backward to supinate the man—it was done with more force than

even Jimmy'd expected, a great violence in his heart perhaps building for decades, since even before his mother's death.

Jimmy heard the man's wrist snap like a stick of dry kindling on a cold night. Billings dropped to a knee, squawking.

It took Gooding and another cop to release Billings from Jimmy's grip, Jimmy holding the man's joint as if clutching the bird-like bones of Hell, lest it soar.

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FIVE

Billings' fingernail had nicked the skin of Jimmy's breastbone through the buttons of his shirt, probably as Jimmy'd rotated the man's wrist, and now Jimmy stood in the bathroom mirror in his hotel room after a shower, studying the small laceration in the shape of a crescent moon that'd been scratched into the dip between his pectoral muscles. He wondered if any of Billings' own blood was transferred in the process—and what Jimmy might have inherited from Billings, bloodborne or otherwise, in the moment he'd subjugated the man.

He walked naked out of the bathroom, physically exhausted, wanting sleep but knowing he wouldn't get any. It was near three in the morning, "black dawn," he often called that time of day, the hour when criminals awoke to pull home invasions or carry bodies out of rear doors. On the carpet beside the bed they'd ruffled together, Jimmy saw Ayita's tote bag in a heap. He'd forgotten about that. Pocatello PD hadn't inquired about Ayita's belongings, either.

Jimmy pulled on his jeans sans underwear, picked up the tote bag, placed it beside him on the bed. With kid glove treatment, he gradually removed the contents: a black canvas wallet large enough for only Ayita's driver's license and credit cards, her government-issued cell phone smudged with fingerprints, two loosely-folded twenty-dollar bills, a worn meditation journal with a leather jacket cover, a single banana, a travel-sized bottle of hand sanitizer, her service weapon—a standard Ruger .45 with a full clip—and finally, a neatly-rolled hand towel Jimmy guessed had been boosted from the yoga studio before Ayita'd found him at Applebee's.

He unrolled the towel. The locker key Ayita'd confiscated fell into his hand.

Jimmy leaned back against the headboard. He remembered that lifetime ago in the hermetic world of his childhood: The low-income chainlink-and-neon urbanscape of Garden City that held his mother's motel; the rooms of the motel holding mostly women of the night in its muscular, rarely-vacant concrete arms; Jimmy's VHS recorder permanently corralling the men who visited each evening; and the men themselves desperately holding onto their secrets, some of them worth the cost of a red-knobbed key.

He drifted to sleep, slipped into dream of Sandy Billings casually breast stroking through the chlorinated water of a regulation swimming pool with the summer sunlight rippling on either side of him, the ripples turning to flames.

A knock at the hotel door startled him awake. It was four in the morning. He realized he'd fallen asleep in his jeans, the lockbox key still in his hand. Another knock on the door, louder this time. Jimmy shoved the key into his front pocket as he traipsed across the carpeting.

Through the peephole in the door, he observed a white male standing approximately 5'10", mid-thirties, a slightly hooked nose.

Jimmy opened the door just wide enough to converse.

The man's physique was slim, hardened like a boxer's. He wore the Chinos and navy windbreaker of a cop but the two-day stubble along his jawline told Jimmy he wasn't one.

"I'm sure I woke you," the man said apologetically. He flashed a composition book and added, "I'm with the *State Journal*. It's too late for our morning print run, but we'd like to post something online about what happened here."

"The police department will give you everything you need," Jimmy said, knowing that wouldn't be true.

"Active investigation," the man replied, making quotation marks in the air. "Pig Latin for 'Fuck you.' And besides, we're also interested in Detective Smith on a personal level. Her mother was an editor at the *Journal* in the early 1990s, so..."

The man strained to see inside the room. Jimmy clocked the reporter's pupils opening to the size of dimes, the way a predator's

might. He thought about Ayita's tote, nobody's business but the PD's. He stepped outside, holding the door ajar with his hind heel.

The man's breath smelled of stale coffee, the odor of the sleepless.

"I didn't know that about her mother," Jimmy said. "Is she alive?"

"No," the man told him. "Listen, I hate to overstep, but can you tell me the nature of your relationship with Detective Smith?"

"I didn't know Ayita Smith very well," Jimmy said. "I'm sorry, but that's all I'm comfortable telling you right now."

The man tore a clean sheet from the notebook, wrote his phone number under the name "Leon Gail," asked Jimmy to call if he felt more comfortable talking over a coffee in the morning.

Jimmy knew he wouldn't. He shut the door, bolted it, listened to the man's footsteps down the hallway. He could also hear the young hipsters in the room next door making love, their stress of waking to a grimmer world than yesterday's, after a homicide in eyeshot of their accommodations, apparently ground-away by friction.

Then he slept two more hours, dreaming rapidly. This time his cell vibrating on the nightstand roused him. He checked the phone—it was his daughter's burner pinging from New York.

"You okay?" he asked, his voice dry from sleep, daylight a bright, vertical crease traveling from floor to ceiling between the blackout shades of his room.

"That's the first thing you say?"

"It's the first thing I care about."

His daughter sighed, her mild anxiety a residual from Jimmy's sometimes strict oversight of her teenaged years. He'd not been a difficult father to understand, but his line of work often caused him to worry about her physical safety, a fact that could be suffocating to her—he suspected that underneath her mild disdain for his affection was a broken heart, like his own, that craved to be worried-over. Such was the state of all children, Jimmy thought, no matter their age.

"I'm calling to see if you're okay," she said. "I got a Google alert for your name that sent me to a *Journal* article. What the hell is going on out there?"

"I'm surprised it posted already. He was just here a couple of hours ago," Jimmy deflected, neither of them enjoying the familial faux pas of too-overtly eliciting the other's concern. "I'm sorry to worry you. It's just work, hon."

"Who's 'he'?" she asked. "A woman wrote this article. And car bombs aren't your usual work. Did you know the victim very well?"

"A little," he said, wished he could tell her more. "You get Google alerts for my name?"

"Only a handful of people have my burner, so I put in alerts for everybody I know back home. It's the only way I'll learn if something terrible happens to any of you."

"That's a sobering thought. Are you sure all of this is still necessary?"

"More than ever. I'm working on a real exposé now. The Nazis lost their war a long time ago—I'm planning to remind them. One question, when did you understand the difference between intuition and paranoia?"

"They're cut from the same cloth," Jimmy told her. "Ally, what are you into?"

"I'll be fine, Dad. The computer in my flat is entirely offline. I'm researching and checking emails at public libraries. I'm paying my rent in cash."

"I love you," Jimmy said.

"I know, Dad. I'm glad you're okay."

Jimmy felt splintered inside when they hung up the phone. Both of his children had traveled great distances in efforts to join what many would deem righteous wars, but wars, nevertheless. He wondered why, feared he'd never fully know the demons his children harbored.

At 8:00 a.m., a salesman from Enterprise Rent-a-Car delivered a white F-150 to Jimmy at the hotel, grabbed Jimmy's signature along with license and credit card information, then jumped into

his follow car and left with a wave. The rain had stopped and Jimmy loaded his gear into the pine-scented back seat. He went inside the motel, filling himself a paper cup of coffee from the lobby's pump-pot. Then he returned to his rental, the sunlight hot against his cheekbones already. He climbed inside. The temperature that day would escalate quickly—absent more rain, by 5:00 p.m. southern Idaho would be triple digits, common for early August.

The interstate heading south of the Clarion was fluid with traffic going to McCammon then Malad City before the Utah border, and eventually to Salt Lake City two hours away, where the President-elect of the Mormon Church's sixteen million members went by the moniker of Prophet and publicly supported conversion therapy, the pseudoscientific practice of chemical castration, electroshock of the genitals, or opposite-sex masturbation as varying means of eradicating what the Church referred to as the "disease" of homosexuality.

If there was a Gomorrah, the city in the Bible punished for its crimes of the flesh, then there would surely be a Gomorrah for crimes against the human spirit. The heart of that city, Jimmy thought, might be Salt Lake's Temple Square.



Braxton Gooding, with his auburn hair, aqua blue eyes, and G.I. Joe dome had certainly been reared from Mormon genetics. Inside the Pocatello police station, Jimmy shook his hand, felt callouses on the man's palm, likely from extensive pull-up work that Jimmy hadn't remembered. Gooding'd been taking care of himself, it seemed.

He handed Gooding Ayita's tote bag, the gun inside weighing down a corner, Jimmy anxious to leave quickly.

"Her service weapon is in there. It was loose like that when I found it."

"She brought a .45 to yoga?" Gooding asked.

"I wondered about that myself."

“You around for lunch?” Gooding set the bag onto his desk.

“Lunch’ll be a protein bar today if I’m lucky,” Jimmy replied.

“I see,” Gooding told him. “Next time, then.”

He shook Jimmy’s hand, held long. It wasn’t hard to read him.

“You haven’t aged much,” Gooding said. “Then again, it was mostly dark the last time I saw you. It came to me this morning that I must have been flying out of Boise the next day for training with the DEA up in Seattle. Was it ten years ago?”

Jimmy checked his periphery to see if anybody in the station was watching through the glass walls of Gooding’s office.

“I’m sorry,” Gooding added, noting the reaction. “My mother always warned me not to piss in my own pool. I guess I didn’t handle broaching this subject very well.”

“Detective Gooding,” Jimmy interrupted before the man dug himself deeper, somewhere Jimmy didn’t want them to be. “I have great respect for the wisdom of mothers. Mine is no longer alive, but I listen to her anyway. I’ve noticed life is a lot easier for everyone around me when I do.”

Jimmy made it back to his truck with his bones rattling, dropped his keys twice on the floorboard before he was able to press the fob to start his engine. Then he accidentally hit his window wipers instead of the gearshift before squealing out of the parking lot.

He tried to understand the events of the last 24 hours. Even some of the smaller details were weighing on him, but little things seldom made sense until the big things did. Ayita hadn’t only taken her service weapon to yoga but also to the restaurant with her and then into Jimmy’s hotel room afterward. Jimmy’s own weapon, the slight-bodied Springfield XDS 9mm with a seven-round clip, had been strapped to his ankle during dinner then placed inside the nightstand. If Ayita had felt an impending threat, a gun on her person after hours didn’t necessarily imply that.

The locker key remained a more pressing question. Why hadn’t Ayita checked it into evidence? Jimmy could have given the key to Gooding himself but didn’t. He was actively hindering a murder

investigation, but why? The key remained in Jimmy's front pocket like a compass pointing him in unexpected directions.

He detoured to the Fort Hall casino, the windows of his rental truck unrolled and the vehicle sucking-in the late summer tang of fertilized farmland bordering that stretch of highway.

If needed, he would return the key later, claiming it'd been accidentally mixed with his own possessions at the motel. For now, Jimmy saw the key as relevant to his theft investigation, also recognized his drive to retain the item out of a gut feeling it was a totem inexplicably connecting his mother's death to Ayita's. Otherwise, why had Rudolph Hillcrest fallen into Jimmy's lap? The rules of the universe often defied forecasting, none of us really knowing what the fuck was going on, big picture. Jimmy would err on the side of caution, keep the key until he no longer felt compelled to. His daughter had asked about the difference between instinct and paranoia. Jimmy, he knew, couldn't rightly answer her.

The F-150 was cruising at ninety an hour before hitting the Fort Hall turn-off, crows spraying upward from the gullies Jimmy passed.

Was it true that certain birds carried away the souls of the recently departed?

Just after 9:30 in the morning, the parking lot of the casino was mostly empty. To the forefront, a dozen low-budget vehicles, presumably employee-owned, were parked in an area least protected from the sun. Many had damaged bumpers and t-boned doors their insurance policies had likely paid-out on, the checks cashed as "fun money" instead of applied toward damages. To the rear of the casino, another unmarked semi-trailer idled in the building's shade.

Inside, Jimmy found Brody Hawkstellar at an empty blackjack table enjoying a plate of eggs with two sausage patties scorched-black and sturdy as hockey pucks. A nearby slot machine was decorated with the arid geography of Afghanistan. It played machine gun fire on a loop.

Jimmy let his arm brush against Hawkstellar's as he sat at the felt-covered card table, Hawkstellar choking on his food then drinking from a glass of water before saying, "I heard things got exciting after you left yesterday." He smiled, teeth speckled with sausage, yellowed.

"What's in those semis coming through here, Brody?" Jimmy asked.

"Old machines and new machines, Chinden. What do you think?" He wiped the back of a hand across his closed mouth, the whites of his eyes clean as boiled eggs.

"I think you made that up," Jimmy said. "And I think maybe you're pallet-jacking reefer for one of the cartels. Or maybe you're bundled-out with workers for the coyotes. Whatever it is, I think those trucks are big enough to transport an old Impala, along with anything else you're running."

"You know the one thing I learned most in prison?"

"What's that?"

"The guards, much as they try, never really accomplish anything."

Hawkstellar picked up his plate, abandoned Jimmy to slot machine gunfire and the aroma of last night's alcohol trailing out of his pores as noxious as jet fuel.

SIX

In the parking lot of the casino, with the F-150 idling, Jimmy took out his phone and read the *State Journal* article about Ayita's death. His daughter had been correct, the story written by a woman. Jimmy was mentioned as a professional associate of Ayita's, caught in the salvo, connected to Ayita only through the Hillcrest case.

He had Braxton Gooding to thank for the discretion. He also had Gooding possibly threatening to breach the walls Jimmy'd built to keep his privacy intact. He didn't know which to count on, the Gooding who was a cop and hopefully reliable or the one Jimmy'd known little about those years past, his jeans on the motel floor along with Jimmy's alcoholism of the time, an ashtray of cigarette butts, a candy wrapper, a sock—it was coming back to him.

He googled variants of "Leon Gail" and "*State Journal*" together but there were no viable hits nor images that matched the reporter who'd tried to interview him at the motel. He opened his laptop and used the casino's wifi to run the cell number the man had given him. It traced to a burner. When he called it, there was no answer, no voicemail functionality.

Jimmy drove to the Flores property past a hundred-acre swath of coal-colored scrub, last month's burn like an eye patch on the face of the foothills, the result of middle-schoolers having absconded to higher elevations to shoot illegal fireworks from energy drink cans with predictable results. The thirteen to fifteen demographic was a shitstorm, vexing and self-destructive, but the ecosystem of humankind thrived, nevertheless.

In moments when Jimmy could quiet his mind, the cycle of life seemed a great comfort, but now after Ayita's death he found the near-mechanical continuity of existence to be almost obscene. Each evening, violence slashed its ever-lengthening blade across

humankind, and yet the morning grocery stores received their semi-trucks of produce, loading docks teeming with minimum-wage workers, the coffee shops on every corner hummed with \$25,000 steel espresso banks, Amazon packages got dumped onto doorsteps from 4:00 a.m. until 10:00 p.m., gas prices rose from two-fifty to four-fifty every summer, and the suburban rich mounted Thule racks to Audi Q7s and took on low-impact charitable work while reaping the social capital it garnered. The mill churned, and even the inheritors of tragedy were expected to merge into it.

Jimmy's part in the continuance would be updating the insurance adjuster later today. Otherwise, he'd risk violating his promised twenty-four-hour contact turnaround, helpful after the discovery of substantive leads in a claim investigation, and he had this interview to conduct with Tio Flores, ten minutes out, although he deeply wished he could mourn Ayita Smith's death properly. Jimmy fought the urge to drive home, close his drapes, and climb into bed for a week. Years ago, he would have included an icy bottle of vodka in the picture.

The Flores' property was ungated, a wall of smashed vehicles to either side of the quarter-mile gravel driveway securing the entry by providing no natural turnaround. Once pointed down the drive, on-comers were forced to continue—subject to ambush, Jimmy darkly thought, the imposing boxes of crushed steel rigid as a Queen's Guard lining the approach to Flores' home. Beyond were hundreds of additional abandoned vehicles, an infantry of rusted hulls.

Jimmy drove slowly, gravel crunching into his tires, dust rising behind.

To the east of the property, just after it opened up, were three small storage barns. Far behind was a tall, steel-framed structure approximately one hundred feet in length, resembling a grain storage facility. Beside it was a vehicle crusher on an unfenced half-acre scrap lot tight with junkyard metal, and an elongated black-on-black Cadillac Escalade parked at an angle.

The main residence, a single story painted the color of nutmeg to mimic adobe, sat upon a parcel of dehydrated sand, its windows covered from inside with heavy canvas.

Flores' large acreage behind the home was low-spreading grassland with a solitary Appaloosa standing in the pasture a quarter mile away. The land probably hadn't been farmed in a century, although Jimmy could see its agricultural potential and what Ayita had implied was a vulnerability to subdividing by West Coast transplants.

Jimmy approached the home, knocked on the door, but there was no answer, no movement within. He heard the Cadillac's engine in the distance. He turned toward the sound, stepped away from the house as the vehicle looped-inward, swung toward him from beside the scrapyard. From two-hundred yards, it approached slowly. Jimmy was uncomfortable with his isolation—the past twenty-four hours' events had his lizard brain rotating on a swivel, synthesizing threat with three-hundred-and-sixty-degree capability.

Sunlight refracted off the SUV's headlights. Dust wafted from the wheel wells. Jimmy felt a breeze against the back of his neck, was suddenly overwhelmed by a sensory memory, the smell of juniper and bitterroot warming in the sunlight of a sub-surface recollection he struggled to place. He wasn't feeling déjà vu but did wonder if men sometimes retraced their steps throughout overlapping periods of time without knowing it, past, present, and future braided.

Tio Flores parked the Cadillac perpendicular to Jimmy, engine idling, the tinted driver-side window descending into its track. Flores wore a ballcap over tar-black hair matted to his temples with sweat, a gold herringbone chain hanging inside his t-shirt. His skin was the color of espresso, aged by decades of deep sunburn. His eyes shone like polished obsidian over high-set cheekbones, and when he reached his hand out the window, Jimmy shook it. The man's knuckles like quarry rocks, Flores either having performed manual labor his whole life or punched people's faces for a living. Jimmy guessed a bit of both.

Jimmy released his hand and Flores said, "Would you mind driving out to the horse with me? I have to feed her." He gestured to the Appaloosa adding, "The rain yesterday curdled her oats. I spoil her. Do you understand?"

"I do," Jimmy said. He walked to the passenger door, stepped into the vehicle, noticed how cleanly the heavy door shut behind him, the comfortable leather seats accepting his body with the ease of a hot baked potato accepting a ladle of sour cream. Against his will, Jimmy melted into the luxury. Maybe this was the plan, people of means often weaponizing opulence against Jimmy as a diversion tactic, the rural moneyed no different from the urban in that regard.

Flores drove slowly toward his Appaloosa, the tires crunching over sage, pebbles smacking into the wheel wells like pennies ricocheting inside a clothing drier.

"She no longer eats wet food. Do you have animals?"

Jimmy told him, truthfully, "I did once. They slept in my bed, and the children fed them from plates when I wasn't looking." He could have kept this to himself, said either "No" or "Yes" and stuck to the job, but Flores' non-combative demeanor had relaxed his reptilian alertness.

Flores laughed with teeth as white as bones in a desert. "You're sentimental, Jimmy. I understand you."

They reached the Appaloosa and both men stepped outside, the horse backlit by sunlight, a small trough of rainwater nearby. Flores pulled a fifty-pound bag of mixed oats and grain from the rear of his vehicle, shouldered it toward the trough, dropped the bag on the ground and slit it with car keys. The bag opened like a knife wound, Flores tearing at it with both hands now. He left it on the ground for the Appaloosa to feed from. Both men stared at the horse, her silver hair falling backward onto mottled, black and white skin, her pitch-black underbelly, her chest of quivering muscles.

"She rarely leaves this spot," Flores said. "Her foal is buried here." Then he added, "I've read that some animals experience

orgasm when they die. In cultures around the world, men murder them for the animal's pleasure alone."

Jimmy looked at the side of the man's face, told him, "I doubt that's true."

They walked back to the vehicle. Once inside, Flores turned it around, headed back to the residence with the sun at their rear and sagebrush scraping at the undercarriage. His unblinking eyes appeared tangled in the thought patterns of a functional psychotic. Jimmy's reptilian instinct reawakened. His shooting hand lowered on the seat cushion where he rested it closer to his ankle weapon for the remaining few-hundred yards of their drive.

Flores had the mark of malignant narcissism Jimmy had seen in dozens of career criminals employing lopsided communication to affect what rational thinkers viewed as "quirkiness," but whose unreliability was exploited to plant seeds of adoration and fear in the same crop, love and the threat of death as co-existing promises, an imbalance used for control, frequently of women and children. Men who suffered under the duress of manipulative but "witty" correctional officers, or migrants smuggled by coyotes with the same conversational traits, were equally susceptible to the emotional stress of pinballing between their captors' false endearment and deadly rage.

Flores pulled in beside Jimmy's F-150, wiped the sweat from his brow with a white handkerchief soiled at the edges, said to him, "If you reach behind my seat, there's a black binder with everything you need, including a complete accounting of parts purchased for the Impala, all receipts, and a narrative of events chronicling my involvement in the rebuild."

Jimmy looked back and saw the binder on the floor, retrieved it and briefly flipped through the pages in his lap. A Polaroid of the vehicle, cherry red and glinting under sunlight beside an aluminum-sided storage barn, was stuffed into the pocket of a plastic divider, the words "1961 Impala SS 409 Convertible" in black Sharpie across the border of the photo.

"There were less than thirty SS Convertibles made that year," Flores said. "They all had a 348 under the hood, Jimmy. I smoked

cigarettes for a month before deciding to put a 409 in it.”

“Wouldn’t an alien engine undercut the value?” Jimmy asked.

“That car got the ribbon at the Barret Jackson Cup in Reno. So, no. Although the sell-through rate at Monterey has been dropping. There were better places to move it this year.”

“Did you advise the owner of this?”

“That is not my business, Jimmy. I only get paid to rebuild them.”

“I think your business stretches beyond hobby cars.”

“That is very true,” Flores laughed. “I haul steel down to the Texas gulf, and we ship it to China where there’s a shortage. They turn it into products we buy back from them. This is why the American presidents are always self-hating, because the Chinese get away with selling us shit we already own. Can you imagine a cocaine dealer paying for overseas labor to step on the product with baby laxative then ship it back?”

Jimmy had baited Flores, intuiting his involvement with Ayita’s murder. Now he’d get nowhere today, not with Flores at the center of gravity here in the desert, and Jimmy off-balance from the unexpected smell of manure on the wind, the sun hotter than expected. He had visual flashes of Ayita departing his motel room, how they’d waved at one another through the plate glass window, and afterward the flames of her truck bursting outward.

The truth always felt symmetrical when Jimmy heard it, wanted Tio Flores to tell him something simple, right the equilibrium, offer a platitude explaining Ayita blown to smithereens across a parking lot in the middle of Jimmy’s heart.

“You do not look well,” Flores told him. Jimmy stared across Flores’ acreage to where the dry heat was already beginning to look like water in the distance. He wondered how anybody, even psychosocial outliers, survived in arid climates without friendship or family. He looked at the Flores’ house now, the heavy curtains keeping sunlight out.

It appeared to have no air conditioning unit, no processes in place for supplemental cooling other than those heavyweight

canvases behind glass. *Why weren't the windows open?* Without cross-ventilation, the rooms would be sweltering.

"Who lives with you?" Jimmy asked. Flores' background report had been absent any relatives, an anomaly with today's search capabilities.

Flores exhaled with impatience, told Jimmy, "You should go home now, but I'd like you to understand one thing before you leave."

"What's that?" Jimmy's feet were planted firmly on the floorboards of the Cadillac, images of his son dappling his consciousness—the boy somewhere in a Humvee across the world, living in a man's skin now. Jimmy missed him badly even as Flores spoke.

"I've known Ayita Smith since she was riding bareback on her mother's hip," Flores told him, the man's voice shifting toward baritone, eyes like black oil sliding over Jimmy's when he added, "I understand you were with her last night. If you had anything to do with her death, Jimmy, I will bury you beside that foal in the field. Only the crows and one horse will be watching me dig."

Jimmy wondered if he and his son weren't both behind windshields in other men's wars—Jimmy bathed in sunlight at the moment, his son bathed in moonlight that came from the same sky.

SEVEN

For the first forty miles of the three and half hour drive back to Boise, wind blew from the south, shaking Jimmy's truck, sagebrush lodging in his grill. Just past American Falls, Jimmy relaxed into the drive, even the usual swelling in his knuckles abating—they were mildly arthritic after decades of bag and dummy work in his home gym. The Jiu Jitsu, Taekwondo, Krav, and Jeet Kune Do, which he also practiced, took their own toll but kept him able-bodied.

Physically fit and usually poised, he'd seldom drawn his weapon as a P.I., fired it only one time on the job, after a standoff with a bail skip holding a baby over the railing of a Garden City flop motel. Jimmy watched the baby wiggle-away from the man, fall from the vintage second-story balcony to the hood of an SUV, roll from the hood and drop hard onto the concrete. Jimmy'd fired a fuck-you round, shattering the bail skip's shoulder, spent three days lying to the police until they eventually decided not to charge him, siding with common decency instead. It was a pass he'd earned due to his six years on the force chasing meth addicts across parking lots.

Although Jimmy was rarely without his ankle weapon, he viewed its necessity as a blight. Ironically, he thought, the common handgun, arguably made more popular by the religious right, often assisted in defying many of the biblical Ten Commandments at once.

Jimmy went heavy because his profession required it, whereas his wife had been an amateur ammunition wholesaler when he'd met her, a fanatic with a charge card hot for assault rifles. He'd never cared for his wife's romance with artillery, thought it selfish to spend used car prices on what amounted to murderous gadgetry, but sometimes Jimmy wondered if his wife hadn't understood better how to live a joyous life, courting immediate

pleasures and live action experience instead of sitting around “thinking,” as Jimmy’d been accused of—none of us were promised more than a single day, he’d grown to understand decades too late.

By the time he pulled into Boise, the air was hot and dry. The gas gauge was nearly on empty, traffic choked as a Los Angeles mile going north on Vista Boulevard. He passed the university, peeled-off west of downtown, detoured to the Greyhound station. The street out front was reminiscent of Boise’s yesteryear, unexpectedly vacant and calm, the pavement quivering with heat. He parked on the station side of the street, cut his engine, stared at the building’s large front windows, his truck mirrored in the reflection, the Greyhound sign a portal to that childhood world he remembered with vivid clarity.

It’d been well-over three decades since Jimmy’d worked the blackmail scam with his mother, twenty-five years since he’d ventured into the Greyhound station for any reason. He could see through the windows the same old lockers, the rows of keys he’d run fingers across—remembered an aphorism from a Chinese cookie at dinner with his daughter once: “A part of us remains wherever we have been.” A part of Jimmy remained inside that station all these years later.

He stepped down from his truck. The air seemed less oxygenated than usual, maybe ninety-seven degrees with a calcine desert wind blowing-in from the middle of nowhere on its way to Vegas. Across the street was the funeral parlor with an empty lot, west a block was the St. Baptist church. A bar band a few blocks away played Jimmy Buffet, probably on the patio of Txikiteo, where the hotel rooms were three hundred a night, the outdoor seating always full in summer.

Jimmy heard the lyrics, “*I made enough money to buy Miami, but I pissed it away so fast...*” felt the midday heat on his forehead, stood on the street a moment looking toward a row of parked vehicles to his east, sunlight banking off their windshields. “*Never meant to last, never meant to last...*”

He remembered those first weeks with his wife, just after they'd wed in Reno then ripped cross-country with the cassette crooning and the windows down, the motels every five hundred miles stinking of cigarettes and cocoa butter and freshly laundered linens dampened by body heat. Some music just did it for him like that, Jimmy Buffett or The Eagles, making him nostalgic for feelings that probably never existed to begin with.

A reflection of himself swung outward when he opened the door to the bus station, its overhead air conditioning unit immediately blasting ice cold air in his face. Behind the ticket counter on a hardbacked stool, the station attendant, an objectively obese young man with a ponytail of snow cone-pink hair, kept his eyes buried in a Harry Potter paperback. The costly air temperature and lack of work ethic seemed just another reason for employers to cut America's once-practical workforce to zero, but for Jimmy the Gen Z-er might be of use.

No cameras were mounted on the ceiling, Jimmy noticed. Cameras would have left the Greyhound Corporation vulnerable to slip-and-fall claims, sometimes a high dollar gift for the poor; absent video evidence of a true accident on the premises, low-budget customers often made poor witnesses for themselves in court, so it could be financially astute for a business to casually neglect interior surveillance measures.

The wall of lockboxes went from floor to ceiling, maybe thirty of them with thick, red keys protruding. Everything numbered. The key in Jimmy's pocket, #189, was associated with a large box up top, big enough for a roll-away travel bag, although it was already unlocked and empty.

As a boy, he'd thought the wall of lockboxes reminiscent of an animal morgue where dogs were kept when they died, the space inside each box full of echoes and darkness as veterinarians, he imagined, closed the door. He'd been eleven, not yet seen death up close.

Jimmy approached the attendant and asked him, "Is it possible somebody broke into a locker? It's been emptied, but I still have the key."

The globular young man met Jimmy's eyes halfheartedly. "You probably surpassed the time you paid for. A three-dollar token gets twenty-four hours of security. After that, we're instructed to store your belongings in the back. It's ten dollars a day if you come to reclaim them."

It didn't used to be like that but then neither did anything in the world used to be like now. Jimmy slid his key across the counter.

"How much is owed?" he asked.

A quick computer check. "Thirty dollars."

Jimmy took out his wallet, reached for his credit card but thought better of it. Instead, he removed two twenty-dollar bills and set them on the counter. The man slid him a ten and lumbered to a small back room. He returned with a sealed manila envelope, slid it across the counter to Jimmy. Probably should have asked Jimmy more questions before doing so—the code of feigned ignorance seemed in place all these years later, the keyholder the only thing that mattered.

Jimmy took the envelope to the restroom and checked the stalls. They were empty. For that matter, the station *and* grounds had seemed uncharacteristically desolate. Usually, a dozen passengers smoked cigarettes or rested beside bags waiting for a transfer outside.

He undid the metal clasp on the envelope, removed a single sheet of paper. It was stamped by the Ada County Recorder. A deed to a land parcel. Explained in tightly formatted paragraphs, the one-sheet identified a three-acre lot on the west side of Boise's downtown corridor.

This particular parcel, Jimmy knew, had been vacated in 2009 when its tenant, the owner of an auto dealership, fled to an overseas location after the Feds cracked down on fraudulent financing in the auto industry. The story of the dealership owner had been in the news for a month straight, then every few months afterward while Boise PD hunted him. Eventually, the story had fizzled.

Those three acres where the dealership had been, and its two adjoining parcels, had become exceedingly valuable to multiple developers working midnights with the mayor's office for approval of an eighty-million-dollar minor league baseball stadium—or soccer, they speculated. Or whatever, Jimmy thought, as there'd been no buy-in from a team yet, back-room money greasing the skids for a stadium in a city with no historical need for one, forty of the eighty mil to be funded by taxpayers, according to newspaper reporting. Nobody understood the deal very well. Certainly not Jimmy, who'd at least understood that to be the point.

The document in Jimmy's hands showed the three-acre parcel to be deeded to "Grisham Greasley, with Rights of Survivorship" and dated almost forty years ago, long before Greasley was a senator, when he was still "Gee-Gee" and maybe running with the white supremacists.

Jimmy took a phone shot of the deed then tucked it into his back pocket, closed the now-empty envelope and exited the restroom. On instinct, he went back to the sullen attendant and asked for another locker token, sliding back the ten-dollar bill. He received his change and a heavy, metallic chip embossed with a transit emblem. Then he picked a low-to-the-ground locker, one the oversized station attendant would have difficulty reaching, maybe forget about entirely. Jimmy slipped in the empty envelope, dropped his token, and twisted the key before tucking it into his front pocket.

He could not have explained why he'd locked the envelope away but kept the deed on his person. Thought of the envelope as a decoy, perhaps—*but for what?*

He rose and glanced out the station's windows. In the vacant lot next to the funeral home, someone had parked a white Chevy Malibu with Utah plates, probably a rental.

He pulled open the heavy glass door and stepped outside. As he crossed toward the front of his truck, something moved—just east of the building a blue splash of clothing, like a man taking a step forward, caught Jimmy's attention.

Instinctively, Jimmy dove to the ground, time slowing as a bullet shattered his passenger-side window. Shards of glass sprayed above him like confetti. Then everything moved at hyper speed again, the falling glass cutting into his scalp and Jimmy's adrenaline like a jackhammer in his throat.

From the concrete, he saw Leon Gail, the so-called reporter, wearing chinos and a windbreaker. The man took two more steps, told Jimmy "I hope you bought the damage waiver for that truck." He extended his pistol arm.

Jimmy whipped his 9mm from his ankle holster. There should not have been time, but he put a copper-encased slug in the man's trachea from fifteen feet away, firing his Springfield sideways from the ground as if whatever god oversaw our world had wanted Jimmy to have just that amount of exquisite ability, at least once, to save his own life—Gail's head cracked against the sidewalk like a bowling pin when he landed.

The man's weapon lay hanging halfway over the curb now, Gail on his back and reaching blindly for it with one arm outstretched, his face pointed at the sky. The gun teetered like a car hanging by its rear axle over a cliff, then it tumbled gently over the curb. Jimmy curled himself into a fetal position against the possibility of the weapon firing again. It didn't.

He rose and walked to the man, stood over him. Gail's trachea had a two-inch hole leaking blood and cartilage down the sides of his neck onto the concrete, his spine visible through the hole.

Atop the pooling blood, mottled strands of Gail's black mane fanned out to each side like the wings of a gull resting on pond water. His glassy eyes stared up in surprise, the air outside so still Jimmy could hear the crossing light at the nearest corner beeping in staccato signaling "Stop," the sound like Morse code, or like an EKG speeding up then ceasing altogether, the way small things, overcome with adrenaline, sometimes dropped from terror in mid-flight.

EIGHT

The interrogation room was cinderblock but smelled like the Jersey seashore, an aroma of chemicals and tidal foam off-gassing from a recent coat of industrial, pure white paint. Interrogation rooms were designed to make a perp want more from life than suffocating in the slowly contracting, concrete shroud they'd found themselves locked inside—the more claustrophobic the room, the likelier a convict would confess, if only to get home for the night. Jimmy imagined sunlight instead of the overhead halogens in two equal-sized rectangles across the ceiling, imagined the walls breaking away into blue skies, broad expanses.

He wondered what'd been painted-over on the now medical-white walls: years of vomit, blood, the shadows of the misguided clawing for a second chance? These could be bleached from the surface, painted a hundred times, but a century of police reports, sometimes our truest histories when uncorrupted, kept the record.

He sat alone at a steel table bolted to the floor by L-shaped brackets. Wasn't handcuffed but the forty minutes of silence weighed as heavy as iron fetters on his limbs. A person of color would already be in county lockup, pulled for questioning only later, county being a feeder to the revolving doors of the prison industrial complex that was growingly privatized now, owned by hedge funds.

First into the interrogation room was Detective Bobby Abbiati, standing only 5'8" tall but built like a college wrestler with a fireplug neck and broad shoulders tapering to a thirty-two-inch waist. Abbiati in generic construction boots, blue jeans, an oversized black tee shirt concealing the print of his standard-issue tactical .45 fastened at the hip, probably his daily uniform for working Vice in the Treasure Valley.

Jimmy had known the man since Abbiati's meth patrol in Nampa in the early 2000s, mostly working the Hispanics when MS-13 gang members briefly trickled into the valley from Central America, infiltrating the state's agricultural labor pools through H-2A work visas, a strategy taken from Mexican gang members running pharmaceuticals out of Pacific Northwest farming hubs. Abbiati'd sent a half-dozen young men to do hard time at the Max complex south of Boise, although many had paroled now, fifteen years older and looking at deportation when the system caught up.

Before moving to Boise in '95, chasing a woman who eventually left him for a needle, Abbiati was a cop in the borough of Queens in New York City, a decidedly advanced training ground for investigations. His hard-earned street smarts made him among the best cops in the valley. Sometimes even the most complicated of crimes stood out to him clear as bright red paint splashed across a canvas, so Jimmy wasn't surprised to discover Abbiati assigned to the bus stop shooting. Jimmy didn't know what he'd tell the man, still couldn't figure himself how he'd gotten so deeply into the shit.

Abbiati shut the door behind him, gave Jimmy a lemon La Croix with beads of moisture running down the can, probably pulled from Abbiati's personal ice chest. A nice touch. He sat across from Jimmy, set a manila file folder onto the polished metal table in front of him, waited while Jimmy opened the can of water then set it aside without drinking.

Abbiati held his fingers tent-shaped, seemed calm, the type of guy who did his own carpentry. The perfect interrogator. Only Abbiati's previous romance with a junkie betrayed the crevasses in his psyche, Jimmy thought. The man surely had well-hidden, broken places that spread incrementally, sometimes like a crack in a windshield but occasionally like the fault line of an earthquake. Had a penchant for working in the shadows, probably for reasons Jimmy himself did too, nobody to witness their demons that way.

Abbiati opened the file folder, revealing to Jimmy an old booking photograph of Leon Gail from a New York precinct, maybe ten years ago, spun it gently so the man Jimmy shot in the throat was now staring back from an 8" x 11" printout. Gail looked

younger in the photo but wide-eyed, a bug caught beneath an overturned glass.

"You took down a button man from Brooklyn today," Abbiati told Jimmy. "Threw it like a sidearm pitch, didn't you?"

Jimmy lifted the La Croix, drank deeply now to buy himself time. He'd killed the man in self-defense but sometimes, if you were in the wrong shit, that didn't matter.

"Aurelio Lopez comes to mind," Abbiati continued. "Pitching for the Detroit Tigers, 1983. A sidearm like spanking your girlfriend, if that's your thing."

Jimmy set the now half-empty can of La Croix onto the table, little bubbles from the carbonation effervescing on his tongue, security camera in a top corner of the room looking down on them like a dove on a perch.

"I just killed a man," Jimmy said. "Yesterday, a woman I respected was mangled by a car bomb while I watched. A few hours before that, I saw the body of a man so violently dispatched it made the back of my throat close, Detective."

"I'm just trying to break the ice. It's been a while, Jimmy."

"Consider it broken. The man I shot came to me last night at my hotel room, maybe four in the morning. Claimed to be a reporter for the *State Journal* in Pocatello."

"He was a shooter for the Aryans," Abbiati interjected.

"That man has the skin tone of an Italian or Middle Easterner."

"That's the game, Jimmy. He's actually half-Jewish, born Daniel Rosenberg. The other half is German seed dating back to the concentration camps. Maybe he hated himself because his great grandmother got rotated by a Kraut, or maybe he just hated the Aryans enough to take their thirty-thou a hit with pleasure. As far as the Aryans are concerned, who does a victim least expect it from, Fatty McFatso with neck tattoos and triceps acne or the understated macaroon in the corner?"

Why would the Aryans put a hit out?

Nothing made sense, except that everything unexpected had started when Jimmy'd run into Brody Hawkstellar, seen him

afterward closing the gate on that fifty-footer behind the casino.

“When I was still on the job, Idaho was a slingshot for the Mexican consortiums running phony pharmaceuticals to the East Coast,” Jimmy said. “Does that have anything to do with this?”

“You’ve been off the job a long time. Everything past the Great Lakes is crammed with state troopers now. Stay with me in the present.”

There was a long pause. Jimmy tried to calm the rising turmoil in his gut.

“You said the shooter is from Brooklyn. My daughter is living in New York City,” he told Abbiati. “Is she in danger?”



An hour went by. Jimmy was unable to reach his daughter on her burner. Abbiati was patient with Jimmy during the attempted phone calls every fifteen minutes.

Jimmy’d answered Abbiati’s remaining questions to a degree, explaining—*no, lying*—to Abbiati that he’d gone to the Greyhound station after discovering the locker key while rooting for a protein bar in his travel bag, hours after meeting Flores and Gooding this morning, Jimmy already on the road. The key, Jimmy professed, must have fallen out of Ayita’s possessions, into his own.

“Why’d you go to the locker before contacting Pocatello?” Abbiati had asked.

“Investigative whim.”

“Although you fully intended to share any spoils. Say you’d found a brick of cash. Or maybe the rubber they’d been looking for in the Lynette Culver Bundy murder.”

“Why would a psychopathic murderer like Ted Bundy use a prophylactic?” Jimmy asked, truly curious about Abbiati’s intellect possibly running on empty post middle-age, the way lots of men declined from lack of testosterone.

“That a forty-year-old case makes about as much sense today as your outlook on chain of custody,” Abbiati said. “Bundy might’ve confessed, but they never found her body, dipwad, so there’s no

proof yet. And I'm guessing you're so much smarter than us you might've found the prized sperm itself locked away doing pushups all these years. Why not? The Greyhound lockers are all evidence lockers anyway, in a manner of speaking."

"All I found was the manila envelope. And you have it now."

"For storing air."

"I don't have every answer, Detective."

"But realizing we might want the prints off the envelope, you locked it back up. Preserved the evidence. But why in a different locker?"

"There's a bad guy with my name in his mouth. I'm assuming he's higher on the chain than Rosenberg. If he came looking, I wanted the envelope to seem gone. Shift the power dynamic."

"Make like you had it, even though you didn't."

"Correct."

"And here I thought only dumb guys gave dumb answers."

Knowing his story sounded pretty weak, Jimmy pulled the key to the new locker from his front pocket, slid it across the table to Abbiati, who also asked to take possession of Jimmy's cell under the guise of doing a forensic search in case it'd been bugged. Jimmy refused. His iPhone contained a photo of the deed. He told Abbiati his report for the insurance adjuster required access to the Impala photos. The paper copy of the deed remained in Jimmy's back pocket.

So far, he had learned almost nil about the attempted hit on him, except that Abbiati theorized Jimmy had also been an additional F-150 target—if *not the only one*, Ayita an associated casualty—and the car bomber's sloppiness had caused the Aryans to import a professional shooter instead. Speculation or not, it made Jimmy feel sick, as did the GPS tracker Boise PD found magnetized to the undercarriage of Jimmy's rental truck.

Rosenberg had likely positioned the tracker after Jimmy'd gone into the hotel for his cup of coffee that morning, which meant that Rosenberg had also likely followed Jimmy to the Flores property, albeit from a great distance. *Had Rosenberg simply been waiting in the wings to take a clean pop at him somewhere privately?* If so,

Jimmy's stop at the Greyhound had accelerated Rosenberg's need to act, explaining the sloppy attempt in public, probably the only reason Jimmy was still alive.

Abbiati was skeptical of Jimmy's official statement but was winding up when Jimmy's cell finally rang, the numbers of his daughter's burner flashing.

"Ally," he said almost under his breath the way somebody might read the name on a tombstone, he'd later think—the way a man prays to the dead, God forbid.

"Dad, what's wrong?" she asked to him, and later that night, falling asleep in his own bed again, in the home he'd tried hard to build for his children as a sanctuary from the details of violence that accompanied his line of work, he would remember their earlier call from the hotel room and joke to himself, "That's the first thing you say?"

Now, with Abbiati listening carefully, Jimmy summarized the recent events for his daughter, begged her to be cautious.

"I already am," she said.

"Be more," he told her. "And if you're in touch with your brother, tell him the same."

"He's across the world, Dad. I think he'll be fine. We both will."

Jimmy hung up, hoped she was right, knew how quickly and inexpensively evil gets around. He slid the cell phone into his front pocket as Lieutenant Bartholomew Tall, "Big and Tall" among the force, opened the door to the interrogation room, stepped inside and shook Jimmy's hand with a Bible-sized claw, knuckles like golf balls, the door left wide-open.

"You've been a busy man," he said to Jimmy. "Three murders in two days. If you're the doer, that's serial territory."

"Fingers and toes," Jimmy said. "That's all I've got into this, Lieutenant."

Big and Tall smiled catching Jimmy's reference to a joke they'd shared back in the day when the Lieutenant was a rookie cop like Jimmy and the only African American on the force, a recent starting linebacker at Boise State thinking he still had a shot at the NFL, saying to Jimmy, "All I got is fingers and toes in this line

of work, Chinden. The really bad guys are waiting for me on the field.”

Two years had passed, Big and Tall performing poorly at consecutive NFL combines, and although he never played regulation football again, he often repeated to Jimmy, when mortality knocked on the door too-frequently, “Only ten fingers and toes into this, brother. Think about it like that,” the way prisoners nurtured the concept of parole, distancing from the grim day-to-day.

Jimmy’d heard that Big and Tall had been moonlighting as a security contractor for government officials when the Legislature was in session at the State Capitol Building in Boise and as unofficial travel detail for the Boise mayor’s frequent trips to Sun Valley, sister city to Hollywood. Now Jimmy noticed the TAG Heuer watch on Big and Tall’s wrist, maybe three grand.

“You’re good to go, Chinden,” Big and Tall said. “Cameras put up by the techies who bought the funeral parlor caught the shooting. So, other than misdemeanor jackass-ery, I can’t think of a charge in our jurisdiction. Pocatello PD, on the other hand, might have you on hindering if they feel like raising their own ass up a flagpole. They’d have to explain why a dead cop left case evidence in the hotel room of a PI she was screwing. I’m being generous, Chinden. I could hold you over the weekend, let you unravel whatever lie you’ve told yourself about tampering, but I’ve got money on the Mariners tonight. I don’t need the extra worry. Can I assume we know where to find you?”

“The same house as ever,” Jimmy said. “And Lieutenant, we weren’t ‘screwing,’ although this is not a word I’d prefer to use. As you indicated, the woman just lost her life.”

“I’ll walk him out,” Abbiati said.

Jimmy stood and followed Abbiati through the doorway, brushed by Big and Tall, noticed his sinewy neck still hardened from three decades of lifting weights, the man’s shirt collar buttoned tight as a housing clamp around a drainpipe. Made sense he was moonlighting in protection.

In the precinct parking lot, two rows of PD vehicles ran adjacent to Jimmy's shot-up rental, the vehicle missing a window, some of the glass still in Jimmy's hair, a chunk of the dashboard torn-apart where the bullet had exploded it.

The early evening sun was sinking like a red ember above Boise's summer smog inversion. Abbiati shook Jimmy's hand, told him flatly, "We have Victim Services available but somehow I don't feel like you're a victim in this."

"Are you suggesting I had a choice today?" Jimmy asked, taking a step closer to Abbiati. The man had gotten under his skin, maybe intentionally.

"I'm suggesting that anybody who fucks with fire can educatedly expect to get the tip of their prick burned. It's not advanced physics."

NINE

By 7:00 p.m., after an hour of paperwork at the nearby Enterprise Rent-a-Car office on Fairview Avenue, Jimmy inched his replacement vehicle through the Hyde Park district of Boise's North End past the old-fashioned ice cream store, patio restaurants, and corner gas station that regularly sold condoms and nicotine e-cartridges to the middle school kids converging from North Junior High.

Twenty years ago, Jimmy and his wife had purchased their four-bedroom North End bungalow for a hundred and forty thousand dollars. The value had quintupled since, and the flora of their little plot of land, on a street canopied by hardwoods, had also matured.

When Jimmy's wife was first leaving, she'd argued to sell. Jimmy'd refused, wanted their kids to eventually know each shrub outside by heart, the way he did, each idiosyncrasy in the home, like the creaking floorboards in the hallway between their single bath and sparsely decorated den with couch, fireplace, books on the built-in shelves, corner lamps Jimmy'd bought secondhand. Hoped his kids would learn that "home" wasn't something to be shifted every few years.

Jimmy'd written his wife a check for forty grand, all he'd had in savings at the time. Except for holiday visits those first few years, he hadn't seen her since. The children had their home, but it was conspicuously absent one of its founding members.

He pulled his rental truck into the long driveway that went back to a detached, clapboard garage, rarely used for parking, painted forest green to match the house. A crease of light from inside showed through a bend in the weather stripping along the concrete. He stepped out of the truck, approached the garage's glass-paned side door, ducked his head under the small apple tree

overhung with new fruit. Twisted the knob on the door, stepped inside.

The overhead bulb was lit, but Jimmy didn't remember leaving it on. Nothing seemed out of place, however. The power tools still shelved. The ten-foot jon boat with outboard engine he sometimes dragged out to the reservoir still at roost on its trailer. Jimmy's lifelike punching dummy erect in a corner, the captain's cap Ally placed on it before moving to New York still sideways, the way Jimmy replaced it after every workout now.

He flipped the garage light off, made sure the door was secured, unpacked the rental truck and took his gear into the main residence. Inside, he opened the windows from living room to kitchen, air coming down from the foothills smoke-scented and full of sage but cooling. Brought his gun to the bathroom and rested it on the floor tiles next to the porcelain tub. Took a shower so hot that when he finally turned off the water his body was the scalded red of a boiled lobster. Condensed steam dripped down the walls—he'd purposely left the overhead fan off; it was loud, concealed too many sounds. He wanted to be sharp.

By eleven o'clock, Jimmy'd typed up a cursory report on the Impala investigation and Dropboxed it to the adjuster with the photographs and video he'd taken. Would eventually drop Tio Flores' binder to the adjuster, too, but the theft and fire investigations were now of little concern to Jimmy beyond their influence on his rapidly imploding world. At this point, it was easy to rationalize not giving a flying fuck about whether or not the senator's daughter had inflated her claim.

He turned the lights dark in his kitchen. In only the glow from a streetlamp outside he unlocked the wheels of his refrigerator and rolled it forward on the hardwood planks, revealing a thirty-inch square floor safe he'd custom-installed with concrete reinforcements between floor joists.

Jimmy cycled through the combo. With hooked fingers, pulled back the heavy steel lid. Among items he'd long ago tucked-away were two gallon-sized freezer bags, one holding \$75,000 in neatly bundled get-out cash and another with an unloaded .22 revolver.

Both bags were wrapped with duct tape that'd browned with age while protecting against flooding.

Into the safe he now dropped a Ziploc sandwich bag Gorilla-taped across the seal to protect the folded deed he'd swiped from the Greyhound station. Jimmy stared at the ancient .22 in his safe, felt a heavy sadness. *Fucking decades, he'd had it. The .22 and sadness both.* Maybe one day he would look at the gun and feel nothing, but it was equally possible Jimmy'd die before that day's arrival, the .22 steely in its crypt beneath Jimmy's kitchen floor.

He slept feverishly that night, eventually dreamed of a long-ago evening at the motel smoking his mother's Pall Malls under moonlight on the rooftop above his room. He was twelve, his tennis shoes dangling over the edge while he eavesdropped on the sex worker next door, a white woman named Reba who'd stayed with them all summer.

Reba's bathroom window was open. Jimmy could hear the mattress weeping, the sex lasting twenty minutes. He smoked two more cigarettes in the silence afterward. Eventually heard loud snoring, sat upright when the woman called out his name in a whisper, but like men in war movies calling to each other at night in the trenches.

"Jimmy, I can smell your smoke," she said. "I need you to come help me, only the door is bolted. Can you get through the window there?"

Jimmy scooted his rear end across the roof to the woman's bathroom window.

He flipped onto his tummy, hung by his fingertips from the roofline. Through the screen, he could see the woman tied four-point, a large man asleep on top, testicles showing from behind.

"Can you get into the room?" the woman asked.

"I have to get a ladder." Jimmy let go and dropped onto dried weeds that poked his palms when he rolled. He came back with a ladder from the utility shed and popped the screen with the switchblade he'd been carrying since Christmas. Once inside, Jimmy cut away the ropes from her arms and ankles. Reba shimmied from underneath.

“This is *not* how it’s supposed to look between people,” the woman said.

“I know that.”

When he got back to his room, Jimmy cried for an hour straight.

In the morning, he watched the man walk across Chinden Boulevard to the breakfast diner. The ladder was still out back. Jimmy broke into the man’s room through the screen again. On the bed, a suitcase was neatly packed for checkout. Jimmy unzipped it and found eight hundred dollars rolled into a sock.

He took the money, balled the sock, zipped it back inside. He exited through the window, refit the screen, replaced the ladder in the utility shed.

Later that day, Jimmy sat by the river behind one of the trailer parks. He smoked cigarettes and counted the eight hundred dollars. Wanted to give the money to Reba.

He looked down at the cash in his hands, wondered about sex. When he gazed up again, the tall, dried grass beside him was on fire from one of his butts. A breeze crossed his face, blowing the fire into a swath as long as his body, then double in size, then triple within seconds.

He sprung away from the spreading fire. Impulsively, Jimmy rolled the money tightly into his hand, sprinted in the opposite direction of the flames. He was a half mile through the woods when he turned and saw billows of smoke rising above the river.

Even in dreams decades later Jimmy recognized the twenty-foot stretch of cottonwoods that’d gone charcoal black, ghostlike and tangy from the fire like a trail of bodies leaning alongside the river when he rode his bike past them the following week.

One of the miracles of life, Jimmy knew, was the phenomenon of memory; over thirty years later, even in sleep—no, especially in sleep—he could smell the charred hardwood trunks buckled against one another, smell the perfume and testosterone across Reba’s naked body smudged by sex in the lamplit motel room. The dream and Jimmy’s awareness were crocheted together, memory

and real life at play. Memory was beautiful, he knew, but could also be a curse.

He awoke at four in the morning, the dream dissipating, to the grating sound of the aluminum framed screen on his kitchen window sliding off its track. His pulse raced. He stood from bed, grabbed his 9mm, carried it slowly through the house, careful to avoid stepping where the floorboards would creak. He found no sign of an intruder.

Through the kitchen window he could see his rear neighbor's sycamore tree dropping leaves in a swirling wind from the foothills. Jimmy went outside, found the rectangular screen lying in the boxelders beneath the window frame. Saw no footprints or broken branches. From a few houses down, heard an engine start, but the car was idling, not pulling away in a hurry.

Later that morning, a Saturday, Jimmy had lunch with Jennifer Hope, an old colleague, now one of his few close friends. They met at Juniper on 8th Street, near the old Farmers Market.

Jennifer was a liturgist for the Roman Catholic Diocese of Idaho. It was her job to study, translate, and enforce the language and message of the pope throughout each parish in the state. She also did "paperwork up the wazoo," according to her unofficial resume, as explained over cocktails when Jimmy'd first met her years ago. Jennifer had contracted him to perform background checks on all incoming employees for the church. Jimmy'd immediately found her attractive—black hair pulled back, Irish blue eyes, a remarkable ability to quote scientific facts and obscure poetries equally, way above Jimmy's head.

On more than one occasion, Jimmy and she had entertained the idea of romance, although both had children entering high school, a seeming obstacle. Neither Jimmy nor Jennifer wanting additional distraction during their final years of parenting. More importantly, Jimmy'd been afraid that loving Jennifer faithfully would require a level of sexual honesty she might not endure. Honesty with himself had barely begun.

Those years of Jimmy and Jennifer flirting with a relationship had slipped away. Now they sat beneath a black canvas umbrella spanning their table, shared a hamburger sliced down the middle, drank iced teas. Violating the investigative code of ethics, Jimmy told Jennifer what'd transpired in the past few days. He had nobody else to confide in, and Jennifer often saw what Jimmy couldn't.

"To be clear," Jennifer said to him. "You went to gather documents about a stolen car. In addition to obtaining them, you found the car itself, albeit torched. In the trunk, you found a murdered man you know, but you haven't shared how you know him. That night, you went to bed with the cop working the dead man's case, although your engagement was absent of 'coitus,' as you call it. The cop was then murdered, possibly in your stead. Then you stopped at the bus station, where a man tried to kill you, likely because he failed the night before. Luckily, you got what you call 'the jump' on him. Oh, and there's a boy at a casino, and you simply don't trust him, but you aren't sure why."

Jimmy felt tears forming at the corners of his eyes.

"Are you crying?"

She reached her hand out, touched Jimmy's. They sat like that for what seemed a very long time. Jennifer's hand moved up Jimmy's arm, the sun doing its best to burn a laser-like hole through the canvas umbrella, the temperature cresting one hundred degrees by the time they paid their bill at one o'clock, the asphalt radiating heat into the side of Jimmy's neck.

Just as they were standing, Jennifer asked him, "Have you talked to your claimant yet?"

"No," Jimmy said. Wiped his face. Wondered if the senator's daughter would give him anything but a hard time, what he'd grown accustomed to from the rich.



He pulled the Impala file after lunch, telephoned Greasley's daughter in Sun Valley. Surprisingly accommodating, she offered

Jimmy an appointment that evening and explained that she'd hoped to leave for LA in the coming days. She wouldn't otherwise have time. Jimmy packed a duffel, planned to stay at a hotel in Twin Falls after taking her statement.

The foothills leading past Hailey were dry and rolling, calming in their own way. As he drove, Jimmy reflected on what he knew about the senator's daughter gleaned from Googling.

She had kept her ex-husband's Jewish surname as a means of disassociating from the two years she'd spent in her late teens with the side of her head shaved running ecstasy south of Coeur d'Alene, prior to moving to Los Angeles at twenty. Within a year of doing bit parts in low budget films, she'd married a fifty-year-old television producer named Hiram Lev.

By twenty-five, she was divorced and now appeared to be in ownership of what was once Lev's three-thousand square foot ranch style home in the Pacific Palisades, one of few that'd escaped recent fires. At thirty-one years old she went by Gertie Lev, instead of Gertrude Greasley.

Jimmy reached Sun Valley and the Greasley family "vacation home" an hour before dusk. The sprawling residence was built of milled logs and constructed in the shape of a boomerang on five-acres of forested bluff overlooking the Big Wood River. The concrete approach was a quarter mile long, with a lane in each direction. He swung his rental into the horseshoe-shaped driveway, where a stone fountain feature of intertwined bobcats rose elegantly above a granite coin pool.

Jimmy wondered what the place Zillowed for. *\$20 million, maybe.*

From the window of his truck, he could see dozens of silver dollars shimmering in the bottom of the fountain. A shadow crossed the water as Jimmy stepped onto the concrete, looked up to see Gertie Lev approach in a low-cut, yellow summer dress, hair atop her head with a pencil holding it in place.

She shook Jimmy's hand, the smell of alcohol on her breath when she said, "I was attempting to work out back but I'm in need of a refill, so let's go inside. Do you drink wine?"

“I don’t.”

She turned toward the home, Jimmy following over tiered stonework through an entryway framed with metalwork of another century. When he crossed the threshold, the hair on his forearms lifted. He felt vertiginous, as if leaning over a deep hole in the earth. Gertie turned back when Jimmy’d impulsively placed his hand against the door jamb. He felt the imperfections of it while regaining his balance.

“That’s repurposed iron from one of my father’s old mills,” she told Jimmy. “Mr. Flores custom installed that when I was only a teenager. I remember wishing he would custom install other things, but that’s what lonely children fantasize about.”

The knot got tighter, Jimmy thought. Eventually, it always did.

“I hadn’t been informed of your previous relationship with Tio Flores.”

“I’m informing you now. My father’s done business with Mr. Flores for thirty or forty years. Does it matter?”

Jimmy followed her into a kitchen with a wide view of the river fifty yards below. He could see a stone outbuilding with stained glass lancet windows to either side of a wooden door, possibly a crypt or meditation room, even a living quarters if he stretched his imagination. He stared a moment longer. Something about the lancet windows bothered him.

Gertie Lev pulled a bottle of chardonnay from the refrigerator, filled a stemless wine glass half-full and cupped it in her hand.

“You don’t indulge,” she said casually. “Always in control, I guess. My ex-husband was like that. Same as his friends in the rape scene in Hollywood, but most of them were vampires.”

“I’m not following this,” Jimmy told her.

“The man I married was a sexual deviant. The first time we made love, it was in a coffin. What do you think drives a beautiful young lady into the arms of somebody like that? It can’t be just loneliness.”

She took a long drink from her wine glass.

“I’m sorry to hear about your troubles,” Jimmy broke the silence. “Sometimes life goes a little differently than we plan.

Would you mind if I ask some questions about the Impala?”

“There you go taking control. It doesn’t bother me much. But, you don’t want to know about that car,” she scoffed. “On a Saturday afternoon, you drove here hot from Boise to find out why there’s a target on your back. I honestly don’t think the danger zone you’ve entered has anything to do with my automobile claim, but is there a possibility it has something to do with you bedding my sister—and in a hotel room, no less?”

Jimmy felt he’d been punched in the stomach. Felt his face tingling without air. Consciously inhaled through his nose, exhaled through his mouth, a reset he’d learned from YouTube videos. Gertie’s eyes were unflinching, as if assessing the damage she’d just inflicted.

“Are you telling me that Ayita Smith was your blood relation, Ms. Lev?”

“Tio called me an hour ago and confessed to several of the more predictable sins of my father. I didn’t know of her existence, but that is apparently the truth. Just as apparently, my whole life has been a lie.”

She drank the remaining wine in her glass in one gulp. The reds of her eyes were like tributaries of blood. The expansive kitchen windows overlooking the river and the grassland beyond, and the dome of Bald Mountain in the greater distance were darkening with the hour.

“Did you sleep with my sister on the last night of her life?” Gertie asked.

“No,” Jimmy told her.

“Why not? Was she ugly?”

“No,” Jimmy said, “She was beautiful.”

“I believe you.”

Indirect light filtered softly onto the kitchen wall where a photograph showed an adolescent Gertie Lev holding a long, wooden spoon protruding from a stock pot over a flaming stove in the very kitchen they stood silently within now. Several men stood behind her in the photo happy to oversee. They wore suits, held cocktail glasses in hand. One man looked eerily familiar to Jimmy.

“Ms. Lev,” he uttered. “Who are the people in this photograph?”

She poured herself another glass, a defensive measure, Jimmy could tell, protecting herself against answering his question.

She corked the wine bottle, replaced it inside the refrigerator. Looked at him with wide-open eyes, as if imprinting the memory of Jimmy for future exploitation. Jimmy had seen this look on ex-cons who’d learned that privacy was a privilege earned only by violence. Like them, Gertie Lev seemed capable of killing to protect what was hers, earned or not.

But what was she protecting in a decades-old photograph?

“You’ve probably gotten what you came for,” Gertie told him. “If you need my woman to make you a room, you’re welcome to it. If not, would you mind leaving now?”

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TEN

Gertie had walked Jimmy to the front door. He'd felt vertigo again on his way out.

"Please drive safely," she'd told him. "The deer can be a real nuisance at this hour. Better people than the two of us have been run off that road."

The large, opulent door shut heavily behind him sealing Jimmy out. Gertie Lev had remained inside, also sealed. Jimmy knew immediately that he'd left money on the table with her, so to speak. Yet, she'd provided other information.

If Ayita were Greasley's illegitimate daughter, she would've had survivorship claim to the stadium parcel in the event of his death, sharing those rights with Gertie Lev. Jimmy wondered if Rudolph Hillcrest had been a hard money lender against the property. If so, he must've learned about Ayita in his due diligence process—and someone might've wanted that information to stay hidden, initiating the ruthless murders of Hillcrest and Ayita both. Maybe the two'd been shorn like cheat grass in a path toward clear title to the property, but by whom? Jimmy believed that Gertie Lev had only just learned of Ayita's existence, which ruled her out, and Grisham Greasley was still alive, regardless, so any rights of survivorship were currently meaningless.

Still, it could not have been a coincidence that the Impala tied the two sisters, if they were indeed that, one whose vehicle was allegedly stolen and the other a cop stumbling onto the case, neither woman with previous knowledge of the other. Ayita had held onto the locker key, maybe after learning what Tio Flores might have known for decades—her birthright, what Senator Greasley had known but concealed. Certainly, Greasley's Aryan connections would explain the button man sent after Jimmy—*for what reason?*

Jimmy decided to bypass Twin Falls and drive into the night with oncoming headlights from the eastbound semi-trucks periodically blinding him. He nodded off twice, his pickup veering onto the rumble strips cut into asphalt along the freeway's edge. By midnight, he was back in Boise.

Instead of going directly home, Jimmy drove Chinden Boulevard into Garden City where riverfront property and even trailer park land were now at a premium, but the thoroughfare remained lined with used car lots, commercial strips in need of paint, and the motels where men still exorcised their demons and spilled seed into the bodies of the vulnerable and exploited.

Where his mother's own motel had been was now an RV lemon lot on a fenced half-acre of gravel between the Cash for Car Title storefront and Over 19, the pornography shop where a young woman stood outside smoking a cigarette as Jimmy passed. He circled, pulled his vehicle across Chinden into the asphalt lot of a vape store, faced traffic, killed his headlamps and reminisced.

How many times had Jimmy filmed the drunks, he wondered, who'd stepped unsteadily from their vehicles in search of sex? Without self-awareness, most men seemed unable to empathize with the trauma their bodies imposed upon others in the many low-ceilinged rooms of America, as on this tract, Jimmy's own personalized tract it sometimes seemed, of Chinden Boulevard. The men Jimmy worried about most were the exceedingly polished ones who were sober with resentment and anger from the war zones of their childhoods, control freaks like maybe Gertie Lev was used to, who scrubbed themselves raw in the showers after copulating and left behind wash rags waxy with their DNA. He'd sometimes done the wash himself, knew the stench of perfectionism and self-hate that often reeked of psychopathy, too.

Directly behind the parcel where the motel had been was a compact neighborhood of decaying single-wide homes, some on girders, along a four-block stretch that dead-ended at a wall of concrete rising forty-five feet to another roadway.

Twenty-seven years ago, Jimmy sat on his haunches inside one of those abandoned single-wides, wore rubber garden gloves,

smoked cigarettes down to the butt while contemplating the cylindrical, five-gallon can of gasoline he'd filled and stashed the day before. Then he'd put the Type II industrial can inside his camping backpack, cinched the bag over his shoulders, and carried the weight of it under a starless black sky to the rear of the motel—it'd been emptied for fumigation and a facelift before Hillcrest's proposed grand re-opening.

With a collapsible stepstool from his pack, Jimmy entered each motel room through its rear window, spent twenty minutes using a strike hammer to punch plate-sized holes through the room's adjoining walls. Poured the gasoline across each room, dragging the metal extension hose from hole to hole until the floors of each room and its damaged drywall were sodden. Lugged the gas can out each window and down the line to the next room.

He made a stop inside the motel lobby, hunching to stay out of sight. There things had still felt like home. Even if Hillcrest owned the property now, Jimmy's mother dead but present in spirit, the walls of the room in back stained by nicotine, the shitty carpeting and foam anti-fatigue floor mat his mother used behind the counter—everything in place.

He finally left through a rear window again, transported his backpack to the concrete barrier wall at the rear of the neighborhood, hiked to his Grand Marquis on the shoulder of the road above. Drove a mile to Veteran's Park, changed into his track suit and sneakers in the dark, went for a jog, eventually crossing the alley behind the motel. There he sparked a sixteen-inch road flare and tossed it through an open window onto a mattress soaked with gasoline.

He resumed jogging at a steady pace, cut across Chinden Boulevard at the nearest intersection. Returned on the other side of the street. Hid in the shadows. Caught his breath.

Then he watched.

The room at the center of the motel finally erupted—a box of flames twitching in the night. Then, almost like an eagle of hellfire, Jimmy'd thought, the whole place spread open its wings and took flight.

His tennis shoes soaked with gasoline to the socks, he finally noticed.

Arson had been grueling, physical work. Easy to make mistakes, Jimmy'd guessed at the time. He half-expected to get handcuffed against a cruiser. Didn't care.

He remained in the shadows as two of the larger engines from the Chinden Boulevard fire station arrived minutes later, blocking eastbound traffic. Firemen leapt from their truck cabs, some scampering toward the motel, some dragging hundred-pound hoses.

One of the younger men, things happening so fast his Kevlar shell was still unclipped, was blown into the air by a propane tank at the rear of the motel lobby.

To Jimmy, the man looked like a Halloween decoration in the sky, arms at awkward angles.

He hadn't yet hit the ground when he rose a second time, as if upon an updraft, hovering thirty feet over the pavement with his outstretched arms aflame, thrashing. Then the man was suddenly calm at the upper crest of the explosion. He looked like a burning angel, bright as sunshine against the midnight firmament, a collateral sacrifice Jimmy hadn't counted on.

Jimmy jogged back to his car, sat in the driver's seat all night, waited to be arrested. Imagined the worst about the man's injuries, imagined death—dismal acknowledgment that even angels could be destroyed by earthly transgressions.

If there was a God, then its manifestation had been set ablaze in the sky over Chinden Boulevard that night and across Jimmy's conscience too, the air full of asbestos-laced smoke, and the young man a fiery effigy bouncing between currents like a party balloon.

In the morning, full of fear and remorse, Jimmy drove nine hours to the Oregon coast, drank heavily, and slept in his car for a week. He had three thousand dollars in the bank, could have made it across the world with that.

Instead, he returned to Idaho, married the first woman he met, became a cop.

The drinking lasted ten more years. When his wife finally left, Jimmy put the bottle away. Hadn't forgiven himself for the firefighter's injuries but, for the sake of his children, decided to live.

Now the RV lot that'd replaced the motel had become a point of curiosity for him. He often wondered why Rudolph Hillcrest hadn't simply rebuilt a better, newer motel, why an arson investigation hadn't led back to Jimmy, the most obvious suspect. Why the land had been graveled over, left undeveloped for almost three decades.

Occasionally, Jimmy parked in this very spot, cut his lights like tonight, paid the penance of reflection. Now, for the first time in many years, he wondered idly about the unknown prostitute who'd likely brought him into the world before setting him onto the lobby floor of the motel for another woman to hold. *The life she must have endured to get to that point.*

Just after two in the morning, Jimmy turned on his headlamps to go home. They shined wide and high in a cone of halogens across the Boulevard where Jimmy saw the silhouette of a man whose stature was similar to Jimmy's, watched the man transect the alley behind the RV lot, a paper bag in his hand that seemed weighted by a bottle. The dead and the living sought their twins on the other side, Jimmy thought—wondered if the man were his own, an omen as Jimmy's old and new worlds unexpectedly interplayed.

He was pulling westbound onto Chinden Boulevard, trying to make sense of the bodies that'd stacked up, when his cell vibrated in the cup holder—a restricted number.

Jimmy turned north onto 42nd Street, answering over the console's SYNC function.

"It's Braxton Gooding. Did I wake you?" The voice was a foghorn echoing in the F-150 and Jimmy wished like hell he'd caught any other investigation than this one.

"It's the middle of the night," Jimmy said territorially. "But no."

“Alright.” Gooding paused, then added, “We had a robbery at the casino out here about two hours ago. A boy I think you know, Brody Hawkstellar, is dead now. Took six bullets in the chest from an AR-15 while working his shift. I thought I should tell you.”

Jimmy pulled his truck onto the shoulder and parked it hard. The Fort Hall police usually kept their crimes internal—the reservation under no jurisdiction but its own. If they called for backup from Pocatello, it’s because they were in the shit.

“Brody Hawkstellar and my daughter went to school together,” Jimmy said. “How did you learn about our association?”

“The kid had a cocktail napkin in his front pocket that read, ‘To do list: Jimmy Chinden.’ What do you think he meant by that?”

“I suspected he was using the casino as a transportation hub for illegal goods, maybe even for a cartel. I confronted him but he didn’t give up anything. And it wasn’t any of my business to even think about.”

“Police work being reserved for the police, generally speaking,” Gooding agreed. “But Hawkstellar trafficking drugs would at least partially explain the half-dozen ARs that ran through here tonight. Or trafficking who-knows-what. Anyway, I’m here now, and the video looks like pande-fucking-monium. Big time.”

“Was anybody else injured?”

“Nope. If you’re right about Hawkstellar, maybe it was a hit? That, and the shrink-wrapped sixteen million they carted from the casino vault in duffels probably didn’t hurt much for motive.”

“Is there anything else you can tell me?”

“Not without embarrassing myself. You’ve aged well, you know.”

A pause. Then Gooding hung up.



Jimmy drove straight home, where he found Detective Abbiati waiting for him behind the wheel of a black-on-black Chevy Tahoe parked in the street beneath the canopy of a century-old maple

tree that'd been planted when the house was built. He parked in his driveway, got out of his vehicle as the Tahoe's passenger-side window lowered and Abbiati told him, "We heard from Gooding out on the res. Get in for a minute."

Jimmy looked at his house, buttoned up, no lights on inside. He crossed the lawn and scooted into the passenger seat of the Tahoe, shut the door with an accidental thud, his body too tired to be graceful at this hour.

"It's two-thirty in the morning," Jimmy said. "I've been to Sun Valley and back in one day. I'm exhausted, Detective. And I'm confused about your presence here."

"Don't be a dick," Abbiati said. "It's the middle of the night for us, too."

He showed Jimmy a series of digital crime scene photographs that'd been emailed to his iPhone from Braxton Gooding. In them, Hawkstellar's chest looked like a bowl of spaghetti. The boy's eyes were as big as fried eggs, having bulged with adrenaline before he died.

"You think you're confused?" Abbiati asked. "The Hawkstellar kid looks like somebody asked him to solve the Riemann hypothesis, I think it's called. What do you notice about the scene?"

Jimmy scrolled through the photos again. In the wide shot, Brody Hawkstellar appeared flat on his back, arms outstretched in a fan of blood soaking into the decades-old carpeting, a cocktail glass toppled onto its side near the body.

"He doesn't appear to have brandished a weapon," Jimmy said.

"Bingo," Abbiati said. "I don't think these people like to wait around for pushback."

"I told Gooding I saw Brody Hawkstellar in the passenger seat of a long-haul semi-truck. I think Tio Flores was driving it. I pegged Hawkstellar to be running a transport, but he was evasive when I challenged him," Jimmy said. "Maybe that pharma route I mentioned to you really is clogged, but I've heard of other routes from Jalisco up to Canada through the Detroit side. If the East Coast isn't the destination, maybe it's the Midwest."

“We have no proof of that.”

“Your sixteen million could be Mexican cartel money,” Jimmy said. “Could the casino be in the laundry business?”

“We’re focused on what we know,” Abbiati insisted. “Although I see your logic. That shithole in Fort Hall has no viable reason to be holding sixteen million on reserve unless they’d washed it and were waiting to deliver it elsewhere.” He paused. “But pretend you’re right. That’d mean the Aryans didn’t just rob a few Indians, they might’ve robbed the cartel, and that’s a pond you don’t sink your balls into lightly.”

“How do you know it was Aryans?”

“Study the photos, Bub. Who else runs around with ski masks, AR-15s, and tattoos that say ‘Aryan’?”

Jimmy’d been transfixed by Hawkstellar’s shot-up body in the photos, hadn’t examined the masked men with arms painted in prison ink. He scratched at his sternum where the crescent-shaped laceration left by his altercation with Sandy Billings had scabbed-over. Nazi Swastikas had peeked from Billings’ shirtsleeves, although alliance with white supremacy was common in eastern Idaho and didn’t tie Billings to the armed robbery or Hawkstellar’s death.

“I’m just showing you a dead body so maybe you get right and tell us what really went down at the Greyhound station,” Abbiati finally added. “Want to amend your spotlessly constructed narrative of events from earlier?”

“Not at this time.”

“Copy that,” Abbiati said. “At the very least, I don’t think you should stay here tonight. Bodies are falling around you like pollen, Jimbo. Do you own another residence we don’t know about, maybe a cabin you can stay at?”

“No.”

“Hm,” Abbiati sighed. “Well, until we figure out what the fuck is going on, find yourself a hideout and pull the blankie over it.”



Jimmy knocked on Jennifer Hope's door, her motion-sensitive security light blinding him on the porch. He'd already woken her with a phone call, conscious of the 3:00 a.m. hour.

She unlocked the deadbolt, let Jimmy inside. He set down his duffel and removed his shoes. Jennifer wore linen pajama bottoms and a t-shirt from San Jose State, her daughter's alma mater.

She took Jimmy's hand and led him to the couch, where he sat as heavy as a marble statue on the cushions before toppling sideways in a lump.

He drifted, half dreaming already. He remembered himself singing to his kindergarten-aged daughter, her cotton onesie with glow-in-the-dark crescent moons across it and her small body curled beneath Jimmy's arm on the couch while he soothed her to sleep. Jimmy's wife had been in the kitchen rinsing dishes after a long weekend of them piling up, their family still in one piece and his infant son already asleep in the crib one room over.

The HVAC system had been humming and his daughter's large brown eyes eventually closed while the words had come out of Jimmy unplanned:

*Star light, star bright,
lonely star awake tonight;
Angel burning, angel bright,
no more stars awake tonight.*

The song had been softer than the traditional nursery rhyme, sadder—beneath the words were a memory of loss from the evening before, when Jimmy'd been trolling Chinden Boulevard for a juvenile missing persons junkie. Eventually found the boy overdosed behind the Chevron station, one of the kid's arms extended beneath a garbage dumpster as if he'd lost something.

Jimmy had shined his flashlight under the dumpster and seen a cigarette lighter in the kid's fingertips. That's how you died, Jimmy'd thought, reaching for a ninety-cent Bic. He'd runaway

only two months before, right after his father'd found him with a kid from the wrestling team.

Jimmy had let his daughter fall asleep then allowed himself to weep. *My God*, Jimmy'd thought. There had been enough opioids in the boy to sink a house.

Jimmy startled beneath his blanket now, daylight slanting horizontally through wooden blinds, the smell of dark roasted beans and the sound of a drip pot from the kitchen. He walked through the empty house, poured himself a coffee, found Jennifer on the small patio out back where jade trees with leaves as brawny as steaks swelled from terra cotta pots and two hummingbirds did the electric slide across a xeriscaped flower bed full of bees and morning sun.

Jennifer was reading the *Idaho Statesman* on her iPad when Jimmy sat down at the whitewashed iron table he'd helped her drag from a swap meet years ago.

"Anything good in there?" he asked, deflecting from the obvious *faux pas* of having barged in overnight.

"Four kids are going to jail for selling pot. The article repeatedly calls them 'men' but they're only eighteen, and I'll bet each of them still has a mother washing their dishes. Those boys don't belong locked up, especially when pot is perfectly legal an hour away."

She sighed, set the iPad aside, and added, "Oh, and apparently the Fort Hall casino was robbed and the boy you told me about murdered in cold blood. I am so frustrated at you right now, but I don't know why. What is happening?"

Jimmy told her what'd transpired since their lunch the day before. He left out only his casual surveillance of the RV lot, which seemed inconsequential.

Jennifer's interest was especially piqued by Gertie Lev.

"She said she was 'working' when you got there, although she obviously doesn't have to. Rich women take tremendous pride in sharpening their pencils. When I still had my membership, I played tennis against those Sun Valley gals. They love to mention how close they feel to the landscape. At a million bucks an acre, I'd

feel damned close, too. For them, 'living off the land' is a euphemism for infinite lines of credit against the appreciation. Does she have an actual career?"

"I didn't get a chance to ask."

"Is she attractive?"

"To most people, probably."

"Then she's used to getting what she wants, which might be a concern. Beautiful women are often pathological, regardless of their work ethic."

"I think the money gets her more than the looks, Jen." Jimmy smiled. "If you're fishing for compliments, think back to the hundreds you've already caught from me."

"I had to try again," she laughed.

She sipped from her coffee, flicked a bee with the back of her hand then added, "Either way, this Gertie seems like a wildcard. Who consents to sex in a coffin unless they're fetishizing death? I'm not a prude, but there's a limit."

Jimmy stared across the table for a long time, said to her finally, "You and I are very similar. I've always appreciated that. Do you think it was a mistake to remain friends...instead of dating?"

"Only on the loneliest of holidays," she quipped, but Jimmy didn't laugh.

"You're vulnerable right now, Jimmy. That's rare for you, so you're trying to identify what it means. Everything is happening at once, and you don't know why. Underneath it all, you miss your children. I know this because I miss mine. Every day begins with a broken heart, and if you can find the right person then it ends with a hug. But the right person Jimmy, not the first person. Let's try not to be each other's coffins, okay?"

He hesitated then told her, "Understood."

There was nothing more to dissect. For obvious reasons, Jimmy had been feeling pressure. He didn't need to project it onto Jennifer. She was right, as always.

"Another thing has been bothering me," he said. "When I left my house yesterday, I set the vacation timer. From 10:00 p.m. to

3:00 a.m. the living room light would normally glow, but the house was dark when I got home before three.”

“Did you tell that cop...Abbiati?”

“No.”

“I’m sorry you have so much going on, Jimmy. And I’m extremely sorry about the woman from a few nights ago—Ayita? Mostly, I’m very scared for you.”

They ate a late breakfast of scrambled eggs with sliced tomatoes that came from a garden pot. Jimmy wished that one day he’d feel complete joy—the sky was blue, the hummingbirds danced, and the sunlight bathed him in Vitamin D, but he felt he’d spent a lifetime masking happiness, pretending, just to get by. *Did everyone do that?* He knew the answer was probably no, that he was most often alone in his melancholy. He daydreamed of his children being young again and in his arms. And the many bodies, as Abbiati had suggested, filtered through the air like pollen—Jimmy could see them dithering in the sunlight that bathed the crown of Jennifer’s hair.

“What am I missing, Jen?” he asked.

“I hope not a lot.” She wiped her lips with a paper napkin. “What more could there be?”

Jimmy’s cell vibrated on the iron table. It was Gertie Lev. He took the call.

“I’ve just been told that my nephew was murdered at the casino last night.” Her voice sounded like the bottom of a boat dragging across a sand bar.

“Ayita Smith had no children,” Jimmy said.

“Brody was Evelyn’s kid.”

Jimmy could hear Gertie Lev light a cigarette, inhale, and then blow the smoke out.

“The senator’s press secretary is your sister, Ms. Lev?”

“Since the day I was born. Although you’d never know it from reading the papers. Other than the Bear River Massacre, my father’s penchant for squaws might be the State of Idaho’s greatest secret. I said I was going to Los Angeles but not anymore. Can you come back to Sun Valley? You’re the only man since my

divorce who's been alone with me in a room and hasn't tried to pull my dress off."

"I don't think I can do that."

"I don't feel safe right now, Mr. Chinden. And if I'm not safe, nobody is."

Jimmy heard the line go dead. He set the phone aside and looked up at Jennifer, whose eyes were as big and blue as jawbreakers.

"She says she's Brody Hawkstellar's aunt. She asked me to come back to Sun Valley."

"I don't want you anywhere near that woman, Jimmy. I have Mass at eleven. Can I trust you to be here when I get back?"

Jimmy tried to process what more he'd learned about Gertie Lev from his visit. She had spoken of a sexual attraction to Tio Flores, yet the man was a possible dumpster fire. And Jimmy'd felt foreboding since noticing the windows of Tio's residence were closed-off—hadn't he felt the same when looking at Gertie's outbuilding with lancet windows, viewed from her kitchen? And she had said "my woman" when referring to making him a room, the language slightly off from any vernacular that didn't extend to slave owners or misogynists.

The sun had shifted slightly. It funneled through a twenty-foot pink and white magnolia tree whose leaves, Jimmy imagined, were the wafers and bodies of Christ placed in believer's palms each week in the communion process Jennifer often spoke of, but by autumn the leaves would curl—by winter they'd be mulch. What did that say of Christ, of any of us?

Gertie had told him that nobody was safe. Had she merely been expressing her concern? Worse, had she been threatening him?

Jimmy dialed his daughter's burner.

Sometime between two days ago and now, the number had gone dead.

ELEVEN

Jimmy left Jennifer's bungalow immediately after her departure for Mass, sunlight half-blinding him through the windshield of his truck, his heart pounding off-tempo and hard when he cut a curb and the sidewall of his tires braced against concrete.

He'd left two messages with Abbiati, waiting to hear back. Abbiati was maybe still connected at NYPD and Jimmy was hoping to track his daughter's burner to the last cell towers it'd pinged.

On 28th Street, Jimmy saw a roadkill squirrel pressed flat, body and earth merging into a singular form. Ally's dead burner meant *what*, he wondered—that she'd run out of pre-paid minutes or that Jimmy was running out of time to understand the roiling war zone he'd entered?

He refused to imagine the violence of an unjust world overtaking either of his children, yet hadn't he always imagined it anyway but only non-visually, in the darkest of intuitions?

He parked his truck in the driveway at home, went inside and stripped for a quick shower, walked across the hardwood in bare feet that'd crossed these same thirteen paces from bed to bath many thousands of times over the years—dry going in, wet coming out.

The living bodies of Jimmy's children had passed from room to room as well, their growing feet carving subtle grooves, wearing down the polyurethane sheen to create a map of family activity; the wear patterns in hardwood flooring indicated size, trajectory, and ambition of its passengers. The body always left a mark—fingerprint technology showed that moisture from the human hand debossed even metal surfaces after only one touch. Where traditional dusting for prints failed, evidence of life was nevertheless permanent, could be extracted and understood.

To this end, when the loneliness accompanying Jimmy's adjustment to empty-nesting became almost unendurable, he sometimes lay on his back in the three-foot-wide hallway, the undulations of his family's shared foot traffic calming, as if he were floating at sea. Those times, he would have given the past five years of his life to have the first five of his children's years returned to him. Evidence of life—memory alone—was nothing like life, after all.

He set his weapon and cell inside a folded towel next to the tub, ran the shower hot and sat beneath it, a habit he'd picked up from his ex-wife in her waitressing years when she'd preferred shaving her legs sitting down. Were his fears about his daughter's safety mere anxiety, an obsessive, intrusive thought similar to his fear that a spray of bullets would one day shred the mildew-resistant shower liner just above his head? Or, he wondered, were his fears for Ally's life a dark communique, a clairvoyance of impending evil?

He heard his cell ringing, leaned over the ledge and pulled it from the towel. It was Abbiati. Jimmy cut the shower and stepped out wet. Answered his phone, heartbeat thumping.

"I can hear the tiles playing handball with your voice," Abbiati told him. "If you're sitting on the pot, call me back."

Jimmy didn't appreciate the casual nature of Abbiati's tone, nor the implication.

"You're talking to me like a cop working a case, instead of a guy helping another guy find his child," he told Abbiati.

There was a pause on the other end.

"Go ahead," Abbiati said.

Jimmy explained his daughter's situation with the burner, asking Abbiati to connect with old partners in Queens. Hoped that somewhere in the New York City boroughs would be a triangulation point leading to Ally. Even if she'd made no recent calls, the IMSI number of the actual phone was in constant contact with towers, Jimmy's daughter wrongly assuming her burner offered true anonymity.

“Hell,” Abbiati said, “Even if she doesn’t have her phone anymore, she might have topped off her minutes recently. We can trace the phone card to a point of purchase, maybe the corner bodega. Might find her pulling a Mountain Dew from the back cooler.”

“Do you still have suction with NYPD?”

“Who knows,” he said. Jimmy could hear the man clearing his throat before adding, “Text me her number and give me twenty minutes. I’ll make some calls.”

Jimmy hung up and sat on the edge of the bath, sent Abbiati Ally’s phone number. The terrycloth towel beside his feet was slightly ruffled. The barrel of his 9mm nosed out beside drops of water on the tiling, reminiscent of blood splatter.

He had a bad, subsurface feeling stemming from Abbiati’s speech intonations on the phone just now, another full-second pause between sentences that alerted Jimmy to... *what, Abbiati’s insecurities about lack of sway with NYPD?*

Jimmy’d always been relatively good at gauging the social temperature of a room or the flow of deception in individual interactions, but the reasons for each were varied. He wondered what was moving the needle for him now, couldn’t land on anything beyond Abbiati’s temperament being generally erratic, the same characteristic that’d helped the man understand bad guys so well.

An hour later, Abbiati still hadn’t called him back, however. Jimmy didn’t want to wait. He stuffed his passport, two 9mm clips, several changes of clothing, and a toiletry kit into a black duffel he’d taken on surveillance trips for the past several years. He checked the living room light timer—it appeared to be working—and secured the remainder of the house.

It was after the noon hour. The only remaining flight to New York City departed at five a.m. the next day, cost almost two thousand dollars on short notice, but Jimmy was prepared to book it. Even at two grand, it wasn’t soon enough. Nothing was, not for any parent watching the clock that measured not just time but window for risk when their children went unaccounted for.

After an excruciating ninety minutes, Abbiati finally called. Didn't have the news Jimmy'd hoped for.

"All I got from Queens was a reminder from my old sergeant that I still owe him a C-note from Super Bowl Twenty-nine. This was not a profitable correspondence for me," Abbiati said, dragging on a cigarette, exhaling as Jimmy heard a car door close.

"You seem to be taking this very lightly," Jimmy said sharply, wishing his words were the butt-end of his pistol across Abbiati's head. "My daughter could be in danger, Detective."

"Copy that, but I can't subpoena a Telecom company on speculation. Your daughter's a grown woman who might've simply cancelled her coverage." Jimmy heard him click his seatbelt, the engine start, the windows roll down. "If it were my own kid, I'd probably be loading rounds, but that's why I keep a woman in my life, Chinden, to calm me the fuck down. I'm deep in paperwork over this case, but I promise I'll do everything in..."

Jimmy hung up.

Paperwork?

Took a deep breath to steady himself, the veins of his neck pulsing rapidly, a physical idiosyncrasy he'd passed to his daughter, whose slight frame betrayed the staccato of a heartbeat between collar bones during her fluctuations in mood. Most people wouldn't have noticed but Jimmy saw clearly when his daughter loved, hated, or worried greatly. It was somewhat poetic—he knew Ally not just by her words but the patterns of blood flow from her heart.

In other ways, it broke Jimmy's own heart to see how often his daughter felt the stress of living in a world primarily owned and destroyed by men. One of the shames of Jimmy's life was that he'd sometimes added to Ally's anxiety by losing control of his anger when she was a little girl, Jimmy's voice like a sledgehammer he'd swung through the walls of the house on occasion, if by accident, sometimes triggered by the overload on his senses, hardly her fault. The phone might ring, the television run too loudly, the clothing dryer banging repeatedly as Jimmy felt the steam building between his ears, then confusion and panic that turned to

adrenaline, like fighting his way out of a tangled bedsheet. He'd been too young a man to raise his children patiently those first few years, but it took being an older man to know this.

He called Braxton Gooding in Pocatello.

The phone rang twice. Gooding answered through a mouthful of food, and Jimmy explained the situation with his daughter, told him how Abbiati had struck out with New York.

"That's surprising," Gooding said. "Exigent circumstances should have allowed a subpoena for the burner records by piggybacking onto the Boise case. Somebody tried to kill a young lady's father and now she's M.I.A."

"Tried to kill me twice," Jimmy corrected, hopeful.

"I'm not in the habit of stoking gratuitous fires," Gooding said. "But there's every reason to believe your daughter could be in danger."

"Can you help me with this?"

"I'm heading back from lunch. Text me your daughter's number. I'll wrap it into our car bomb investigation and fire-out an affidavit for subpoena within the hour. There's a few judges who still work Sundays if you pay 'em in barbecue. And we do that all summer."

"I'd really appreciate that," Jimmy said. "Thank you."

He almost lost his mind waiting, after that.

He did push-ups, sit-ups, drank a glass of water, sat on the floor of Ally's old bedroom with his back against the sideboards of her bed frame. The poster of the band Tegan and Sara, which she'd tacked to her wall at fifteen, nearly made him cry. It had been ten years, but he could still hear Ally's CDs playing in the room, remembered all the times her door was shut while she sobbed—people who believed homosexuality was a choice had never lived with a daughter fractured by societal rejection, had never found an overdosed boy beside a dumpster, the cigarette lighter in his fingertips being the last thing he'd held.

The only part of Jimmy's daughter being gay that'd been her choice was to keep living despite the hatred dispatched toward the queer community, despite all the rhetorical weapons that

organized religion, corporate marketing campaigns, radicalized buffoons, and cowardly, lard-lipped politicians provided to assist in their deaths.

It was fitting that his daughter now made a career out of fighting for her life. The article she wrote for *The Times* last year exposed the Alt Right's neo-fascist, internet-based information warfare and radicalization of the New Hitler Ninety, a syndicate of middle-class, middle-America brats who turned to thuggery out of boredom at having been given the world without working for it.

When death threats came, followed by a suspicious package bearing a faulty toothpaste bomb full of gel explosive, Ally packed a go-bag and left her known associates behind. It was a month before she'd told Jimmy why. Now, here he was with his own go-bag at the ready.

If he had confided about his own sexuality, told her while she was still a teenager, might that have assuaged Ally's pain or made it worse? The burden of thinking about her father's intimate life was not exactly the top of any daughter's wish list, he'd decided.

The truth was Jimmy didn't care to think about it either, if doing so interrupted the duties of daily life. *There were too many things mattering more*, like his police work in the beginning, packing lunches for his children or driving them to their martial arts lessons, or his recent years of surveilling the deadbeats who'd driven fists through spouses and children—the work wasn't glamorous, but Jimmy's sexuality, whatever the fuck that even meant, came second to loving his family, or helping people out of a jam. He felt no remorse from placing the needs of the defenseless before his own—That's what a man *did*, he thought. And he'd spent the last few decades busy at that.

Only once had he investigated his sexuality clinically, with a psychiatrist in her small office above one of Boise's downtown coffee shops.

"What am I?" he'd bluntly asked.

"You're a pansexual hetero-romantic. It means you only love women, but the rest doesn't scare you off. I recommend you stop hiding."

"I'm not hiding. I just don't talk about it."

"Why not?"

"Because it might hurt my children."

The psychiatrist shifted her legs, crossed her feet in front. She wore grey slacks with bright yellow Hoka running shoes.

"Your daughter might benefit from your honesty," she suggested.

"Or might not. I think I'll just leave it alone."

And so he had.

Gooding called Jimmy back mid-afternoon.

"There's good news about your daughter, sort of. The last number she dialed went to Shindad Air Base in Herat Province, Afghanistan. The call lasted less than two minutes."

"My son is in Afghanistan," Jimmy said. "At a combat outpost just east of the Iranian border." Jimmy's eyes swelled with tears before he added, "I think."

"Well, the part you don't want to hear is that the call wasn't placed from New York City but Detroit. She was on the move, or somebody'd moved her before the phone went dead." Gooding exhaled hard. "You said you thought Brody Hawkstellar might have been running a transport. Did Abbiati happen to mention there's a Mexican pharmaceutical leg running from Fort Hall to Motown?"

"I brought it up to him myself. Are you suggesting a drug cartel has my daughter?"

"I'm suggesting it wouldn't be the first time somebody asked that question. Ransom kidnappings are Chapter One in 'How to Run a Successful Cartel.' As soon as we get off, I'll text the location of the last tower she pinged. I'm no urban ethnologist, but Detroit's east side seems a long way from home. My own son was in Afghanistan for two tours, by the way. He came back alive and in one piece, makes eighty-five a year working for the nuclear lab in Idaho Falls. I thought you might want to hear that. I know I would've liked hope when he was away. They do come home."

One way or another, Jimmy thought. But the words were too painful to speak aloud.

“Oh, and I almost forgot to tell you,” Gooding said. “ISP found bomb-making materials in Brody Hawkstellar’s apartment, but the door had a busted locking mechanism.”

“So ISP thinks it was planted?”

“When have you ever known state police to think out loud?”

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TWELVE

Jimmy made a call he wished hadn't been necessary. By seven o'clock in the evening he was pulling into the airport just outside of Hailey, where Gertie Lev waited on a runway next to her family-owned Lear 55 business jet.

A single red light on the airplane's belly blinked like a beacon in the heat waves off the concrete as Jimmy approached with his duffel in hand, his pickup behind him inside the Greasley private hangar.

Gertie had agreed to transport Jimmy to Detroit, commercial flights booked solid the same as New York. No options, but this one—and Gertie happy to pay the ten grand in fuel costs in exchange for what she'd referred to as Jimmy's "temporary protection and overwhelmingly-platonic companionship." She also seemed truly afraid.

Jimmy's sternum vibrated on takeoff. At ten thousand feet, he stared down on the millions of acres of mountain range that within a century had been parceled and wrapped like meat by the billionaires and their offspring who owned everything now.

Separated by a polished hardwood cocktail bar built into the fuselage, Gertie sat across from Jimmy in jeans, a pair of brown mid-calf leather boots laced up the front, and a long-sleeved floral blouse with the top three buttons undone.

From a simple gold chain around her neck, a pendant of a small hummingbird swung freely when Gertie leaned to open the credenza, removed a single-serving bottle of white wine. She filled her glass, took a sip, rested the base on her knee. Stared out the window.

Looked at Jimmy, eventually.

"I want to thank you for asking for my help," Gertie said. "I know you don't trust me. From your mannerisms, you don't trust anybody with wealth, and I don't blame you for that. Tio used to

tell me that everybody really alive is only stampeding over the bodies of the dying. Isn't that something? That's how riches are accumulated, too, in a mad dash across corpses."

"It's not that I don't trust you," Jimmy said. "But that I don't trust needing you. A woman I'd begun to care for and now Mr. Hawkstellar are both dead, my daughter is missing, and there have been multiple attempts on my life."

"Do you think my family has blood on its hands?"

"If it does, I don't blame you personally for that."

"But you expect me to understand the alarm bells going off, and I do," Gertie said. "I'd never heard of Ayita Smith before this week, so I don't feel either profit or a great sense of loss from her death, although I am very concerned about what happened to my nephew."

"Concern isn't the usual expression of grief," Jimmy told her.

"I'm not a sociopath, if that's what you're implying. I just didn't know Brody very well, as my father has always driven wedges where he sees fit. Evelyn and I don't speak often. I suppose she appears to be my father's favorite because she works for him, but sometimes I think squeezing her close is my father's way of punishing Evelyn for raising a child out of wedlock. She had a husband long enough to take his name, but Evelyn never enjoyed the company of men. I've wished lesbianism ran deeper in our family—I didn't luck out, although there is evidence that it's genetic."

She stared at Jimmy an uncomfortably long time.

Jimmy said, "Are you asking me something?"

"I wouldn't do that," she told him.

Gertie finished her wine in a pull then set aside the glass.

"And just so you know, the Impala was a labor of love which Tio and I both worked tirelessly on. It really was stolen out of the auction yard, or so I thought, which hurt me deeply. Maybe it looks bad that I owed Tio money on it but that's not high stakes. You have to remember, forty-grand to my family is like your own family neglecting the utility bill for a month, and I don't mean that as an insult."

“Are you aware of Mr. Flores being heavily in debt himself?”

“He lost money on some bad housing projects during the crash, although in Tio’s words it’s not debt if you refuse to pay.”

“What would you call it, then?”

“Come-and-get-it numbers.”

She gazed out the window. The light was soft against her cheekbones, one of which had a faded chicken pox scar the shape of a small kidney bean, barely visible when she turned back to him.

Gertie considered Jimmy for a long moment, said to him, “I would like you to understand, since we’re traveling companions, that I don’t need to steal things. I am a generous person, which is why you’re on this plane. And I have a bigger heart than you think, which is why I’ve accompanied you. I can offer you additional resources, should you need them while attempting to locate your daughter. I don’t like the idea of people getting murdered because of something my family might be into, if that’s what’s happening. I am also very easily wounded, so please be nice to me, Jimmy. I don’t deserve more hostility in my life.”

She was right to insinuate that he’d been cruel, had lumped Gertie into the pages of a case file in his mind, as Abbiati had done to Jimmy, but with no proof of her wrongdoing, not even related to the Impala. If not for the current circumstances, how would Jimmy have viewed her?

“I’m truly sorry,” he said. “I’ve never been the best at letting go of ideas.”

“I believe you. Thank you.”

Jimmy asked, “Why else are you here?”

“I’ve been living in a very big house full of demons. Some of its timber is a thousand years old, and I hear it creaking at night. I’d think it was a prowler, but history is more complex than that. Frankly, I’m scared shitless of being alone right now.”

She unlaced her boots, slipped them off, curled her feet into her lap and closed her eyes. She was asleep within minutes.

The overhead lights had dimmed and through his window Jimmy could see the Learjet’s wingtip-mounted collision blinker pulsating thousands of feet above the cloud line. Gertie had spoken

of history, while a thousand miles behind them the sun would begin its descent over Los Angeles, and with it Gertie's multi-million dollar home in the Palisades, now left as unoccupied as the residence in Sun Valley.

The noises that haunted Gertie Lev at night were within Jimmy's understanding. Perhaps the hummingbird totem on a chain around her neck, a symbol of healing but also territorial ferocity to the Indigenous, offered protection. The hummingbird was also the only species of bird that could fly backward, Jimmy'd learned from a podcast. The rest of us were expected to push forward with little navigation, he thought, away from the clamor of our pasts.

On the drive to the airplane hangar in Hailey, Jimmy'd called the last outgoing number from his daughter's burner—it'd rang Shindad centralized command or so the recorded answer had told him. He knew he was unlikely to find his son there. As Special Forces accompanying recon units, the boy's combat outposts were miles from centralized ops. Nearly every American force had left Afghanistan anyway—only a few soldiers, like Jimmy's son, remained.

Initially, Jimmy'd fought with his son over joining the military, not from lack of understanding but Jimmy's own fear. Their arguments had driven a wedge. If Jimmy had embraced the idea of his son's enlistment, he often wondered, would the boy still have gone? *At least, wouldn't he have gone stronger into battle if wrapped in approval?* Jimmy felt motion sickness, far above the cruising altitude of commercial flights. Viewed from forty thousand feet, did life make more sense or less?

Gertie had said that Evelyn Hawkstellar was a lesbian, which might have explained Brody's childhood anger at Jimmy's daughter, the young man not yet understanding what he may have perceived as his mother choosing another woman over her son. What wedges, Jimmy wondered, did even the best of parents unwittingly drive? Raising a child was a process that few seemed prepared for and was over long before anybody realized, and what

could Jimmy know about raising a boy, anyway, when Jimmy'd had no father of his own?

Most of the men Jimmy'd had passing friendships with fell to either end of the criminal justice spectrum, as cops or criminals. He never paid much attention to the lives of men in his life, few as they'd been. Those relations were short-lived. To earn Jimmy's respect, Jimmy generally only required that a man be physically clean, slender if possible, and with a medium to high level of fitness. Not an imbecile. Not unkind to animals. Ideally, knew how to submit a man in a scuffle. Protected children. Didn't take up too much space in the presence of women. Didn't eat with his mouth wide-open or piss with the seat down. Didn't blow snot from his nose onto the pavement. These were some of the rules he'd taught his son—hardly enough, Jimmy knew.

The only consistent friend in his life, close to what might have been called “extended family,” had been Ethan Campbell, his Michigan State junior year roommate and long-distance friend of almost thirty years.

They'd met at a sorority party and taken LSD together, the only time Jimmy'd done hard drugs but the first of thousands for Campbell, who stayed on at State to earn a doctorate in history. Campbell's thesis on the Lordstown rebellion a 1970s blue-collar uprising of autoworkers at a General Motors plant in Ohio, fueled the beginning of his lengthy career teaching and writing about America's disenfranchised classes.

He completed the writing of his thesis while in a Detroit drug rehab, an immersion experience causing his scholarly and personal focus to narrow-in on the decay of inner-city black communities which, in Campbell's words, had “lost their prophets.” A shaggy, tenured professor at Detroit's Wayne State University now, Campbell was conscious of his inability to be a meaningful spokesperson for the sufferings of a community he was squarely a tourist within, being Caucasian.

Still, he did complain every six months or so, in alcohol-incited phone calls to Jimmy, about the intellectual laziness of even his smartest students. They appropriately called-out Campbell for his

biases, he admitted, but wouldn't bother to read books like *The Autobiography of Malcolm X*, instead claiming to understand the power of X's placement in Black American history because they'd seen Denzel Washington's portrayal of him in YouTube clips from a 1992 dramatization.

His middle-class white students wrote least intelligently about racism, as they had no social context for the experience, did their research on Vice News, a source streamlined for a poorly read generation seemingly too psychologically unwell to critique themselves. On one occasion, Campbell was disciplined by his Department Chair for failing a posh Bloomfield Hills undergrad who often publicized himself as surviving the struggles of immigration but whose birth father's family were 5th generation French landowners and arts philanthropists—the boy indeed an immigrant to the U.S. but hardly a poster child for the topographical struggles most immigrants faced. Campbell's essay exam was prefaced by a requirement that his students use "only original thought," so when the boy asked Campbell to define that phrase, he threw him out of class, gave the boy an F for the semester.

Campbell remained a functional alcoholic and drug addict, his positioning on the criminal justice spectrum somewhere in the middle, parallel to politicians, yet he and Jimmy'd stayed close out of a shared history—they were friends because they had simply been friends too long not to be anymore. And, no other acquaintance of Jimmy's, through parenting or professional collaborations, had known Jimmy as Campbell had, in the years before Jimmy's mother died.

Jimmy had telephoned Campbell after securing Gertie's plane to Detroit. They'd arranged to meet in the morning. Jimmy had hoped for guidance in navigating the city, which he'd visited during college but not since. And he had no intention of calling Detroit PD for help. It was one of the least-funded forces in the country. They'd want to confiscate his 9mm, unregistered in

Michigan, waste urgent hours questioning him instead of pursuing Ally's whereabouts.

No, Jimmy would do this on his own, go after his daughter at first light and with abandon, which the law seldom allowed for.



The hard landing in Detroit woke Jimmy from a fitful sleep. It was two in the morning when he and Gertie crawled into an Uber Black Cadillac sedan, two-thirty when the freeway dumped them downtown beneath the MotorCity Casino Hotel's neon lights washing like an aurora across the sky. Beyond them, the massive Ambassador Bridge to Canada was lit along its cantilever trusses crossing the Detroit River, itself long filled with the bodies of homicides, Jimmy knew.

Three in the morning by the time Jimmy and Gertie crossed the polished hotel lobby to an elevator foyer. Gertie pressed a button, waited. Stood beside Jimmy without talking, her rollaway bag between them and Jimmy's duffle over his shoulder.

While he usually wore his weapon at the ankle due to the long surveillance hours that made a hip-carry uncomfortable pressed between his body and the driver's seat, the 9mm was now tucked snugly into a holster at the rear belt seam of his trousers. A black t-shirt and hooded sweatshirt hung loosely overtop. Jimmy was half-asleep already when the elevator doors opened.

They stepped inside, a newly-applied essential oil emanating from Gertie's nape—tea tree, Jimmy noticed, mixed with stale cigarette smoke from the elevator's evening. When the doors closed, they ascended to a fifteenth-floor suite, booked at Gertie's insistence. The doors opened and Gertie stepped out. Jimmy absentmindedly remained leaning against the elevator's support rail, fully exhausted from travel and worry, his adrenaline crashing, eyes closing from shutdown.

Gertie stepped back into the elevator. She put her fingertips on his wrist.

"Are you coming?"

Her eyes were blue green like Ayita Smith's, Jimmy realized, but several shades lighter, tenth floor eyes but not the suite, her spirit in a world well-below what money had bought her.

The hotel room was half the size of Jimmy's house but with only one bedroom. A wall of steel-framed windows in the common area faced south across the city. The black Detroit River looked like an oil slick in the night. Jimmy stripped his shirt, crawled under a thin blanket on the couch. He turned inward on himself, slept hard immediately.

Gertie had claimed the king-size bed, closed the double doors to the bedroom. Twenty minutes later, she opened the double doors again.

Jimmy awoke from the sound, turned to face the room now and saw Gertie in an ivory sleeping gown made nearly transparent by the window light.

"I was worried your gun would go off while you slept," Gertie said, her voice at a respectful whisper, her presence like an older sibling checking on the youngest, how Jimmy had known Ally to sometimes monitor her restless brother's asthma growing up.

"I remove it before I sleep," Jimmy told her.

"Okay. Good."

Gertie hesitated a moment then returned to the bedroom. Jimmy heard the doors close fully now, and in her absence realized that her presence had been comforting.

THIRTEEN

Jimmy dreamed of his mother tying his shoelaces for him in the parking lot of their motel, summer sunlight across the asphalt and his mother saying, “You haven’t been loved very well,” but in the dream he felt defensive of that, believed it to be a lie.

He slept for two hours, and by 6:30 a.m. was fully dressed. He descended to the hotel bar where Ethan Campbell awaited him. It’d been twenty-seven years since they’d last met in person, the month before Jimmy’s mother died, and now Campbell sat at the bar in jeans and a grey tweed blazer over a fading “Detroit Vs. Everybody” tee shirt, slurping a Bloody Mary. Jimmy stepped up and embraced him.

Campbell’s mop of hair was thinned by age, his skin roughened by alcohol, but his eyes as sharp with intellect as when he’d been an undergraduate ranting on acid about corporate-funded puppet governments in Central America, Jimmy barely comprehending.

Jimmy joined him at the bar, ordered a black coffee. Campbell held the celery back from his drink with a forefinger that looked like it’d been crushed in a door long ago. Slugged hard then set the glass aside. Jimmy could smell the alcohol, as familiar to him as the anchoring scent of a human being.

“So,” Campbell said. “Cut to the chase. That tower your cop friend pinpointed is directly across the street from the old Packard plant. That’s forty acres of abandoned shitsville. The two of us blindly searching for your daughter in that neighborhood is about as safe as rollerblading into a canyon ambush full of jizzheads. If you remember the John Wayne movies we used to watch, everybody who lays out a picnic blanket gets murdered on site. The good news, odd as this sounds, might be the cartel involvement you mentioned. You weren’t in Michigan long, but do you remember the name Marty Maroon?”

“The old billionaire?”

“Correct. His private company actually owns the Ambassador Bridge. Consequentially, that’s the only privately-owned border crossing between the U.S. and Canada. Twenty-five percent of our trade with the North crosses the Ambassador. That’s why those Canadian anti-vaxxers blocked it when they were pissed from not getting any pussy in ’22. I heard Maroon takes in \$60 million a year from the bridge alone, but homeboy also owns a trucking company called Trans Fleet CA, based in Windsor. Naturally, they do business across borders.”

“He owns the trucks, and he owns the bridge,” Jimmy repeated. It didn’t take much effort to synthesize Campbell’s direction.

“You can imagine that Marty Maroon would be of great interest to the cartel.”

“Are you suggesting Maroon has a way of bypassing U.S. and Canadian Customs?”

“I’d never say that on record about a billionaire doing business in a city where a thousand dollars can put a contract out. Do you know how many thousand-dollar hits are in a billion dollars? One million. To put it another way, a thousand dollars is .000001 percent of the money this asshole can burn coming after you. That’s why I get pissed off when Jeff Bezos brags about giving a million dollars to a charity. Percentage of net worth, that’s like me donating a box of crackers to the clap clinic and expecting every newspaper in Wayne County to run featurettes.”

Campbell lifted his finger to the bartender, a Black woman with large gold loop earrings, ordered another drink but added, “Just the juice, please.”

She set a small glass before him, which Campbell drank in one mouthful. His jawline had two-day old stubble that’d greyed along the ridges. Between his lower lip and chin the skin tone was mottled, as if peeled by sunburn.

He blew his nose into a napkin, told Jimmy, “Related to finding your daughter, what’s important is that Maroon also owns a fuck-ton of vacant properties this side of the river. We’re talking sixteen-hundred parcels, land and buildings mostly purchased

right after the city hit bankruptcy. A *Free Press* reporter got shot up two years ago after speculating about the Maroon acquisitions being a laundromat for out-of-state drug runners. You don't get more out of state than Mexico, I guess. The point is, two of Maroon's buildings are catty-corner to the Packard complex, so they would've pinged the same tower. I Google-earthed that shit on cocaine last night."

He rubbed his face with an open palm as if wiping away either sweat or the tacit demoralizations of the evening before.

"This is great information. Maybe I should check the addresses without you," Jimmy offered. "I'm worried you're at risk in your condition."

"Which is what?"

"Dehydrated."

He'd known addicts his whole life, first when they streamed like paper-thin spirits beneath the parking lot halogens of his mother's motel, knew them as an adult with a badge running them down, later in his sobriety meetings in the low-ceilinged rooms where addicts hoped to repurchase their lives with truth-telling, the only currency they had left. Campbell's tenured professorship provided stability, likely keeping him out of prison, but he would always be a passenger on the ghost rail.

"I've enjoyed our phone calls over the years," Campbell said, maybe reading Jimmy too clearly. "But I'm pretty certain I'm the last guy you'd socialize with if we weren't already friends—so it means a lot, riding with you." His eyes developed a sentimental sheen above the bloodshot. His busted finger flexed with a nervous tic before snickering, "We had some fun back in the day. Remember that strip bar in Windsor with the row of bedrooms upstairs?"

"I do but I'd rather not."

"I guess we'll skip the titty clubs, then. Let's go."

They took Campbell's late-model, cranberry-colored Ford LTD, rusted at the wheel wells from road salt, the ashtray full of cigarette butts mashed into loose change, the windows down, the summer humidity thick as cotton flowing through the car.

Jimmy's phone showed missed calls from Jennifer and also Gertie, whom he'd left a brief but likely unsatisfactory note for—didn't want her following him into trouble, wanted to let her sleep. Foot traffic surrounding the eastside soup kitchen was heavy, the streets potholed, Cash and Liquor signs glowing atop decaying storefronts that reminded Jimmy of his Garden City years, his childhood, riding second-hand bicycle along its miles-long strip, the banana seat riding up his ass when hitting curbs. He remembered his mother handing him a paper-wrapped half-ounce bar of soap when he'd come back sweaty after-hours huffing auto fumes from 32nd Street all the way up to 5 Mile and back, a century of riding for a 9-year-old. Jimmy's children wouldn't have ridden a mile alone at that age nor was he likely to have let them.

Campbell whistled under his breath to a Springsteen cassette he'd pushed into an aftermarket stereo that appeared to have been installed by somebody without thumbs, loose wires hanging beneath the dash like cobwebs against Jimmy's shins.

"I think you should know that I'm armed and have no intention of considering my own life ahead of my daughter's. Realistically, you're not safe with me today," Jimmy told Campbell.

Campbell smiled.

"There's a peashooter in the dash and a Walmart machete under my seat. I'm over-educated and under-height but I live in poverty, so I've miraculously retained ninety percent of the anger of my youth, meaning I know how to talk to people when they hold a gun under my chin. Very slowly at first, and then with no talking at all. Fucking-up street gangsters is a skill set I've honed along the many roads to and from drug remission. Some of my most agile moments happened across floors saw dusted with rock baggies, pal. You don't have to worry about me."

Jimmy opened the glove box where a loaded .22 caliber revolver was stuffed into a pile of maintenance records for the LTD. He closed the glove box. The LTD's suspension took a corner like an amusement park ride, wide and loose, and when the vehicle

straightened, Jimmy caught his breath then pointedly asked, "Have you ever shot that?"

"No, I take the bullets out and blow pot through the barrel with my students."

Jimmy wondered if intellectuals and criminals operated with the same parts of their brains, before Campbell added, "I'm kidding, Jimmy. If I didn't know how to use it, I wouldn't be holding it. Michigan is a red state, remember."

The neighborhood outside looked war-torn, homes charred and gutted from old fires, others half-demolished in patterns that made no sense. The back wall of a carriage house like a stage prop, but the rest of the home was missing. Several whole blocks had been scraped to the foundation, overgrown with weeds.

As in most war zones, there were survivors determined to beautify. Campbell slowed the LTD to a crawl as they passed a freshly painted bungalow with front windows so new they still had the stickers from Lowe's. On the stoop, a Black woman in jeans and Caucasian woman in a house dress smoked cigarettes together, drank from mugs. In their yard, a row of tomato plants had fallen over ripe with fruit.

Campbell's arm hung out the window, and the morning sunlight was angled and hot across a sidewalk bulging and sinuous with cracks. The abandoned Packard industrial compound was six blocks long, deeply ravaged by time, many buildings with holes the size of mortar impacts where cars had hit them, rods of metal rebar now poking out from braids of wire mesh meant to keep the concrete from collapsing.

"The Titanic was a hundred feet tall, a thousand feet long, and had twenty-two hundred people aboard when it sank," Campbell said. "This shithole here had forty-thousand employees at one time, more than most of your whole cities in Idaho, and I guarantee nobody outside of Detroit played the fucking violin when it went down."

Campbell pulled the LTD to the curb, parked it, left the engine running.

There was no traffic, no hint that anything resembling a morning rush hour had passed through the neighborhood in decades. The streets in this part of town were cracked but not potholed because they'd seen little wear. Weeds grew from the asphalt, and across the street a young Black man in his twenties leaned against the porch beam of a clapboard row house smoking a cigarette. He wore boxy, knee-length denim shorts, black shower slides with white horizontal stripes.

A mixed-race toddler sat with his back against the man's left leg as if reclining in a camping chair. The toddler stared across the street at the LTD with eyes so blue they pierced the distance even in daylight, seemed computer generated, like dragon eyes in the dozens of popular films featuring burning castles.

"That's one of my kids," Campbell said.

"You fathered that child?"

Campbell snorted, "The Black guy, Jimmy. His name is Deon. He's one of my grad students. You should see the mother of that little boy he's got. Blonde from the toes up and I swear a whole body of skin that smells like a cherry popsicle. She danced over at Dream Girls in Lincoln Park for three months. I know because I made her car payments that winter. I'm ashamed to say I might've seen her naked before my student did. Journey I think her name was, but this was years ago. Then when she was pregnant, I'd see them together getting Coneys at Lafayette sometimes. You remember that place?"

"I remember our wallets got jacked by middle-school kids half our size and twice as tough."

"That's the one. Now they got rich ladies doing cardio across the street. Anyway, it was obvious his girl recognized me one day at Lafayette because she and Deon looked at me and just kinda laughed like there was a fool in the house, like watching a TikTok video of a baboon hula hooping in his own feces. Then last summer, he asked me to be on his thesis committee. I got so embarrassed by the idea he'd had a glimpse at my peccadillos that I took him to a lunch cart by the river, told him point blank, 'Deon, I'm an alcoholic and addict. While none of my past behavior

is excusable because of that, I also happen to be an idiot, which I hope excuses a little.' You know what he did? Took out a bankroll fat as a softball and paid for our lunches himself. Didn't say a word."

"How does he make his money?" Jimmy asked.

"The same as everybody else in Detroit: Two parts hustle, three parts none of your fucking business. And squeezing in a master's degree and kid? If I remember, this might be Deon's grandmother's house, so maybe he knows something about traffic from the warehouses. They're only three blocks further. I'm gonna bum a smoke and talk a minute. I'd bring you up with me, but you reek of police work."

"I haven't been a cop in almost fifteen years," Jimmy said.

"Being in law enforcement's like eating at an IHOP," Campbell told him. "You're in the booth forty-five minutes, but your shirt smells like pancakes until the day they strip it from you in the morgue. Trust me on this."

Campbell jumped out of the car and let the door slam heavy.

Jimmy turned on the radio. He was nervous about Campbell poking around on his behalf, saying the wrong thing. In the news, bombs were again blowing apart the Middle East. One day the skies around the world would be carpeted with napalm, the oceans boiled to salt—yet humankind continued to spend its expendable wealth lobbing grenades into the living rooms of strangers.

Jimmy turned off the radio, stepped from the LTD and began to walk up the street. Briefly second-guessed himself about not calling Detroit PD. Yet police in Idaho had been alerted and bullets *still* sought Jimmy—what would happen to his daughter if DPD failed to find her, a task delegated to government employees...? Jimmy bet more on himself than anyone, his fatherly instinct having evolved through millions of years of men protecting their daughters. Trying to, anyway.

He passed two scraped-bare plots of land where shotgun homes once held middle-class earners, many of them descendants of southern slaves who'd migrated to Detroit for paid work in the auto factories. Most of those jobs went away by the 1990s and the

smell of decay in the air was now profound. The General Motors buildings in the downtown corridor shone silver and high against the morning sun, but out here the flatlands were odorous, the prospect of lifelong work seemingly stillborn.

Jimmy heard the LTD before it sidled up, its big engine throbbing unevenly. He got in.

“I told him I’m working an eastside redevelopment story for the *Free Press*. When I asked if he knew anything about renovations on the Packard plant or nearby, maybe for condos, he snorted. I was gearing up to ask about the warehouses when you know what he said? ‘Yeah, and they’re turning that Narco pad up the block into a Whole Foods.’”

They drove two more blocks and approached the pair of warehouses, one seemingly vacant, the other on a half-acre plot ringed by a ten-foot chain link fence. In the rear of the fenced area was a loading dock and three tractor-trailers. Two of the long-haul trucks, fifty-footers, had Canadian plates on their bumpers.

The other had an Idaho plate.

“Friend of yours?” Campbell said.

“Friend in the making,” Jimmy told him. “Pull around the next corner and let me out.”

Campbell swung the LTD through a stop sign bent like melted wax. He parked at the curb. Jimmy pulled up his hoodie, got out, walked a half-block along a sidewalk to the fenced warehouse.

To the front, a directional security camera pointed at a set of glass doors chained and padlocked. To the rear, two cameras were mounted to the same corner. One pointed at an electronic fence gate on rollers, the other angled toward the loading dock, where the three semis aligned.

Jimmy skirted the fenced perimeter. No activity. The roll-down door at the loading dock was sealed. A nearby barred window was blacked out with spray paint. The only indicator of life was a braced-open ventilation window the size of a food hatch in a prison cell. And cigarette butts littered the concrete inside the entry gate, possibly discards from a man stationed during evening hours.

Jimmy used his iPhone to surreptitiously snap photos of the plate numbers on the 18-wheelers and the address of the building in faded black paint on the curb. He slid the phone back into his pocket, leaned against the gate in the near-quiet. A mile away, traffic from the interstate hummed. Across the street, a dog barked once, then again when a screen door slammed. Pots and pans rattled in a nearby clapboard house like windchimes. He closed his eyes. With the sounds fading and the sun warming Jimmy's eyelids, he heard the faintest shuffle inside the warehouse: Boxes being stacked softly as a whisper through the ventilation window.

Jimmy walked around the block before returning to the LTD and got in, told Campbell, "I'll need my laptop to run the truck plates."

Campbell put the vehicle into drive, pulled away. Rolled through every stop sign on his way out of the neighborhood.

"In moments of urgency I'm tempted to believe I have no skills of substantive use to outcomes. You can 'run plates,' while all I do is drive my late grandfather's dump on wheels and pretend I have the balls to 'smoke a motherfucker.' You and I both know that bluebird in my glovebox has never left its nest. When I go home at night, I am not met by animals or loved ones."

Neither was Jimmy anymore. It'd been years since he was greeted at home by more than an Amazon package on the doorstep.

"It's good to have your help," Jimmy allowed, bridging the gap between hyper-focus on Ally and the human needs of his friend, a man of great flaws but easily hurt. He felt brief nostalgia for their friendship, told Campbell, "The only thing I know of this city comes from the time we spent in it. What is that, four or five trips to blow your student loans on a suicide run?"

"When student loans worked on the honor system," Campbell laughed. "Every time my check came, I'd skim ten percent and force you into my passenger seat for a ride across the bridge. I remember on more than one occasion there was an armed conflict in my nether regions afterward."

“We took the tunnel once,” Jimmy reminded him.

“I don’t do that anymore,” Campbell said. “It’s not natural to travel a mile beneath seventy-five feet of water with five hundred cars behind you back-to-back. And all of that hundred-year-old concrete peeling at the edges? One day, somebody will drive a truck bomb down the hole and our illustrious Detroit PD will be dredging the river for bodies and iPhones.”

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FOURTEEN

They returned to the hotel, where Gertie was sitting on a bench outside. She held a brown leather clutch in her lap, her face tilted toward the sun, the skin across her cheekbones damp with humidity. Campbell pulled back on the gas pedal, let the LTD sidle-past.

“That woman is a stone-cold fox,” he said, saw Jimmy’s irritation at the salaciousness, adding, “Don’t tell me she was your ride out here?”

Campbell stopped the car, jammed into reverse, backed up slowly. Gertie stood from the bench.

Jimmy got out.

“The note you left me was unaccompanied by a rose,” Gertie said.

She waved reticently to Campbell, said to Jimmy, “Is this the hussy you left me for?”

“I wanted to let you sleep,” Jimmy apologized.

She went to the car window to get a better look. “You’re Ethan?”

“Dr. Campbell.” He corrected, leaned across the seat, shook Gertie’s manicured hand.

Then he looked past her to Jimmy and added, “I can take her over to the Cadillac Diner for a meal. If we haven’t heard from you by the time we’re done, I’ll hit up Deon again while he’s slicing limes over at this bar he opens, a place called Mary’s about a mile from here.”

He looked at Gertie adding, “Do the wealthy drink beer this early in the morning?”



Jimmy went upstairs and sat on the couch in their hotel room, ran the plates from the three trucks at the warehouse. Two of the plates were out of Ontario, Canada, registered to Trans Fleet CA, the billionaire Marty Maroon's company.

What caught him off guard was the Idaho plate he'd photographed, also tracked to Trans Fleet CA, registered to an Idaho division of the company only two blocks from the Capitol building in Boise. The registering agent was a man Jimmy recognized from Idaho politics, a former lumber lobbyist turned attorney for Grisham Greasley.

Jimmy Google-earthed the warehouse, studied the surrounding fence line and abutting properties. Then he jumped onto the City of Detroit web site and paid two dollars to pull the warehouse's tax records and assess its interior.

A schematic of the warehouse showed three storage areas, each a thousand square feet, and a two-hundred-and-eighty-square-foot refrigeration room. There were three restrooms in the building, two near the loading dock, one attached to a small office at the front, near the chained doors.

Jimmy guessed the refrigeration room to the east of the building was no longer in use, as he hadn't heard the trademark whir of a condenser fan, and no exterior refrigeration unit appeared via satellite in the Google image.

An hour and a half had passed.

He called Jen but got sent to voicemail. Left a message apologizing for his disappearing act. Let her know he was in Detroit, thanked her for what he stupidly referred to as her "hospitality."

He was grateful to have her in his life, wanted her to know it. Now he wished his message had been more forthright, that he'd said what he'd been thinking since waking up in her home.

He thought about calling Detroit PD or even Gooding or Abbiati as a conduit to local authorities but instead stashed his spare 9mm clip into his back pocket, looked out the big windows to the city. Thought of Ally lost in the labyrinth of a world mapped by men.

He took the elevator down then walked through the casino. The strawberry-colored slot machines were churning currency. Outside, he ordered an Uber. Paced for twenty minutes in the sunlight, pits sweating from humidity by the time the vehicle arrived.

The bar called “Mary’s” was cinderblock, no windows, a lipstick-red armored door thick enough to stop a bullet. Inside, Jimmy found Campbell and Gertie at the wooden rail with a pair of empty Corona bottles, two fresh ones, a smattering of lime wedges on a porcelain saucer. They played “Hangman” with a ballpoint pen and cocktail napkin. Gertie was enjoying herself in a way Jimmy hadn’t previously seen.

Campbell’s graduate student, Deon, dragged a trio of recently hosed rubber mats through a back door into the galley behind the bar, where they slapped down heavily.

The air smelled of last night’s sweat and recently applied chemical fresheners. The beers atop the bar looked a perfect forty degrees cold with condensation running down the bottles. A low-playing song by Morris Day and The Time issued from budget speakers mounted into two corners.

Jimmy set Campbell’s beer behind a cluster of taps, cutting him off from more alcohol.

“The rich lady and I have a shared love of music,” Campbell said, smiling directly into Gertie’s face. “And the word I’ve spelled on this napkin is hyphenated, an admittedly grey area in the rules of Hangman. If you can’t outsmart them, it’s best to confuse them.” He turned to Jimmy adding, “At least I finally know how to make a woman squirm.”

Gertie put a hand on Campbell’s arm, told him dryly, “I doubt that, hon.” She turned to Jimmy now, “Your friend told me about a time he collected you from the police in college. You’d broke a boy’s jaw but wouldn’t say why, which seemed ‘categorically queer’ at the time, he said.”

Campbell snickered, seemed two sheets to the wind.

Gertie continued, “I don’t want to leave just yet. Can we stay a while, James?” Only the government and Jimmy’s mother called

him by his formal name.

Jimmy reached for Campbell's arm. "A minute in the restroom," he said, pulled his friend from the barstool.

The men's room door swung shut behind them and Campbell splashed water on his face, smoothed the hair across his forehead. Turned to Jimmy. "What you see out there isn't drunkenness. The first two or three only level me out. I'm working her, 'James.' And overall, I'm not sure you should trust that woman."

"Why not?"

"When I told her one of the trucks we saw had an Idaho license plate, she wasn't surprised."

"And Deon?"

"He knows more about the warehouse than he's letting on. I tried to pressure the kid, but you see how hard he works. I don't want to lose his trust as a student."

"I'll talk to Deon," Jimmy said. "You stay here with Gertie, if that's okay. You were never coming into that building to begin with, but I'll forward you a cell number for a police officer in Idaho. If you don't hear from me in an hour, call it."

Campbell reached to open the restroom door. Jimmy added, "Also, I'm sorry I doubted you. It's been a lot of years."

"If you'd seen me two weeks ago, you'd have every right to doubt," Campbell said. "Today, I'm copacetic."

"No more stories from college?"

"No problem, brother. They aren't mine to tell."

"Then stop telling them."

Jimmy found Deon dumping a bucket of mop water into the alley out back, sunlight bouncing off the cinderblock wall, illuminating a dime-shaped scar on Deon's cheek.

Deon turned the bucket upright to dry in the sun. He lit a cigarette.

"I can't tell you what you want to hear," Deon said. "And it ain't about you being police. I have to protect my grandmother's house."

"I understand," Jimmy said. "The thing is, my daughter is missing. I've come all the way across the country because I believe

she might be a captive in that building.”

Deon hit the cigarette, blew smoke in a milky stream from the side of his mouth, the scar in his cheek flexing.

“There’s a lot of people missing all over the fucking world. You understand that, too?”

“I do,” Jimmy said.

“And you understand how a white guy talking at me like I have a moral obligation to help him, simply by the fact of his requesting it, can easily be interpreted as symptomatic of the robustness of slave owner genetics?”

“I do, I guess. I apologize for that. If I had my chance, I’d hang every slave owner by the flaps of flesh left around their ankles after skinning them. I just want to find my child.”

Deon looked at Jimmy a long time, dragged off his cigarette again.

“They run girls through the loading dock, but I don’t think American ones.”

He flicked his cigarette into the alley. Then he added, “Protect my fucking name in this. If not, I’ve got people who’ll be a relentless source of pain to the loved ones you leave behind.”

“Your professor warned me about that. According to him, my life is worth less than a membership at the CrossFit gym if you break it down by month.”

“He’d be right.”

“I appreciate the situation,” Jimmy told him.



Jimmy Ubered to a corner liquor store three blocks north of the warehouse, got out and put his hoodie up to provide cover from security cameras.

Went inside and purchased a tall bottle of Five O’ Clock vodka, two containers of rubbing alcohol, a package of first aid gauze, a box of baking soda, and a disposable lighter—paid for it all with twenty-five dollars in cash he slid through a window in the bullet-proof polycarbonate glass separating him from the store clerk.

Left with a paper bag under his arm. Walked toward the warehouse neighborhood with the big Packard buildings visible and the sun at his shoulders. Across the street from the warehouse, he ducked through a breezeway into an abandoned house gone lopsided on a crumbling foundation, its copper pipes and electrical wires scavenged years-ago through now-rotting holes knocked into the plaster.

Jimmy saw through the open doorway to the warehouse's entry handles wrapped in galvanized chain, the glass spray-painted black from inside for privacy. Parked along the street was a black-on-black Lincoln sedan.

He emptied the vodka onto the old laminate flooring that'd peeled from weather, refilled the Five O' Clock bottle with rubbing alcohol and baking soda. Stuffed the neck of the bottle with first aid gauze, tipped the bottle once to soak it.

He stepped gingerly into the weed-covered lot outside.

In the otherwise dead silence, he heard a car horn honk from two blocks away, heard his own heart thump louder across the rumble strip of his ribs.

Jimmy crossed the street and ascended the curb at the warehouse, lit the gauze, hurled the bottle like a discus, sidelong through one of the front windows.

Flames engulfed the chain-locked entryway. He felt the pulse of memory around his eyes. It came as quickly as the unnamed dead who crossed the air we breathe but leave no signature, left him alone just as quickly. Jimmy hustled around the corner now, the two cameras tracking him, the electronic security gate opening on wheels.

Jimmy squatted onto one knee with his 9mm extended, inhaled a single breath then exhaled softly as two Hispanic men in jeans and ballcaps rounded the gate with pistols swinging carelessly.

He fired two distinct shots, one bullet apiece hitting the upper leg of each man running across the weeds at him. Each fell, grabbing at their wounds. Both of their pistols scattered, the sound of metal across stone almost childlike in its timbre, like cap guns raking across a driveway.

Jimmy hopscotched between the bodies, one man trying to grab Jimmy's leg—then ran toward the gate and ducked around the corner with his weapon extended.

He entered the battered concrete shipping lot with the three semi-trailers parked neatly in a row. Waited in a crouch. The loading dock's roll-gate had been lifted, but no more men appeared. Maybe the two he'd neutralized had been it. He rushed the concrete stairs of the dock. Plumes of smoke billowed from inside. No flames had breached from the interior doors to the office space yet.

Beneath the overhead halogen lights in a back room, a schoolgirl's backpack—pink with a travel-sized hand sanitizer dangling from a carabiner—leaned against the leg of an elongated stainless-steel table. The main room, closest to where Jimmy stood, was crowded with pallets of cardboard boxes stacked tidily, wrapped in industrial cellophane.

One of the men he'd shot limped into the loading yard, weapon extended. He fired two rounds at Jimmy but without skill. The rounds whizzed into the warehouse. Jimmy returned one round, spraying concrete at the man, who pivoted onto his bad leg, stumbling. Jimmy shot another round into the concrete, drove the man back, where his tee shirt caught on the fence.

Jimmy's ears rang.

He turned back to the warehouse, saw the door to the 14' x 20' refrigeration unit. Stepped beneath the loading gate and entered the musty space with weapon extended, adrenaline thumping in his head. He covered the twenty feet to the refrigeration room and gripped the foot-long latch in his left hand. His right-side gun hand hung low.

He felt the snub of a small caliber pistol pressed softly into the back of his head, just above the bone ridge in his skull. Jimmy instinctively squeezed his left hand tighter around the refrigerator latch but felt the gun push harder from behind. Came to his senses.

Heard the words, "Easy, pussycat."

Tio Flores' breathing against Jimmy's neck smelled like cinnamon, and the weight of Flores' body was against Jimmy's ass when Flores reached down to remove the 9mm from Jimmy's hand.

Then Flores stepped backward as quickly as if skating on ice.

When Jimmy turned around, Flores said as if first having pondered the skies, "How can only two of us make the world seem so crowded, Jimmy?"

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FIFTEEN

Jimmy was bound with a double-cuff Nylon zip then dumped hard into the trunk of the newly shined Lincoln parked streetside. He hadn't struggled, and neither Tio Flores nor the two men he'd shot inflicted violence upon him.

Although there had been ample opportunity to resist, Jimmy immediately sensed Flores wanted him alive, that there was business on Flores' mind and not the dark matter of murdering Jimmy thousands of miles from home with nobody the wiser, nobody eventually finding Jimmy's body at the bottom of the river between two countries, nobody knowing where to dredge.

The trunk of the Lincoln was surprisingly accommodating to Jimmy's stature, almost comfortable, not cramping him like Hillcrest into the shape of a seahorse in its final estuary. Jimmy likely could have found something to shimmy the plastic locking bar in the cuff, release the tension and free his hands, but the better play was to ride through whatever shit he was in and hope for Ally at the other end.

Only one door had shut. Flores placed a call in Spanish too thick for Jimmy to understand while the vehicle briefly stopped. Then the Lincoln began a slight ascension similar in grade to entering the foothills outside Boise. Jimmy knew they must have been traversing the Ambassador Bridge to Windsor.

The vehicle stopped on the Canadian side. Flores spoke to a custody agent. Then the Lincoln was waved-through. Jimmy could have kicked a taillight out as a "Mayday" call to Customs, but didn't. Less than ten minutes later, the vehicle stopped again and the engine was cut. The trunk opened to sunlight bouncing off a concrete building, backlighting Tio Flores as he pulled Jimmy's legs from the vehicle, grabbed two handfuls of his hoody and hoisted him up like a duffel bag.

They were in a sloped parking lot in an alley behind a bar. The smell of alcohol emanated from garbage bags of empty bottles filling a dumpster. The percussion of hip-hop came through the cinderblock.

Flores pulled a wire snip from his back pocket, cut the straps from Jimmy's wrists. He casually tossed the snip into the trunk, accidentally dropping Jimmy's ligatures onto the soiled pavement. When he leaned at the waist to retrieve their scraps, the gold herringbone chain Jimmy remembered from his first meeting with Flores spilled from the man's collar. Jimmy briefly imagined choking him with it. Instead, he rubbed his wrists where the plastic had cut into them, asked Flores, "Are you taking me to see my daughter?"

"In a manner of speaking," he said, pulled a pack of Camels from his front pocket. Lit one, then asked Jimmy, "Do you smoke?"

"I quit when I got sober."

"I understand why. All vice is an embarrassment to our manhood. I have undiagnosed lung cancer that will either take fifty years or five to kill me, Jimmy. Have you ever seen a wild animal intentionally harm itself the way humans do?"

Jimmy drilled his eyes through Flores' smoke as a substitute for liver-punching the man. The idea that Flores had Jimmy's daughter in captivity somewhere filled him with a rage like a pressure cooker full of framing nails ticking down from ten...to nine... to eight...

His composure was in service to the long game of getting his daughter home safe, but there were limits, and some men were insufferable to Jimmy's senses. *Always had been, always will be.* Flores no different than the gang rapers and wife beaters, the lunatics poisoning neighborhood cats. Jimmy didn't know how long he could hold himself back from the violence building in his blood.

Flores flicked the cigarette, said to Jimmy, "Follow me without incident."

They entered the bar through a reinforced steel door off the alley. The music surged and the door slammed behind them. Flores led through a small hallway painted midnight black, dimly lit by overhead bulbs the color of cranberry juice that seemed to pour down the back of Flores' hair as he walked in front of Jimmy—left himself unprotected, knew he held all the cards.

The hallway opened to a windowless bar, its walls blackened by high-gloss paint, easiest for wiping-down sweat. Beneath multi-colored tract lighting, a red-haired girl, younger by years than Jimmy's daughter, gyrated in full nudity on a hardwood stage, touching herself in rhythm while half a dozen men in trousers and collared shirts gazed without blinking. Two bouncers at the front entryway, a cocktail girl, and bartender all smoked cigarettes across the room.

Jimmy looked away from the stage. Kept walking until they reached a stairwell landing sticky with spilled alcohol beneath Jimmy's shoes. Angled away from the landing in a zigzag, one stairwell led downward into the pitch dark, presumably toward a cellar, while another angled steeply upward. Adorning that second stairwell were skeletal handprints made with glow-in-the-dark florescent paint, the way a child presses their palm to construction paper for Arts and Crafts.

More than a dozen small hands rose along the walls. Jimmy recognized them in the way his memory often recognized not just the visual but sometimes lingered in a retrocognitive space where intuition of past events that he could not have known about through normal means, but still somehow frequently proved true, overcame him in a flood of imagery and emotion at once. He'd foolishly told another cop about this during rookie school in the 1990s, only to be called "possibly retarded." Now, he remembered the handprints from when he and Campbell had visited as students on a bender, but remembered so much more, too, imagery that came in flashes he'd have banished from his brain if he'd only known how.

He looked back at the stage, octagonal in construction, same as years ago when he'd drunkenly thrown dollar bills onto it like

crumpled receipts from a life purchased recklessly, no doubt still in mourning over his mother, what he mightn't have understood for decades.

Flores leaned back to Jimmy, nodded toward the young girl as she crawled across the stage, an arc of light dipping along her spine. Her bare feet were small and pale. Flores put a hand on Jimmy's shoulder and shouted above the music, "Some babies look like they've been sucked out of their own bottle!"

Jimmy couldn't help himself. He tightened his right fist, hard as stone, drove it into Flores' solar plexus. The man fell backward up the stairwell, out of sight of the bar. Jimmy climbed atop now, Flores momentarily breathless beneath Jimmy's straddle.

There were so many ways to send a man to the ER with a single strike. Maybe drive a second punch into Flores' sternum and crack it, bruise the man's heart in the process. Or just choke him, Jimmy thought, drag him by the windpipe. But Jimmy had to think straight, too.

He stepped over Flores, climbed the stairwell to an upper landing where a beveled mirror was mounted on brackets. A series of birch-stained hollow-core doors lined the distressed upstairs hallway that'd gone without update since the 1980s.

There were six bedrooms down the hall. Jimmy remembered the layout from his visit during those college years when his habits aligned with the men who'd visited his mother's motel rooms. His first sexual encounters had been with adult women, and he'd sought similar prurient experiences into his twenties, perhaps to hold his other urges at bay.

At the far end of the narrow hallway, a young girl in cutoff denim shorts and bra sat cross-legged on the hardwood floor, hitting from a vape pen.

She gave him a curious smile as Jimmy approached.

The booze coma he'd awakened from in one of those bedrooms years ago now seemed like an emulsion X-ray he viewed the young girl through. Saw everything about her. The whites of her eyes were an inverted identification of how long she might live—the younger they were, the quicker they died. She might have been

fourteen, Jimmy thought, looked no older than girls working the cookie store at the mall.

She reached out, told him, "Help me up." Her fingers felt soft and malleable as red licorice in his hand when he lifted her.

"I'm looking for my daughter," Jimmy said.

There was recognition in her powder blue eyes.

"Okay."

She took Jimmy's wrist, led him into the nearest bedroom. It was painted pink, outfitted with a platform bed constructed of cinderblocks and plywood. A bureau topped with folded hand towels was stationed beside the queen size mattress.

The girl shut the door, took her bra off.

Jimmy immediately looked away, said to her from the side of his face, "Put it back on," opened the bedroom door to leave. One of the bouncers from downstairs filled the threshold, put a stun gun to Jimmy's breast.

Jimmy dropped like a man falling into a sewer hole.

Five minutes later Tio Flores was sitting on the girl's bed smoking a cigarette, staring down at Jimmy on the hardwood floor.

A welt across Jimmy's cheekbone from where the bouncer had punted the side of his head after falling. A thickness filling Jimmy's skull like a water balloon ready to pop.

He pulled himself to a seated position.

Flores inhaled deeply, blew a quill of smoke whose folds rose to the ceiling of the room.

Smiling, Flores said, "You're not the smartest man, Jimmy. I don't especially like having your electrocution on my hands."

"Where's the girl?" Jimmy asked.

"That little sprig of mint? She thought you were a pervert and ran away. It's good to be cautious with so many types of people entering a woman's life, sometimes even monsters!"

Flores' teeth were white as shaved ice around his cigarette and his eyes looked heavy at first, then suddenly alive with memory.

"The strangest thing I've seen was a young blonde girl in Jalisco," he added. "Her little toenails were escaping down the

street from a deformed man with gorilla arms. I think he was an exclusive type of movie producer, like Harvey Weinstein but straight to internet. That was a real nightmare. Yet when I saw him carry her to the trunk of his automobile, I realized how well cared-for she would be. I guess the girl you just saw will go down to Mexico tomorrow. They start here, they go there—or if they start there, they come here. We move them so we can get the Sky Miles.” Flores’ wet tongue slid across the back of his cigarette filter. His black eyes became flat as tar. He inhaled then blew out more plumage.

Said to Jimmy, “Have you ever cracked open an apple with your bare hands? A perfect apple is very clean inside, and there are only little seeds in a sea of pure white meat that is delicious.”

“Fuck you,” Jimmy said through the pain.

Flores burst into laughter.

“This is why you’re so stupid, Jimmy! But I also find you mysteriously trustworthy. You have a conscience, which makes you a terrible businessman but high-quality friend with many inroads to your heart. In another life, you and I would become close, maybe own a bar together or take drives through town, enjoy the company. Tell me, what have you learned about what happened to Ayita?”

“Nothing.”

“You loved her?”

“We’d only just met,” Jimmy said. “But I cared for her.”

Flores sighed. He smoked his cigarette to the nub, flicked it at the wall above Jimmy’s head where it rained-down sparks. Jimmy leaned forward to swat the ashes from his hair and arms, the blood pounding in his eyes.

“Men are weaker than women, Jimmy. This is why we murder them. But in your case, I believe your affection would have prevented that. The world needs more love, yet we keep incubating zombies like that Brody *pendejo*. After a certain age, their only human interaction is with their own penis.”

“Are you telling me Brody Hawkstellar is responsible for Ayita’s murder?”

“Have you ever seen a vacuum-sealed egg? That’s what his eyes looked like on a daily basis. When he was a child, he shot two squirrels and skewered them onto his handlebars.”

Flores flopped backward onto the bed like a teenager, his feet barely touching the floor, asking, “Why is my life so complicated right now?”

The base notes from the bar downstairs vibrated in Jimmy’s chest. The smell of incense drifted into the room from across the hall. The situation clarified for Jimmy. Hawkstellar had done the hit on Ayita, without concern for Jimmy’s life either, but Flores had been kept out of the loop, rupturing his confidence in whoever was boss—maybe Grisham Greasley. Through the patchouli smoke, peach-scented perfume, and stale musk emanating from the bedsheets was the pungent reminder of Flores’ unpredictability, especially if he no longer trusted his employer.

When Jimmy stood, Flores sat upright, pointed at him and said, “Whoever you think you are in moments of bravery, that is your very best self but not your most intelligent one. People who survive stay put.”

“I just want my daughter back,” Jimmy said.

“I know you do, honey. And every father in the world feels the same, which is why I’ve brought you here. Do you promise to stop punching me in the chest, so I can speak freely?”

“Yes already.”

Flores’ thighs looked hard as bricks under his jeans when he stood and arched his back to stretch it. Then he said to Jimmy, “Your daughter is in transit. You didn’t have to travel here to learn this—you were on my calendar for later in the week!”

“Transit to where?”

Flores cocked his head like a Pez dispenser, looked at Jimmy. “You have beautiful skin for a man supposed to be dead a few days ago. Follow me downstairs without fucking hitting me.”

He led Jimmy past the bedroom doors, most of them closed now but with muffled voices leaking, one of the rooms with pop music playing, the sound of a teenaged girl laughing alongside the

baritone of a grown man Jimmy saw tickling her through a crease in the doorway as they passed.

As they went down the black stairwell with its glowing handprints, hip-hop from the bar filled Jimmy's ears. He followed Flores around the stairwell landing, descended into the basement, completely dark at first. Jimmy held a wooden railing that felt smooth in his hand. The music from above them faded.

Flores told him, "Careful at the last stair." Then he flipped the switch to a low-wattage light bulb above them.

They were in a large, industrial kitchen that seemingly hadn't been used in years, the flooring patterned by art deco tiling, banks of pendant lighting crossing overhead with the bulbs stripped, the walls white with subway tiles.

Flores said to Jimmy, "This used to be the baking room. Notice the ornate porcelain flooring. In 1921, there were still coal-fired ovens, but the original owner eventually switched to gas before losing his restaurant in a mob situation. Now we sell raw *coño* upstairs and I fantasize about simpler times. This might have been the butcher's room if not for those delicious tiles—grout absorbs too much blood."

He lit another cigarette, inhaled. "Maybe in the next life for me."

Flores turned down the hallway and Jimmy trailed him to another room he couldn't see into yet, but which felt larger and gave the impression of a box canyon, echoey and wide. The darkness had a smell to it like Clorox, pennies, and urine.

When Flores hit a switch, three long rows of modernized tube lighting brightened a polished concrete room. The walls were stark white except for splatters of blood.

At the rear of the room, Bobby Abbiati sat chained by his wrists to a steel D-ring in the wall. A black bandana balled into his mouth and duct taped. His face badly bruised, his body naked except for white cotton trunks stained piss-yellow.

One of Abbiati's eyes blinked at Jimmy like a distress signal.

SIXTEEN

The key to enduring delicate scenarios manipulated by madmen was to avoid reacting without forethought, Jimmy knew, as when he'd leveled Flores on the upper stairwell. Instead, he needed to remain open to a pattern of logic that was abnormally nonlinear.

Every part of Jimmy's neural and cognitive functioning had been groomed by millions of years of evolutionary experience, the value of which seemed drastically diminished in the presence of Tio Flores. He could have easily overpowered Flores again—but to what end? The mentally freakish or otherwise impaired simply didn't think like most of the world. Officers of the law witnessed this daily on the job, such as when Jimmy'd once asked a heroin addict in the throes of addiction, "Why did you leave used needles lying around for your kids to pick up?" Fighting to reclaim his children from the back seat of a cruiser, the addict responded, "Cause if I throwed them in the garbage somebody'd a' got sticked!"

There were cigarette burns on Abbiati's torso. He was moaning through the buildup of snot and coagulated blood, each breath as if trying to pull a forest through a mesh screen.

"You don't seem impressed," Flores said to Jimmy. "And yet I worked tirelessly. Have you ever stayed awake overnight in a basement? It's creepy."

"It's not going to be easy to kill a cop."

"When the cop is dirty, it's cake," Flores smiled. "I saw it all the time on my TV growing up."

The one eye of Abbiati's that wasn't swollen-shut continued to beg Jimmy for help, the pupil dilated and the eyeball darting like a black wasp in a web of blood.

Some of the pieces were coming together for Jimmy.

“He tracked my daughter’s burner and gave you her location in New York,” Jimmy acknowledged with pain in his heart. “You both work for Gee-Gee—Grisham, I mean—so this is about betrayal for you. You thought you held the reins but realized you were the horse.”

“That’s insightful,” Flores said. “They’re using your daughter to get the deed back, Jimmy. They know you have two testicles full of hand grenades, so Grisham and this cockroach sent me to put a hood on the young lady.”

“The deed is in Boise,” Jimmy explained. “We can be there tonight. I don’t know why you need it, but I don’t care. I assume you’ll release my daughter the second I give it to you?”

“Baby, that was never going to happen.” Flores dragged from his cigarette then walked to Abbiati, squatted down and held the man by his bare foot, grinding the cherry into his shin. Abbiati kicked and screamed then settled into the pain, the chute of his throat wheezy with phlegm. Flores stood and stretched his lower back.

Said to Jimmy, “For the sake of honesty in our relationship, I admit there was debate about exactly when to kill your daughter because it’s hard to make money off dead bodies. You can harvest organs and get close to fifty-grand, but keep a woman alive, she’ll bring half a million a year. That’s after documentation and bribes, food and beverage, clothing and makeup, and of course grooming, sometimes condoms. In today’s market, nobody throws away product the way we used to.”

Jimmy could smell the sweat and testosterone leaking from Flores’ pores. Instinctively, he turned away. In the harsh overhead lighting, Abbiati looked like an ogre that’d been beaten from beneath a bridge.

“I don’t believe you’ve harmed my daughter yet,” Jimmy said to the air. Then he turned back. “You said they ‘sent’ you to kidnap and eventually murder her—Ally is her name, but you know that now—and you’ve also implied her considerable worth to you in a brothel, like the child I saw upstairs. But neither of those

options make you happy. You need something from me, and I don't think it's the deed."

"You're right, Jimmy," Flores said. "Just don't pretend you don't understand its value. You're smart enough to know about the stadium plans. I believe Grisham wishes it to be his mausoleum. Why do so many rich white people still invest in the idea of their legacy after death?"

"I suspect they hope it amends their comparative uselessness while living," Jimmy answered.

Flores lit another cigarette, blew a smoke ring that opened to the size of a donut, and looked at Jimmy with wide-open eyes that seemed suddenly to recognize an essential truth. "Yes, that's it. White people don't see everything is sand and wind. This is why their mistakes seem so arrogant."

"Is that why Detective Abbiati is chained to your wall?"

"He's performance art at this point. You have to go with it, enjoy your cocktail then casually nod at the suffering."

Flores knotted his fists. "That fucking Hillcrest *maricon* brokered an agreement on behalf of Grisham—a million cash for Ayita to renounce claim to the land, a good deal for being leftover sperm juice—those were Hillcrest's words. They needed her to back-off but also relinquish the deed given to her mother as collateral for shutting up when Grisham first ran for office. He promised Ayita'd be taken care of when the land got sold. But Jimmy, I learned a joke when working for the senator. How does a politician say, 'Fuck you'?"

"How?"

"Trust me."

Flores had tears in his eyes.

"Ayita brought the deed to Boise but was clever and locked it away before visiting Hillcrest's offices that night. She was not in uniform—no gun, no baton—so Shitbag took the locker key off her then ran his hand up her dress like a water pump."

"Rudolph Hillcrest sexually assaulted her?"

"First with his fingers, then with a black Sharpie from the desk. I know because Brody Hawkstellar watched it from a room

down the hall. Grisham had sent him as a tail, to confirm the deal went straight. Hawkstellar saw Ayita enter the Greyhound station but also got cash-hungry when Ayita rushed out of the office—he stayed to smash a LaserJet printer onto Hillcrest’s face, figuring to take the locker key and bring the deed and whatever money home himself. That might’ve worked but there was no money or deed, and Hillcrest never got up. It’s like what Jews say when they walk into a bar in north Idaho: ‘Oops.’”

“Hawkstellar killed him?”

“He thought so, but sometimes children are visually impaired by a multitude of nonessential anxieties. He panicked, drove Shitbag out of town without stopping at the Greyhound. Halfway to the casino he heard moaning—instead of being happy his grandfather’s business partner was still alive, Brody knocked him over the head with a rock from the side of I-84. Hillcrest’s brains were soup in the trunk of the Impala I worked two years to make pretty.”

“What was Brody doing with the Impala?”

“Had it pinched from Monterey and was storing it in a long-haul behind the casino waiting on a run to Detroit—the Motor City is the worst place to unload a classic car, buyers having the most knowledge and least money.”

“His ankle monitor would’ve been pinged if he’d travelled cross-country,” Jimmy said.

Flores smirked. His brown lips looked meaty beneath the halogens. When he spoke again his teeth glowed as brightly as evidence under a luminol light.

“The senator worked it so Brody was listed as Abbiati’s informant to bypass the parole office, which meant he was also Abbiati’s errand boy.”

He flicked his cigarette, squatted beside Abbiati and studied him, Abbiati’s breath intake forced and uneven when Flores punched him hard in the temple and said, “Right, *puta*?”

Abbiati groaned.

When Flores stood up again, his eyes betrayed his exhaustion.

“The problem with millennials is they have the worldly experience of a caterpillar. When Brody saw you at the casino, he texted me to clean up his mess. That’s the first I learned he’d boosted the car. He popped the trunk, and we found Hillcrest alive, but he’d been there two days, was crying in Pig Latin. He’d sawed his wrists to the bone trying to get out. I drove the rig to the desert and we unloaded the Impala. Brody was supposed to dump it down a mine shaft outside Gillette five-hundred miles away, but his tiny balls got him less than ten before he put two rounds into Hillcrest’s throat, the first once to kill him and the second because Brody was pissing his pants.”

“He lit the car on fire but there was rain coming,” Jimmy said.

“There’s a reason God made abortions, Jimmy. Brody also left the locker key hanging in the ignition. When Abbiati checked the evidence log he realized Ayita must have it, so he gave Brody a new boner to ride—kill every motherfucker in sight named Ayita Smith, just take her out and forget the deed. When Grisham found out, he set up the casino robbery as a front for murdering his grandson without the family knowing. Told me Brody proved to have too much Indian in him.”

“None of this has anything to do with me.”

“Yes, it does,” Flores said. “Grisham fucked me when he took that cash from the casino. That’s sixteen million I vouched for. Mexican money, Jimmy. It’s worth more in blood than dollars. Now I need help recovering that money if you want to see your daughter. I brought you across the bridge for *Señor Puerco* here to confirm for you what I gently blowtorched him to extract.”

When they looked at Abbiati again, his face was the color of blueberries and his one working eye was cranked-open in stare like a child’s pencil drawing.

“He’s dead,” Jimmy said.

“I see that.”



It was still broad daylight when Jimmy and Tio Flores each rolled fifty-gallon, black oil drums from the unmarked dock east of downtown Windsor onto the canopied swim platform of a twenty-seven foot Sea Ray motorboat.

Bobby Abbiati had weighed one-hundred and eighty pounds, thus each of the two oil drums contained approximately ninety pounds of body matter plus an additional eighty-pound bag of Quikrete powdered concrete they'd poured like sugar, dust rising into Jimmy's throat.

The oil drums were upright on the motorboat's swim platform. Flores ran a siphon hose from the river into their two-inch pour holes until water flooded out. Then he capped the holes. Jimmy thought to himself, "Just like that."

The Detroit River rolled at the edges of the boat. A formation of geese flew overhead like bullet spray against a bright blue sky when Flores primed the throttle. He pointed at the drums then said to Jimmy, "He would've had your daughter scrapped for parts. Fuck him."

They moved at low speed. When they crossed beneath the Ambassador Bridge, the netting of steel girders overhead reminded Jimmy of summers at Boise's local Hydrotube, a two-hundred-foot enclosed waterslide corkscrewing above a sprawling lawn where Jimmy'd sat on his swim-towel those days gazing-up at the shadowy bodies of his children whisking through green polymer tubing.

Flores remained on the Canadian side of the river, progressing toward its northernmost point where the water was deep, the current agitated by wind. The mansions of Detroit's exclusive Grosse Pointe were tucked behind fully blossomed hardwoods across the expanse. He cut the engine, the boat jerking forward. Jimmy again felt vertigo. Leaned over the starboard and vomited.

"I was given a Sawzall at seventeen," Flores said. "They get easier to use every time."

Flores stepped onto the swimming platform, put his chest against each oil drum, one by one, and sank them both.

By dusk, Jimmy and Flores stood outside the Lincoln in the alley behind the bar. Flores handed Jimmy his cell and 9mm back, popped the Lincoln's heavy-duty trunk, lit another cigarette.

Jimmy held the gun with the extended clip in it. Fit his hand perfectly, an extension of his body.

"Play this out," Flores said.

"I shoot you and I never see my daughter."

"Game over."

"I get that."

Jimmy set the 9mm inside the trunk, started to climb in so they could cross the Ambassador back into Detroit.

"Wait," Flores told him. "I've been feeling very guilty about something."

"What is it?"

"Some of the Impala parts had no receipts, so I made them on my laptop and exaggerated the value of each by twenty-five dollars. This occurred on three occasions. If anybody finds out, will I get jail time?"

Jimmy ground his teeth at Flores' levity. The man's ability to see and yet mock reality must have made him the perfect fixer for Greasley through the years.

"I understand my daughter's safety to be dependent on my actions," Jimmy said. "But your own safety is dependent on my daughter's, therefore the control you have over your fate is no less fragile than mine. I believe you're sociopathic, which is advantageous to you in violent situations because your sociopathy devalues human life, and yet I also believe you to be surprisingly emotional over the passing of Ayita Smith. You killed Abbiati because of it, so you must have loved her."

"You're no fun, Jimmy."

"I think Sandy Billings loved her, too."

"Get in the trunk."

They pulled out of the alley, down the main thoroughfare, eventually entered the border plaza. The Lincoln paused briefly again, a few quiet words spoken outside the vehicle exchanged with Flores. Then the Lincoln bumped over ruts going over the

bridge, the trunk black dark and the tires kicking gravel against the wheel wells. It sounded like big rain on a tin roof.

The rise was three hundred feet, all of which Jimmy felt in his stomach. The higher the vehicle rose, the deeper he imagined Abbiati's body to have sunk, even though the weighted oil drums had hit bottom within seconds. Was there a layer beneath what we knew, Jimmy wondered, to welcome the newly-descended?

In what world would Tio Flores exist after this one, would even Jimmy? Death scared him most when he contemplated the loneliness of it, the darkness no eyes could focus to.

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SEVENTEEN

Jimmy entered the Motor City casino after dark, crossed the lobby and waited for the elevator. The welt on his face was swollen like a purple walnut protruding from his cheekbone, shiny in the foyer mirror, the overhead lights casting golden tones.

There were text and voice messages on his phone from Campbell, Gertie Lev, and Braxton Gooding, but the calls had stopped midday. The voicemail from Gooding had been perfunctory, stating he'd received a drunken, garbled call from a purported "doctor" claiming Jimmy to be M.I.A.—out of respect, Gooding had checked in. "I hope you're okay," he'd said before hanging up.

A brief afternoon voicemail from a detective with the Detroit Police Department stated to have received a message that Jimmy'd been abducted. He requested a call back "within seven days," in order for the department to assess the validity of the call they'd received.

Jimmy rode the elevator to the fifteenth floor, entered the suite to find it littered with beer bottles, wrinkled clothing, carry-out Chinese food. A condom wrapper lay in two pieces on the carpet near the couch Jimmy'd slept on the night before. There was a glass of water spilled beside it.

In the bedroom, Gertie and Campbell were asleep together, face down and naked atop the king-size bedsheets, the air conditioning blowing like a nor'easter over their dimpled butt cheeks. Jimmy adjusted the thermostat, retrieved his blanket from the couch and hastily covered the two.

Walked back through the suite, stared out steel-framed windows to the city lights beaming like smartphone clusters across a ten-mile expanse, although many neighborhoods had no light at all.

Thought if he were ever to suicide, Detroit would be the place. Like every addict, he was often compelled to meet adversity with self-hatred and physical harm, vices Detroiters seemed to know intimately. Jimmy'd flogged himself for years with alcohol, punishment for his mother's murder, which he'd been too nearsighted to prevent. Now those urges were returning with Ally's life in the balance—his baby, whose cheeks still smelled like peeled pears, who had leapt over sprinkler heads every summer into her early teens, her laugh catching sunlight.

He spent twenty minutes on the floor of the shower, fully dressed at first, with the water running blood from his clothes that turned pink on its way to the drain. Then Jimmy was pink-naked himself under a scorch that couldn't get hot enough. He wrung his clothes, draped them over the marbled sink, tied a towel around his waist.

He looked strong in the mirror, felt he'd prepared his children to have both physical strength and mental conviction—his family should have been safe, yet he'd allowed them to roam beyond his reach. He stepped out of the bathroom, called Jennifer Hope. Sat heavily on the couch with his hair wet, legs sticking to the leather. The phone rang twice before he remembered the condom wrapper on the floor beside him, stood up again.

"Jimmy," Jen said.

Then he told her, "I've been alone, and I don't want to be anymore."

"Why are you telling me this?"

"Because there's no one else to tell it to," he said. "And because I care about you. I hope that's okay."

"It is," she said.

"There are other things, more complicated, that I've wanted to tell you about myself."

"You think I don't know that?" she asked. "I have things too, Jimmy."

"Not things like this," he told her. "Will you give me time?"

"Jimmy," she said. "I've known the man you are for years. You don't have to say the words if you don't want—I'll still know it. If

you want to know who I am, shut up and listen. We both have *things*, and the trick is to accept they're the same, even when they're different."

"I don't understand."

"You do," she said, frustrated. "Jesus, Jimmy—the real problem with our generation is that most of us were raised so right and so fucking wrong at the same time. Why do we all carry a cross?"

He could hear tears in her throat.

"I'm glad you called. Please make it home."



The plane back to Hailey left at 5:00 a.m. The private runway at DTW blurred as Jimmy closed his eyes, the fuselage lifting. He wore the 9mm on his ankle, the cell in his pocket clogged with old numbers and emails that meant little.

Five hours earlier, he'd roused Gertie. She'd conveyed her embarrassment, was in no condition to travel. Arranged his flight with her pilot. Said to Jimmy, "I guess you're safe but four shots-in, we were both still very worried."

She fell back asleep, a bag of ice on her head, arms wrapping a waste basket for nausea.

Campbell had not stirred—for the better, Jimmy'd thought. He'd carried his go-bag and a laundry sack of wet clothing out to the street, dumped it in a trash receptacle a block away. Ordered an Uber. Waited on an unlit corner.

Tio Flores had shared that Greasley's surface interest in the stadium was secondary to the lucrative venture of assisting the cartel with laundering cash—Greasley would sell them a portion of his downtown parcel at three times the going land rate to capitalize on the chaos of Boise's real estate boom, then Hillcrest was supposed to have lent construction costs to the cartel and Greasley alike, their interest payments kicked-back in purported revenue losses in perpetuity.

While the stadium would show an operating deficit, the assessed theoretical value of the structure would be leveraged for approval of additional developments downtown, also via hard money loans through Hillcrest Financial. Without the stadium, the land was worth four million, but a proper stadium in Boise's urban redevelopment core would inflate that value into hundreds of millions over the next twenty years, even if primarily empty. Brody Hawkstellar, of course, had fucked that up. But Greasley could salvage the deal, find another crooked lender among the lowlifes pouring into Idaho.

Somewhere over the Dakotas dawn rose behind them, and by touchdown in Hailey, when Jimmy awoke, the sun was low and liquidlike across the tarmac. His rental truck was where he'd left it beneath the Greasley private hangar.

Gertie's pilot stood sentry outside the Learjet's small cockpit as Jimmy disembarked, his head foggy with pain from the previous day's beating. By midnight, Flores would be arriving in Boise on another plane. Jimmy'd meet him at the airport for whatever came next, the world righted again—or opposite that, if Jimmy were unlucky, a world without righting.

On the drive south from Hailey to Twin Falls, Jimmy ruminated on the young girl above the bar in Windsor, the stream of vape smoke like cotton candy from her lips as he'd approached, her denim shorts and bra no bigger than what Jimmy's daughter might've pulled from the Junior's section in high school.

At Twin Falls, Jimmy was supposed to swing west onto I-84 toward Boise but instead drove the opposite way, arrived at Tio Flores' ungated property outside of Blackfoot just after the noon hour, the quarter-mile stretch of crushed cars rusted and squat, dusted by sunlight up the driveway as Jimmy approached the residence. The big tires crunched over gravel. A glare crossed his windshield and half-blinded him.

The home's nutmeg exterior flattened in direct sunlight. The heavy canvas curtains were closed. The outbuildings showed no activity. Flores' Appaloosa rested on her belly in the pasture.

Jimmy stepped out of the truck, once again felt a sense of déjà vu. Stepped across the property to the front door, feeling he'd stepped there previously—perhaps there were parallel lives, he thought, each manifestation only slightly off-sync.

He broke through the cheap lock on the door with a flurry of kicks. The twenty-dollar doorknob set lay in pieces on the ground.

The interior of the residence was primarily empty of furniture, the walls whitewashed. The stench of bleach or industrial sanitizer permeated the barren space. In a small bathroom, he found the origin of the stench—a five-gallon paint bucket containing a recently-skinned, razor-toothed fox skull soaking in what must have been twelve inches of straight Clorox.

There were three bedrooms, only one furnished, utilitarian. It contained a platform bed and mattress, makeshift nightstand of stacked cinder blocks, punched-tin cross of Jesus above the bed and a Bushmaster AR-15 semiautomatic rifle safety-mounted upside down through a locked, steel housing just below the cross. On the floor beneath the rifle, a shoebox was loaded with thirty-round clips. Jimmy sat on the edge of the bed, smelled Flores' effluvium rising from the sheets.

Hanging inside the open closet was a row of blue jeans and work shirts draped over plastic hangers. On the floor, a milk crate brimmed with rolled tube socks and laundered cotton briefs.

The rear of the closet was drywall, primed flat white but unfinished. In contrast, the rest of the house was lathe and plaster, painted in a rich semi-gloss sheen noticeable even without sunlight hitting the walls.

Jimmy stood from the bed, inspected the rear of the closet. The paint strokes along the seam where drywall met the surrounding plaster were incongruous. He pushed the hangers to either side.

Then he placed both hands against the drywall sheeting, let his palms briefly linger, curled the knuckles of one hand. Gently, he tapped across the wall, finding the hollows.

In a common home, the studs behind a wall tended to run every sixteen inches from floor to ceiling, leaving room for wiring, plumbing, insulation, and regulated structural support. Jimmy

could tell that the wooden studs of the closet had been customized in their spacing, its largest gap running approximately thirty inches across center.

He stepped back. Then he stepped forward again with a chest-high front kick that propelled his black tactical shoe through the drywall, its gypsum crumbling between the studs. With both hands, Jimmy ripped at the hole, methodically tore out a gully that exposed five equally sized shrink-wrapped bricks of cash containing what looked to be about \$100,000 per package.

Every millionaire with a hustle had their get-out stash. Jimmy'd found Tio Flores'—he pulled it from the wall, stacked the bundles on the bedroom floor while coughing drywall dust.

Walked around the home, found no other anomalies.

Stepped outside and viewed the structure's extremities from thirty feet. The sun angled across the shingled roofline and the doorway and concrete step were unadorned, with only tufts of common sage as shrubbery. Like the rear of the closet, the home itself seemed a false front, in contrast to Flores' personality and business interests.

Two hundred yards across the property were three ramshackle barns, a hundred-foot grain storage facility, and a vehicle crusher and scrap lot full of junk metal from which Flores had pulled his Escalade on Jimmy's first visit. Jimmy made his way across the dirt.

The grain building was corrugated metal upon a ventilated concrete foundation, steel-framed with a twenty-foot rollup door, the roof pitch thirty degrees to protect it from snow and rain. The bolted steel panels flashed in sunlight. Jimmy touched his palm to the heated metal, a sweetness like motor oil in the air—he thought of his son, the boy born almost yesterday and his skin smelling of breastmilk, then toothpaste, then deodorant, then musk within the brief time it'd taken Jimmy for a handshake with whomever our God was, to make the deal to love his son but let him leave. The boy was the glint Jimmy saw in everyday things, a reminder of how little we can know but how beautiful it was to guess.

The rollup door had no access handle. Most likely it operated electronically, although an adjacent entry door was protected only by a commercial keypad lock with a nickel-plated lever. Jimmy ransacked a tool cache beside the vehicle crusher, returned with a crosshead screwdriver and ancient-looking twenty-four-inch cast iron plumbing wrench that must've weighed ten pounds.

Destroyed the lock after successive strikes, shards of metal flying. Rotated the screwdriver into the locking mechanism and pulled the steel door open. A shaft of sunlight crossed the breach and Jimmy stepped into otherwise total darkness. Reached his hand to the wall and found a wiring cable that ran to a switch box.

Flipped the switch as a row of high-hanging LEDs radiated downward from girders, onto a clutter of camping cots in makeshift sleeping quarters. Enough room for twenty girls, Jimmy saw. At the back of the room was a steel work desk pushed against the wall. He walked slowly past the cots, opened the large file drawer of the desk. Inside it, he found a leather-bound, handwritten ledger containing profit-and-loss accounting of Flores' business transactions, and a list of addresses along an operational route from Windsor, Ontario to Puerto Vallarta, Mexico. Jimmy closed his eyes, breathed deeply through his nose to slow his heart rate.

Suddenly, he knew he would eventually drink again.

There among the cots, some with strands of long hair left across ten-dollar farmhouse pillows by girls who'd laid their heads while waiting for transport, Jimmy thought about revenge, an urge he'd long been familiar with.

He'd been young while on the beat, snuck into the Garden City Police Department evidence room after a shift, only weeks after his daughter's birth, then surreptitiously removed the freezer-bagged .22 throwdown revolver from a banker's box associated with his mother's case. In the absence of his ability to save his mother's life, Jimmy'd brought home the pistol that killed her, swore to use it on her doer one day.

But after years on the force, he'd pushed away thoughts of vengeance. Had become a grown man, almost overnight,

understood that protecting his daughter's future was more important than misguided attempts to triage Jimmy's past. His daughter had been everything he cared about. He had acquiesced to a curried indifference for his own life, so long as Ally was safe. And then later, his son. What else mattered, in the history of humankind?

Jimmy'd practiced a stoicism that Tio Flores had now intruded upon.



At five minutes to midnight, Jimmy sat in his truck in the pickup line at Boise Airport, waiting for the last flight in from the Midwest.

As a boy, the sky above him had been starry, the clean air chasing across Idaho all the way from the Pacific. Now the entirety of Boise seemed bathed in halogens at night, the nearest dark-sky preserve a hundred and fifty miles east. A week's inversion could leave the Treasure Valley with a brownish stain from fires burning even hundreds of miles away, smoke smelling of burnt sap drifting in. Forest Service jumpers leapt out of planes all summer long so the rest of the state could remain oblivious to the causal effect of the fossil fuels needed for its oversized trucks. The world was on fire, and life as we knew it could change in an instant, but Tio Flores wanted to force Jimmy's hand? The man's hubris was insulting.

Who the fuck do people think they are?

At exactly midnight, Jimmy pulled up curbside at the terminal.

Flores, wearing jeans and an untucked work shirt, walked out with a duffle over his shoulder, a black rollaway bag in hand. Tossed them both into the back of Jimmy's truck and stepped up into the passenger seat, a hard candy chiming in his teeth like rolled dice. But Flores also had his fists clenched as if ready to break Jimmy's orbital bone.

Flores shut the door, but Jimmy didn't drive.

“I assume you watched me on the cameras mounted across your property, three covering the exterior and one inside the slave quarters you run your girls through,” Jimmy said. “Maybe an app on your phone live-streamed me?”

“That’s right, Jimmy. I was in Greek Town eating a late lunch before leaving for the airport, and there you were on the little television in my palm. Have you ever had saganaki?”

“It’s that cheese they light on fire.”

“Right at the table, and then the waiter shouts ‘Opa!’ because he’s excited. I thought of you in that moment, Jimmy, and of the many creative ways to inflict pain. When all is said and done, you and your daughter may have scars.”

“No, motherfucker,” Jimmy said. “You got this backward.”

He handed Flores a stylized ballpoint pen with a silver clip then added, “That’s a voice activated audio recorder. We’ll go up to Coeur d’Alene and get my daughter alright, but in addition to your cash and the deed to the land, I grabbed your ledger. You’re gonna wear that while you talk to the senator or the last breath you take in this life will be a mouthful of hollow points.”

EIGHTEEN

They exited the airport terminal with eight hours of travel ahead, Jimmy having pivoted the power dynamic to his favor. Every minute or so, Flores cleared his throat when the sugars from a hard candy he'd popped into his mouth saturated his esophagus.

A steady stream of semis on the freeway to Eagle Road were driving toward Oregon, where weed was legal and the ocean directly west, nearly equidistant to the far northern country of Idaho where Jimmy and Flores would arrive after daybreak.

The big box stores they passed on Eagle Road—Hobby Lobby, Petco, Bed Bath & Beyond—glowed alien against the dark of high-stakes life, the suburban economy of privilege bursting with demand for nonessentials.

At the Shell station just before turning north toward Horseshoe Bend, Flores pulled his .32 caliber handgun and concealment holster from his rollaway bag, loaded the weapon and strapped it to his waist. Jimmy watched through the window from the checkout line with two coffees and a sixteen-ounce bag of beef jerky. Knew that when he got back into the truck, Flores could maybe put the gun to Jimmy's head, take Jimmy to the gravel quarry off State Street, leave him bleeding in the stones. But then life for Flores would take a dramatic turn, Jimmy knew—Flores' fate mimicking Jimmy's, ending with the cartel. Maybe Flores' sun-bleached skeleton in the desert a year from now, the vultures playing Pick-Up Sticks with his bones.

"Did you get me cigarettes?" Flores asked when Jimmy came back and let him take a coffee.

"Why would I do that?"

Flores went inside, returned with cigarettes. Within forty-five minutes they were deep into the mountains with the windows cracked and the night air coming off cold and dark from the

Payette River where Jimmy's kids used to wade in the shallows. Even then, in the mottled sunlight on day trips, their potato chips and water bottles shaded from the heat, their beach towels laid across boulders, Jimmy'd been painfully aware of there being no way around none of them living forever.

Greasley had wanted to dangle Jimmy's daughter as bait for the deed, wipe both her and Jimmy from the tabletop like crumbs. Instead, Flores now offered an exit strategy for Jimmy and Ally, so long as Jimmy soldiered-up and assisted Flores in retrieving the sixteen million from the casino heist, along with Greasley's head.

If Jimmy'd refused, he might have joined Abbiati in a pair of oil barrels at the bottom of the Detroit River, maybe thirty years from now reappeared when the river and Great Lakes were siphoned as a freshwater reserve. Or he could have choked Flores out, laid his body across the tiles next to Abbiati's dead body in the basement of the bar when Flores proposed his deal, gone looking for his daughter and never found even remnants.

Flores, though, had mistaken Jimmy's compliance to be fear-driven. Although Jimmy understood how brutally and quickly tides changed, it wasn't fear but love for Ally that functioned as his motivator. Love made Jimmy gamble in a way that fear could not.

He remained cop-enough to recognize that when a perp began bargaining, they exposed a weakness, a lever to pull. Flores feared the cartel more than he feared Greasley. All Jimmy had to do was keep Flores in the box, put the pressure on, let him crack into halves from his own steam, the way the mountains to either side of them, tight and high, were pocked by geothermal grottos that'd built-upward from millions of years of boiling-hot water looking for a way out. An exit plan, what most criminals eventually wanted.

There was no cell service, and Jimmy took the road cautiously between switchbacks for ninety minutes until he opened up the F-150 on a starry straightaway through Round Valley, into the lake town of Cascade, when his phone pinged with messages from Campbell and Gertie Lev.

On the other side of Payette Lake on West Mountain Road was a three-hundred square-foot clapboard cabin where Jimmy's wife used to take the kids for weekend getaways when they were tiny. Jimmy sometimes going along, more often staying in Boise to work a case—if things were heated between him and his wife, emotionally regroup. Weekends Jimmy couldn't get back now, the children grown, their earliest childhood memories sometimes itemized without him.

Flores had fallen asleep with a light snore like a hum that slipped from his nostrils into the bubble of the F-150's cockpit. He stirred briefly when the elevation rose at a 7% grade into the pitch-black of White Bird summit. In sleep Flores turned his body toward the passenger-side window. Perhaps to gain purchase, curled his knees like a child.

They were nearly in the clouds, the canyon descending a mile beneath them where the U.S. military, propping up gold mining operations four generations ago, invaded the Nez Perce on a sixteen-hundred-acre battlefield that'd become sodden with blood. The area was still haunted by violence. Jimmy'd been burned on a White Bird surveillance job ten years ago, had a Mossberg shotgun leveled at him through the open window of his truck. He'd been doing a workman's comp for the insurance company, those miners of that sacred space within each of us known as privacy. The man pulled the trigger but the gunpowder in the shell casing had accidentally been soaked in motor oil leaking from a cannister in the claimant's garage, didn't ignite when the pin hit the primer. Jimmy dove out the passenger side of his vehicle then ran through the woods. The man did six years for attempted murder then sent Jimmy a postcard from India to the State Farm office that read only, "Eat shit."

Flores slept for another hour, awakened after Jimmy refueled at the Chevron station outside of Potlach. The temperature was down to thirty-eight degrees, the roads were wet and slick through the mountains. Five minutes down the road, the F-150 caught black ice at three thousand feet and Jimmy's heart took a shot of adrenaline.

He slowed the vehicle. Flores wiped his eyes while sitting up, said to Jimmy, "Do you want to know what I was dreaming back there?"

"This isn't a camping trip, Flores."

"It's painful to hear you call me by my last name," Flores told him. "Although I understand why referring to me as 'uncle' would put a tickle in your shoot."

"Police officers and investigators more commonly use the surname in our report writing. It's an unconscious practice carried into my life. It's not meant to offend you."

"Perhaps you're an obsessive," Flores said. "I wonder if we have killed the same amount of people in our nightmares."

He untwisted a restaurant hard candy, peppermint with red swirls, popped it into his mouth and added, "I was dreaming that Ayita was riding her two-wheeler with the training wheels attached. Can we stop for a cigarette?"

At the next pullout, Jimmy veered into the gravel. Parked and put on his hazards. They stepped out into the cold mountain air, stood beside a guard rail lining a five-hundred-foot drop to a forest that seemed nebulous in the dark. Flores lit a cigarette.

The vellum sky above them was clouded, the hazard lights blinking fat and red against their skin. Jimmy remembered the pressure of Ayita's curvature against his own, the scent of her natural oils when he'd clutched her.

"All of these bodies for money?" Jimmy asked.

"Money, yes, but also pride. I already told you Grisham wants the stadium to be his mausoleum. It's because he has end of the road pancreatic cancer."

Flores stamped his cigarette into the gravel. "You've misinterpreted my affection for Ayita. I loved her as if she were my own child. I gave money to her mother for years, at first as Greasley's fixer. I was only twenty years old. Later, I gave from my own pocket."

"Why would you do that?"

"Because God told me to."



At exactly daybreak, they drove a mile through fire road switchbacks, crossed a murky streambed with the tires splashing water into the wheel wells, finally pulled into a quarter-acre clearing in the pines where a one-room, off-grid cedar cabin awaited on Greasley's thousand acres in the heavy forests west of Coeur d'Alene. The flora was still wet with dew, strands of nightfall still caught on the branches like silver cotton gently tearing-away with daylight.

"I planted that cedar by hand twenty years ago," Flores pointed.

They stepped out of the truck. The ground was soggy with conifer needles underfoot. Overhead, a brown raptor crossed the sky, and Jimmy felt a wave of nausea.

Flores unlocked the cabin, returned a few moments later with a Ruger .308 scoped sniper rifle under one arm like a loaf of bread. His rough hands cupped two fully loaded clips. He set the ammo and weapon into the back of Jimmy's truck, crossed the clearing, entered a cedar-framed outhouse with a moon-shaped window carved through the wall for ventilation. Pulled the outhouse door shut behind him.

Jimmy walked to the cabin, went inside. A wall of canned goods abutted a propane-based kitchenette, the remainder of the two-hundred-square-foot room sparsely furnished with platform bed, two-person antique dining table, unpolished wooden chairs. In an open footlocker, from which Flores must have grabbed the sniper rifle, additional loaded clips for the .308 were stacked like decks of cards. A row of emptied twenty-ounce Gatorade bottles held what looked to be several thousand rounds of .22 LR ammunition for a Smith and Wesson semi-automatic sport rifle leaning in a corner behind the kitchenette. Also in the footlocker were several Tupperware containers loaded with full metal jacket ammo and clips for Flores' .32 caliber, which he kept on his person.

Jimmy heard the outhouse door open then bang closed. Glanced out the window. Flores tightened his belt, stopped just

shy of the porch to light a cigarette. Jimmy stepped out to join him.

“Your choice of sidearm is unexpected,” Jimmy said. “The .22 rifle inside makes sense for small game, and the .308 in my truck is of tactical interest, but the Walther on your hip is quirky.”

Flores shielded the sun from his eyes, a trail of cigarette smoke rising from the fingertips above his hairline. He squinted at Jimmy.

“The .32 ACP is generally considered an ‘offense-only’ handgun,” Jimmy continued. “It’s primarily used against unarmed civilians since the caliber isn’t competitive with the modern .45 or 9mm options most commonly seen in a firefight. The Nazis used .32s against Jews who either wouldn’t get on the trains or had outlived their ableness for labor at the concentration camps. Adolph Hitler committed suicide with a .32 ACP.”

Flores hit from his cigarette, his exhalation like yellow pollen in the sunlight, said to Jimmy, “I don’t know about that. Grisham gave it to me for my twenty-first birthday.”

“I’m not surprised.”

“It occurs to me that wild animals wouldn’t have this conversation, Jimmy, since they kill each other with their face.” Flores locked on Jimmy’s eyes, adding, “Some of the police officers in Pocatello like to deepthroat chorizo. I don’t think you’re a homosexual, but what are you?”

Jimmy wondered if he should kill Flores right now. It would be easy.

When Jimmy didn’t answer, Flores went inside, put two cans of white bean soup on the stove, stuffed an extra Walther magazine into each of his front pockets. From a small, double-hung window above the kitchenette, sunlight divided the room—one moment Flores in complete darkness, the next moment crossing to full exposure again.

Jimmy stepped inside, too. Sat in one of the chairs, noticed how insignificant Flores looked while domesticated: A wooden spoon in his hand, the way he stirred the small pot and sniffed at the steam rising.

"I hear things on repeat," Jimmy told him. "I memorize license plates without trying, all the way down the road for miles at a stretch. Fluorescent lights make my skin crawl. The sound of a woman's high heels crossing marble can be louder than a thunderstorm. I can read and write backwards for extended periods but there's never been a reason to."

Flores cocked his head. "Are you high?"

"You wondered if I was obsessive. I'm autistic, about twenty percent of me. I've been spelling your name in my head for hours without wanting to: F-L-O-R-E-S, like the sound of tires rolling over themselves through the mountains. Like a heartbeat you don't think about until you put your palms over your ears and hear it inside you before realizing there's no getting away from it." Jimmy paused, then added, "I suspect you'll be inside me for many years after you're dead, and I'll hate every damned minute of it . . . but the way fire hates what it eats and eats in anyway."

The pot of soup bubbled into the burner cap with a smell like singed hair.

"You're weird," Flores said.



They ate at the table. Flores drew a map of Greasley's compound, including the gun towers Jimmy'd observed online. Within an hour they were back in Jimmy's truck, bouncing through switchbacks to a paved, two-lane road squeezed by forest, primarily untraveled.

"Grisham owns this too, on both sides," Flores said. The audio pen was clipped inside the shirt pocket where he carried his cigarettes. "Have you ever owned land?"

"No."

"Some people work their whole lives to own one acre. Those people become translucent to people like Grisham."

"I don't disagree with you, but there are two things that matter to me today," Jimmy told him. "Each of us doing what we said we would do, and you shutting the fuck up."

Jimmy drove a mile farther, then Flores directed him down an abandoned forestry turnoff that was overgrown, too tight for the F-150 and scraping the truck's side panels with scrub vegetation. He stopped the vehicle then cut the engine.

Got out.

Flores scooted into the driver's seat, rolled down the window and lit a cigarette with his Bic.

"Keep looking left as you walk," he told Jimmy. "In a quarter mile, there'll be a sun break. You'll see the turret a hundred yards off."

Jimmy took the .308 clips from the bed of the pickup. Grabbed the rifle, said to Flores, "This is one of those deals that nobody wants. I'm trusting we have the same motivation, to walk out with what's most valuable to us."

He leaned the rifle against the F-150, reached across to Flores' shirt pocket, clasped the audio pen. Gently pushed down the silver clip while Flores held the coal of his cigarette at bay.

"That's recording now," Jimmy said.

"It felt like you were straightening my tie before prom," Flores said. "All of this behind us, we might be friends one day, Jimmy."

"Unlikely." Jimmy picked up the rifle then added, "Give me ten minutes."

He started walking, the soil beneath his tactical shoes rutted and damp, the foliage around him concentrated with the scent of conifer drifts. The sun was higher now, its early heat perceptible above the hardwood and pine crowns.

In the silence a few minutes later, Jimmy could hear the truck's engine restarting with a healthy torque and Flores backing onto the paved road.

To Jimmy's left, the forest was suddenly thicker with evergreens. Daylight streamed through creases. Jimmy stepped off the trail with the rifle in both hands at his chest, the denser underbrush raking at his legs.

He stopped just shy of the edge of the woods, with a view of Greasley's compound. The three-story turret was unmanned, built of raw block like an industrial stairwell shaft leading only to the

sky. Greasley's mansion and guest home appeared constructed of stone and old growth timber on a two-acre pasture, across which another turret stood at attention from the edge of a hardwood grove shielding two bunk houses of stick frame and stucco.

The turrets were stylistically out of place, likely built hastily in the late 1990s when North Idaho supremacist factions faced media scrutiny, feared a government takeover of their land and belief systems under the Democratic presidency.

No movement was visible, either outside the residence or through its wood-framed casement windows cranked open for morning ventilation. Jimmy stayed low, hurried to the back wall of the turret, rested briefly. Then, he advanced around the turret's blind side, ducked into the stairwell. Remained concealed as he ascended to an open-air platform with a rebar-and-block roof. Its forty-eight-inch protective wall hid him from the residence and outbuildings while he squatted comfortably, caught his breath.

Crouched out of sight, Jimmy set aside the rifle, secured a pair of iPhone buds into his ears, now sweating behind the lobes. The audio pen on Flores was communicating via satellite to the app in Jimmy's phone, a recording that duplicated itself in the cloud. He could hear Flores breathing, heard gravel crunching under the big F-150 tires.

Jimmy peaked over the ledge to an oversized stone carport on the eastern side of the residence, a quarter mile stretch of driveway leading to it from the woods. Flores was advancing slowly, dust floating up from the gravel.

BPD Lieutenant Big and Tall, Evelyn Hawkstellar, and an unknown Aryan goon accompanied Grisham Greasley as he exited the residence, navigated the gravel driveway in house shoes. Slightly hunched as if suffering from back pain, Greasley no longer the towering figure of his youth. The four crossed beneath the shadow of the carport, emerged into sunlight, awaiting Flores.

Jimmy rested the sniper rifle on the edge of the protective wall, put the scope on Greasley. The man appeared pallid in direct sunlight, his lips deflated and anemic. His eyes perhaps familiar, but Jimmy'd never met him in person, knew him only from news

reports through the years. The folds of his neck now hung like curtains drawn-open to glimpse the dying.

The scope's crosshairs, centered tightly on Greasley's forehead now, reminded Jimmy of the four appendages of a black swastika against the man's aged, pale white skin.

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NINETEEN

Jimmy eyed the Aryan goon standing just behind Greasley in a marshmallow-white tee shirt that looked freshly pulled from the plastic it'd come in, a crease down each side. His biceps bulged like Olympic shotputs: right forearm tattooed with the depiction of a mass grave whose corpses wore the Star of David on their sleeves, left forearm with the image of Jesus sporting a neck tattoo spelling "Aryan" in black calligraphy, a near match to the ink on the goon's own neck with faded prison script across distended veins. Beneath his Adam's apple were twin lightning bolts, homage to the Nazi S.S. Everything you needed to know about the man.

Evelyn Hawkstellar was standing to Greasley's left, her oil-black hair pulled into a bun, the nape of her milk-colored neck swanlike yet stark above a tailored ivory pantsuit. Her fingernails manicured but unpainted. She rested her hands on pointed hip bones just above her trouser line. When Flores' windshield refracted sunlight across her face, she squinted, brought a hand flatly to her brow. Jimmy wondered why she wasn't downstate beside the body of her son, why mourning Brody Hawkstellar had been displaced by Evelyn's ministering to the business needs of Grisham Greasley.

Big and Tall wore tactical khakis, chest bulging beneath a cobalt golf shirt wrinkling over the print of his sidearm. He was sweating in the sunlight, the TAG Heuer wristwatch glinting. Jimmy was surprised to see him, until he wasn't—Big and Tall's security presence for the mayor's Sun Valley jaunts would've put him in contact with Greasley, and there was also no way Abbiati had been able to skirt his police department responsibilities without Tall's acquiescence. Abbiati now seemed unlikely to have been a shot caller, more likely just Big and Tall's punk in the hierarchy.

Jimmy scoped tightly on Greasley's visage and even from this distance recognized disease in the man's eyes, a skim across the soup of his soul. In press coverage through the years, Grisham Greasley had appeared the iconic Idahoan, healthy and hard-boned, but now the curvature of his back had dropped him by inches, the dimple of his chin sagging from muscle loss and gravity.

Flores parked and stepped out, the additional .32 clips in his pockets and the pistol holstered inside his rear belt seam. Gravel crunching under his boots and Flores' breath and the jangle of hard candy amplified in Jimmy's earbuds.

Flores had a plum-colored wound across his forehead, splatters of blood on his shirt, none of it there ten minutes ago. He'd likely pistol-whipped himself after Jimmy walked off. It was a nice touch to sell to Grisham, but Jimmy worried things could go wrong. Flores openly carrying the extra mags was stupid, Jimmy's scope in broad daylight might glint—and Ally was nowhere visible.

Even before Flores stopped walking, Big and Tall's voice boomed with testosterone.

"Where's Chinden?"

"Shot in the leg and cuffed inside my cabin," Flores replied. Stopped and lit a cigarette and Jimmy saw blood across the ridge of his knuckles. Greasley saw it too, which Jimmy supposed was Flores' point. "We got in early, so I stopped to check my propane and the cunt ambushed me."

Evelyn Hawkstellar surveyed Flores like a seamstress. "Why didn't you grab the deed and kill him?"

Flores exhaled smoke with a flourish. Cleared his throat and said, "That's the other thing that nobody wants to hear. I think the deed might be rolled up into his poophole. I searched everywhere else and couldn't find it, but he swears on his daughter's life he brought it along."

"So you assume it's in his ass?" Big and Tall asked.

"The average anal cavity is eight inches long," Flores said. "I know a guy who claimed to have kept a Nokia cell phone in his ass for eleven days in prison. Chinden's an ex-cop who knows the

tricks. Plus, I think he's a fag who's maybe used to bottoming on trombones the length and girth of a coffee thermos from the looks of him."

Jimmy's trigger finger itched. He suspected he could clear every last one of them from his vantage overhead, ping them like ducks in a swimming pool.

"He's a *what*?" Greasley asked.

"A pipe fitter," Big and Tall chortled.

"Either way, we can't kill the guy until we know where the paper is," Flores said.

"We don't even know where Abbiati is yet," Big N' Tall responded. He stepped six inches closer to Flores. Jimmy could see the muscle in the back of Tall's jaw like a walnut shifting beneath the skin before he added, "He hasn't called you?"

"No," Flores told him. Tall looming over him made Flores sniff with discomfort, wipe a forefinger beneath his nose like clearing the last long snot in this world he cared to think about.

He carefully peeked around Tall's massive chest, said to Greasley, "Grisham, get this fucking bell tower out of my face."

Greasley walked between the two men, purposefully separated them on his way to the truck, ran a hand along its hood. He swiveled in his house shoes, said to Flores, "You checked this?"

"What I could of it," Flores told him.

Greasley nodded his head reflectively then asked Evelyn, "What do you think?"

"That these idiots should take the truck apart before you decide on anything," she told him. "I don't know what you do about the girl and Chinden, though. That was a bad idea from the beginning. You acted impetuously, which isn't like you."

Greasley smiled at her counsel then admitted, "I regret those decisions, but I've killed easier and for a lot less. Goddamn money—it can be thicker than a blindfold."

At the far end of the pasture, a thin-bodied white-tailed doe and her single fawn gingerly stepped from the woods, froze like mannequins when Greasley lifted his head to watch them. He started to talk, involuntarily coughed-up phlegm before spitting it

at the gravel in frustration. The whitetails hopped back into the woods.

When he caught his breath, Greasley told the Aryan goon, "Go to the garage and bring out whatever tools are needed to chop this thing to the bones if we have to." Turned his face into the sunlight, closed his eyes and said, "I used to get a lot of pussy in weather like this."

Jimmy scoped on the man's eyelids and for a second thought his lens sprinkled sunlight across Greasley's face, eyeballs flickering briefly beneath palpebra the color of starched rice.

Greasley looked at peace with himself, his satin skin translucent with age. He opened his eyes then turned to Flores and asked, "Tio, when's the last time I smoked one of your cigarettes?"

"New Year's Eve of 1999," Flores told him. "We were waiting for the Y2K shutdown. You thought the world was ending, so you had five million in cash converted to gold bars sitting in your panic room in case nobody could get to banks for a while. You had a bad feeling in your stomach and thought the nicotine would help."

"That's right," Greasley said. "But you only had three cigarettes left, even though the universe as we knew it was collapsing at midnight."

"It didn't."

"I admit that now," Greasley said. "You were often one step ahead of me, I suppose. You've become a modestly rich man, through a combination of my assistance and your own hard work, but if you'd been white you could have been wealthy. That's a testament to your character."

Greasley shuffled his shoes in the gravel. "Let me have one of those Camels, Tio."

Flores took the pack from his shirt pocket and shook out a cigarette.

Greasley took it in his fingertips, wrapped his feeble lips around the filter as Flores produced a flame. The old man inhaled deeply, appeared dizzy. The balls of his feet lifted slightly

backward until his balance caught up with the surge of nicotine in his brain.

Flores re-pocketed his Bic but struggled momentarily to manipulate the pack of cigarettes back into his shirt beside the audio recorder. Greasley studied Flores' calloused fingers forcing the soft pack of Camels along its edges.

Then the slots of Greasley's eyes suddenly dilated. He said to Flores, "I've never known you to carry a pen."

Jimmy knew the jig was up when Flores flicked his own cigarette across the gravel and didn't otherwise respond. Flores rolled a fist, coughed his hard candy into it, tossed it aside. In the sunlight, his face looked like stretched leather on a drum, his black eyes the density of ore.

Overhead at twenty-thousand feet, a jet trail from north to south marked the airspace as if the finger of God were drawing against a prison wall to tally Day 1 in a personal hell Jimmy couldn't yet see coming, the sky a deep blue and the tracer the color of autopsy cotton traveling downstate.

Greasley watched the contrail cross his property, swiveled his head and seemed to look directly at Jimmy's scope in its perch across the pasture. Perhaps he'd seen its light refracting or perhaps through Greasley's age and deterioration the man saw nothing now but Flores' blind devotion having turned rotten.

The sun had risen by a degree. Even through Jimmy's lens he saw the likeness of Ayita Smith in Greasley's eyes, her presence diluted but surfacing through the film of sickness like a mercurial light rising from the bottom of a pond.

Greasley rotated back, said to Tio sharply, "I pulled you from a sarcophagus in *Culiacán*, you prick. You were so poor that bitch you impregnated was hanging laundry off your rib cage. The cartel had you doing hits for a sandwich and a blow job, Tio. Did you forget that?"

"I don't forget anything, Grisham," Flores said.

He pulled the pen from his shirt pocket, gripped the cap and derby tightly. A squirrel ran across the gravel as a high-elevation breeze crossed the back of Jimmy's neck, pattering and cold. Then

Flores spiked the pen into the side of Greasley's neck as easily as puncturing a juice box with a straw.

Greasley fell, clutching just behind his carotid artery with a hand that trembled wildly at first, blood leaking through his fingertips when he found the wound.

Big and Tall said, "Mother fuck," and immediately reached to pull his service weapon on Flores. Before he could draw, Jimmy put a two-inch-long .308 slug directly between the man's massive right deltoid and chest muscles, the thunder of the sniper rifle shaking at the wooded circumference of the pasture. Big and Tall did not go down easily, lived for another eleven seconds, shifting from foot to foot as if on hot coals. With his left hand, he managed to unholster his service weapon and fire three rounds at Flores but missed with each. Flores fired backward as he ran for cover behind the truck's passenger side bumper and quarter panel.

Big and Tall, remaining in the open, flipped his service weapon into his right hand and with his healthy left arm grabbed Evelyn Hawkstellar around her neck. Tried to drag her across the gravel as a shield, but Flores put a round into Evelyn's thigh, causing her weight to drop. Big and Tall struggled, relinquished Evelyn. In that moment, Jimmy put a round into the side of Big and Tall's forehead that made the man's feet pop six inches off the gravel.

There was relative silence, only the sound of the shot echoing backward through Jimmy's earbuds. Then he descended the turret with his chest heaving, the rifle in his arms, his feet almost floating on their own accord in a tunnel vision that took him across the pasture at a heavy clip.

Greasley's goon rushed from behind the house now, firing on Flores, who dropped to a knee and artfully put three rounds into the goon's torso in a pattern that opened his stomach. The goon held his intestines in his hands. Flores walked past him toward the residence firing two rounds into the man's chest to end his life.

By the time Jimmy'd crossed the pasture and reached the gravel driveway, Flores was no longer visible. Evelyn Hawkstellar was lying on her back in a pool of blood that appeared to have been leaking out of the femoral artery of her leg. Three feet away, Big

and Tall's brain matter looked like a bevy of garden mollusks. His service weapon lay in the gravel near Evelyn.

Positioned parallel was Grisham Greasley, very much alive for now but with a five-inch pen buried three inches into his neck. He lay perfectly still on his back, arms and legs as uniform as a man inside a CAT scan machine. Appeared to be either in shock or simply unable to move. Jimmy set the rifle down and squatted to hear Greasley's labored breaths, could smell his breakfast through a cranked-open mouth that would surely welcome flies into it soon.

"Hi, Gee-Gee," Jimmy said. "You don't know me, but Rudolph Hillcrest stole my mother's motel and maybe even put two bullets in her first. I don't care if you live or die but if you were complicit in my mother's death, either of those two existences will be hell for you."

Greasley's eyes were unblinking, colored slightly turquoise, drenched in sunlight when he said into the sky, "Of course I know you. You're my son."

At that moment, Evelyn Hawkstellar, lying on her side with one hand clutching uselessly at the hole in her leg, lifted Big and Tall's service weapon six inches off the gravel with the other and rapidly fired a series of .45 slugs that disappeared inside Greasley's torso. Then she pointed the service weapon at Jimmy's head, firing another round. The bullet grazed the back of his skull at just over five hundred miles per hour, cruising speed of the Greasley family Learjet.

Jimmy was knocked unconscious. In that dark moratorium between what he knew of his life and what was to come, in that axis between the bullet ricocheting off bone and Jimmy's head hitting the ground, there were large-winged birds in the sky, or at least Jimmy thought they were birds, and their undercarriages were silhouetted the color of blackstrap molasses that ripped across the sunlight and took Jimmy aloft.

TWENTY

Under the black curtain of oblivion, Jimmy did not experience thought or emotion for roughly sixty seconds, while overhead the pair of golden eagles he'd seen continued to soar on wide-open wingspans, their eighty-inch breadths of plumage designed specifically for flight, the five thousand contour feathers along each chest and abdomen greased and outlined for thrust.

As Jimmy came to, he saw from his childhood vantage—he had been three years of age, maybe—the land around Tio Flores' property wind-blasted and sunburned across the expanse. There had been more Appaloosas back then, plus two black sedans coated in dust like powdered sugar from hood to trunk and along the wells of each silver-rimmed wheel.

Jimmy's mother in one of the sedans.

Jimmy waited for her in the gravel with the sage-dust in his eyelashes and his eyeline precisely at the sloped radiator grill stuffed with the carcasses of highway crickets. Droplets of sweat along his hairline relentlessly dragged salt into his eyes but were cooling in the afternoon heat. Jimmy's mother exited the sedan now, took his hand, stepped into the rear chamber of the second sedan, the driver blowing the air conditioning and humming to himself. Jimmy fell asleep in his mother's lap along a roaring stretch of highway, the smell of cigarette smoke and musk in her skirt.

And now he felt his daughter before awakening fully—no, he smelled her skin, which since her childhood had a primary scent of waterlogged bark, hair oil, diluted vanilla, then fruit in the fall, changing with the seasons. His eyes opened and closed, opened again. He saw the bodies around him. Greasley and Big and Tall and Evelyn Hawkstellar and the Aryan goon all having bled out into the gravel at once.

“Dad,” he heard his daughter say, and when he closed his eyes again, briefly heard Ally’s voice echoing in turning fragments like a kaleidoscope. Her hand on Jimmy’s shoulder now. He felt it, reopened his eyes. The two golden eagles circled a mile above him, hunting in the clear blue sky.

He felt his mother’s fingertips tracing the root of his neck as if searching for Jimmy’s pulse, heard the electronic window of the car she rode in inching-downward, the sound of his mother’s Bic lighting a Pall Mall, the eagles above him dipping together as if holding hands.

What had Jimmy been designed for, the doorway between present and past so diaphanous he could reach his hand and clear a whole lifetime like cobwebs to find his childhood ornamented by the same heartbreak and longings as now?

In Ally he saw his lost mother, his love wide and unending. He had honored his biological instinct for care by raising Ally beneath the radiance of adoration, a substitute for his inability to rescue her from the world. Were his recollections of his mother cherished more because of the woman’s absence, the cherishing of children greater because they leave?

In Ayita, he had nourished the same instinct, to care for those who would depart—No, Ayita was something different.

And what had Greasley told him, You’re my son?

Tio Flores stood over Jimmy now, the sun hot along his shoulders but the man’s face in the shadows, the .32 snug in his waistband.

Flores said to Ally, “Let’s get him up, Skinny.”

Ally’s arms wrapped Jimmy’s torso. He rose to her chest. She cradled him. Jimmy’s wound wetted her scoop-necked top—modern black, her favorite color since high school, the journalist’s outfit, black on jeans, or in high heat sometimes white on jeans. Jimmy often dressed the same way, in a uniform of sorts, something he later learned was a characteristic of his mental biomarkers. He wanted to hold Ally in his arms the way he’d done when she was three, when she was five, when she was nine, not the other way around like this, Ally protecting him instead.

Flores squatted and said to Jimmy, “There’s a lot of *pinche* motherfuckers dead in this world, but you and I aren’t one of them, Jimmy.”

Inside the house, striking in size with furnishings that’d not been updated since the 1980s, they patched Jimmy with gauze and medical tape from a laminated bathroom cabinet. The gash was no deeper than a flat stick of gum across the back of his head, the .45 slug having travelled the ridge where Flores’ gun had rested only days earlier.

The fogginess accompanying Jimmy’s concussion blotted his vision. He leaned over the sink, drank cold water from cupped hands that still had his own blood in them at first.

When Jimmy looked up again, he saw Ally in the mirror behind him. Her eyes were rimmed with worry. He wanted to say, “I’m sorry, Hon.” Hoped she knew the difference between the danger he’d put her in and the life he’d imagined for her when she was still a child.



Jimmy and Ally entered the twenty-by-ten-foot panic room on the main floor where Flores was hoisting black duffels full of cash in plastic-wrapped bricks. Jimmy guessed each bag weighed ninety pounds apiece, probably four million dollars per sack. Shelving in the room was lined with assorted ammunition and canned goods, jugs of water. There was a functional toilet at the foot of a camping cot, a ruffled sleeping bag atop it.

“Is this where they kept you?” Jimmy asked Ally.

“It was only two nights,” she said.

Flores packed out two of the bags, returned for the rest.

Jimmy told his daughter, “Meet me at the truck.”

He slung one of the remaining two bags over his shoulder and humped alongside Flores to a three-car garage where Greasley’s Chevy Tahoe awaited with the hatch open.

Flores shut the four duffels inside by pressing a button in the self-closing liftgate, said to Jimmy, “Your daughter could use some

meat on her bones.”

“My daughter’s body is not your concern.”

Jimmy walked outside to his truck. Flores followed. The bodies in the gravel nearby were still. The Aryan goon’s swastika the same as Sandy Billings’, manufactured by vitriol, but ideologies slipped from bone as easily as meat after death, raptors and coroners alike could attest.

Ally sat in the passenger seat with the window down. Her arm rested outside the way her mother’s used to, waiting on Jimmy before a road trip, the woman already sucking on sunflower seeds before they’d left the driveway, then for hours spitting shells into a plastic cup. Ally now roughly the same age, although her mother had worn dresses back then, cringeworthy to Ally.

Jimmy got onto his back in the gravel, slid beneath the rear end of the truck. He reached both arms above the spare tire mount, ripped down a black garbage bag he’d folded over Flores’ ledger and adhered to the vehicle by duct tape.

When he stood up again, he gave the bag to Flores and pulled his SOG utility knife from the front pocket of his jeans. Handed that to Flores, also.

“I stuffed the deed into the book while it still had relevance, long before you harpooned your boss,” Jimmy said. “I’m not shedding tears, but I didn’t know that was the plan.”

“Yes you did,” Flores said. He used Jimmy’s knife to shed the duct tape and plastic from his ledger, removed it, flipped through the pages.

He pulled out the deed, its thin white paper see-through in sunlight, said to Jimmy, “This is a photocopy.”

“That’s all there was,” Jimmy told him. “Not that it matters now. Gertie Lev has the only right of survivorship, and she doesn’t seem like the type to launder money for scumbags.”

Flores slowly folded Jimmy’s knife, handed it back. “Did Grisham happen to say anything to you before he died?”

“Nothing,” Jimmy said.

“Perhaps we should talk, Jimmy.”

Jimmy looked at his daughter sitting high in the cab, remembered when she used to cry at being buckled into her car seats when she was little. She was exactly one half of what Jimmy cared most about in the world.

He turned back to Flores and said, "I don't think that's necessary."

Flores pulled the cigarettes from his front pocket, lit one. Blew the smoke out and told Jimmy, "If you say so."

Then Flores rested his hand on the butt of his .32 and added, "Where's the five-hundred thousand you ripped out of my wall?"

"I'm donating that," Jimmy told him.

"It's not in the truck?"

"Not unless I topped the fluids with it," Jimmy said.

Then Jimmy added, "I took scans of your ledger and sent them to a friend. If you or your cartel associates consider putting a machine in motion against my family, that's a kill switch."

"Smart, Jimmy."

"It means that even if you're able to beat me to the draw with that .32 of yours, which I don't doubt the possibility of since my weapon is on my ankle, you won't be shooting me or my daughter right now and leaving us here on this property with the goblins."

"I bandaged your head. Why would I turn around and shoot you?"

"Because maybe you have ideas about what kind of man I am. And because you happen to also be a goblin, Flores. And because maybe God told you to."

Flores' laughter was bronchial and husky around the edges and his teeth were as shiny as switchblades flickering in the shadows of his bone structure.

Jimmy got into his truck, turned over the engine, backed the vehicle out slowly.

South of Potlach, he swung into a pullout, parked. Turned to Ally. "Are you okay?"

"I'm fine," she told him. "But it took you long enough to ask."

He leaned across the center console, hugged her tightly. His head was throbbing, his heart pumping liquid emotion, lungs short

of breath. Through Ally's open window, he could smell the grass and rolled hay bales and fertilizer across a wide-open meadow and felt Ally's cheek against his beard stubble.

"I'm just shook up, Dad. Nothing happened to me," she added.

"Yes, it did," Jimmy told her, letting go. "But we can talk about it when you're ready. There's plenty I want to explain to you, as well."

"I meant—*nothing happened to me*. Isn't that what dads want to know?"

Jimmy couldn't answer her. The silence in the cab of the truck was a vacuum strong enough to deplete the entirety of the world's oxygen, it seemed.

Then she asked him, "How many of those people did you shoot?"

"I shot only one of them," Jimmy confessed. "He was a police officer I used to work with. He was on the pad for Senator Greasley, and I believe he was at least complicit in several murders. I have no doubt that even beyond the events of today he was a danger to our family, although I don't know if he had his own family to consider. If he did, that will stay with me for a very long time."

"You don't have to make excuses, Dad. Those fucking assholes kidnapped me. Why don't I drive?"

"That's a good idea," Jimmy said.

He stepped out of the truck, walked around it. Ally climbed over the console to swap places. After Jimmy climbed back in, she pulled onto the two-lane. Jimmy rolled up the windows to call Braxton Gooding, whose phone rang only once.

"Chinden," he said when he answered. "I got another call from that professor in Detroit, although this time he sounded like he was coming down from methamphetamines. You haven't answered my messages. Are you safe?"

"I'm safe. I'm with my daughter," Jimmy said. "I'm calling to report a series of homicides related to your investigation. You'll need to collaborate with Kootenai County, and I guess with Ada County, too. There are four bodies in the driveway of the Greasley

property in Coeur d'Alene. One of them is the senator. Another is a Boise lieutenant named Bartholomew Tall. Evelyn Hawkstellar is also down, along with a lineman for the Aryan Knights."

"Say again?"

"Multiple agencies will want me in a room. I'll write up a detailed report and send it through an attorney before interviews are conducted. You have my word on that. There's an audio file I'll email you when I get better reception, but there's one other thing. Detective Abbiati is wearing a two-piece at the bottom of the Detroit River, on the Canadian side."

"As in bathing suit?"

"The mafia kind."

"I was worried about you, Chinden," Gooding said. "More than I was supposed to be."

There was a too-long pause.

Then Jimmy said, "Like I told you, I'm with my daughter."



Jimmy slept nearly five hours without stirring. When he awoke, Ally was sucking on Spitz sunflower seeds with her lower lip full of the cracked husks. She'd stopped for gas at some point, put two cans of Arizona sweetened black tea in the cup holders.

"You're awake," she said. "I grabbed your wallet at the Chevron back in New Meadows. I would've woken you to ask but like you've always said, your wallet's my wallet. Also, I took your phone and downloaded an album for you when we had reception back in Cascade."

"You know my passcode?"

"I know my father. It was only going to be one of two birthdays."

"You're alarmingly upbeat for a girl who endured a kidnapping."

"Maybe in Idaho you can still get away with calling me a girl. In the world at large, I'm a threat. Let's agree to that, yes?"

“You’re right,” Jimmy said. “You’re right on principle and you’re right in practice. There are things I’m still getting used to. When you were young, we taught you to defend yourself, but the part of me who changed your diapers wishes you never had to. You called your apartment a ‘flat,’ for god’s sake. A year from now you’ll introduce a woman as your wife.”

“You’re being ridiculous. You don’t want me to be potty trained yet?” Alley snorted out a laugh then added, “I’m doing my best to stay positive in a time of crisis. It won’t make you feel any better to learn that I generally have a delayed response to stress. I’m just getting through today so that I can live to panic tomorrow. Press ‘Play’ already.”

Jimmy looked at his phone, where she’d queued The Very Best of Eagles double-album they’d ritually listened to as a family on road trips, the CDs eventually rubbed to translucence along the edges after a decade of use.

The music washed over Jimmy like a whole lifetime with his children. *Why did his immense love for them hurt so much, the rituals bring pain along with the joy?*

They were coming upon a pit stop at Banks, its permanent population less than twenty but river-rat SUVs with mounted kayaks lining the shoulder of the two-lane every summer denser than a Santa Monica road rally. Ally turned onto the Banks-to-Lowman road, drove a quarter mile then veered into the gravel along the South Fork of the Payette. She parked so they could stretch their legs, the mid-afternoon sun hot as a flash-bang grenade to Jimmy’s concussion when they got out and shimmied down the small escarpment to the river.

Along this riverbank ten years ago Jimmy’d stood helplessly watching a man drown after being thrown from a raft, his body wedged into a granite crease between rapids. Traffic along the South Fork had pulled to the edge, bystanders dialed Emergency Dispatch, but the big water was turbulent, the boil lines high down the center, the boulders sometimes undercut and dangerous on their upstream side. The man appeared caught in the sieve between two of them. Without dying themselves, nobody could

help. His arms lost motor function from hypothermia, head finally bobbing like a rubberized flotation toy atop the rapid's incessant crest. A woman had run along the bank shouting at onlookers, Jimmy included—"Do something!" But the man was already dead, no one getting to him except by dropping-in a kayak or raft upstream.

Now Ally was standing beside Jimmy, a breeze off the river making tassels of her hair, the sun across her cheekbones like polished stones, like in half the Eagles songs ever written. The air was cooled by a mist from the current. Water particles in the air, like pollen or shards of mirror, danced with the billion images of existence.

He sat down on the boulder at his feet, was silent at first, before asking Ally, "When's the last time you talked to your brother?"

"I tried him from Detroit, but they took my phone," she said. "I don't know why I called him instead of you. It was just instinct."

"He's a protector," Jimmy said.

"But it's weird that he was my first call once I got a chance. I guess I wonder if we've grown apart," she admitted.

"You can accidentally let that happen by living your life," Jimmy told her. "It's not your fault but don't let it stay that way. Family can be the antidote to suffering."

"Unless they're the cause."

"Your brother never hurt a soul in his life, Ally."

"He's Special Forces, Dad. What is it you think they do?"

There was a long silence between them, the afternoon hot around Jimmy's neck suddenly. The small rose tattoo on his left forearm, inked there in the weeks after meeting his wife, began to itch from direct sunlight. He didn't know if it were his concussion, the trauma of having almost lost Ally to violence, or the hole in his heart that could only be filled by his son at times, but Jimmy put his face in his hands, dropped his head, and wept beside his daughter.

An hour later, they exited the Fanci Freez drive-thru in downtown Boise, a sack of veggie burgers and French fries in

Ally's lap. Jimmy parked beneath tree cover on 14th Street. They unrolled the windows and ate in quiet, the engine cut and cooling. The nearby chokecherry trees were heavy with overripe fruit that sweetened the air. The bulging root system of a seventy-foot elm that'd likely been growing for half a century cracked-through the sidewalk outside Ally's window—everything seemed in its place, percolating with life, but Jimmy remained elsewhere.

He phoned Sandy Billings. The call went to voicemail.

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TWENTY-ONE

Two days later, Jimmy had his first drink in fifteen years at the rail of a cheerless, cinderblock bar beside the Union Pacific train tracks in Nogales, the Mexican side, on an afternoon so parched of hope it seemed the sun moved across sandpaper instead of the sky. He ordered one ounce of Tito's vodka with a single ice cube and a pimiento-stuffed green olive. Then he watched the ice cube take five minutes to melt completely. When he finally angled the vodka into his mouth, he did it like getting rid of evidence. A black pepper sting in the back of Jimmy's throat when it went down.

The front door to the bar was propped open with a stack of bricks to allow for an occasional breeze off the byway, and because there was no screen there were flies along the bar top, but they'd gone listless in the heat. The house radio played American country songs, the commercials in Spanish advertising a local payday lender, two auto dealerships, a Mexican restaurant in Arizona—everywhere the same as everywhere else. Two men at a faux wood laminate table drank beers, and three stools over from Jimmy a man whose hands looked as rugged as flanks of beef jerky smoked a cigarette, twice resting his eyes as if exhausted, deep in memory, or both.

Jimmy tipped the olive into his mouth, left cash for his drink, stepped out to the crushed stone parking lot, sat baking inside the cab of his truck for twenty minutes before returning to the freeway to drive another two hundred miles south.

At nine in the morning the next day, at a taqueria across the street from his motel at the southern tip of Hermosillo, Jimmy tilted his second drink in fifteen years—a Bloody Mary mixed with tequila so pungent it might've been squeezed from kerosene rags. The warmth of it in Jimmy's chest cavity widened like the flame on a newly-struck match. He ate half a dozen tacos carnitas with

lime wedges for breakfast, drove another ten hours south to Mazatlán, found another motel room, this one facing a McDonald's.

By nightfall, Jimmy'd shut off the overhead light, drawn his drapes against the mustard-colored arches and passing headlamps outside, climbed into bed. He lay on his back listening to the window-mounted air conditioning unit cycle on and off for sixty minutes until finally yanking the AC plug from the wall. Slept as heavy as a bag of wet sand, then.

He remembered no dreams upon waking in the morning. Swung his legs over the side of the bed, showered for fifteen minutes beneath a chrome-plated nozzle caked with limescale, stood in the parking lot eating a breakfast of two oranges and black coffee from the motel lobby, foot propped against the front tire of his truck. The sunlight across his face was hot already at 8:00 am. Listened to the birds chirping from the tar and gravel rooftop of the motel and garbled Spanish coming from the McDonald's drive-thru behind him.

On the road to Puerto Vallarta, Jimmy had the urge to check his cell but he'd left it in Boise when he slipped away from Jennifer Hope's bungalow in the middle of that first night down from Coeur d'Alene with Ally asleep in Jen's spare bedroom. Jimmy'd been on the couch emailing Gooding a report on the recent trail of homicides, starting with Abbiati's. Didn't know Flores' whereabouts and hadn't felt safe taking Ally directly home, although he believed the odds were against the man being in their lives anytime soon. Knew that he would drink again, knew Ally was safer with Jen when he did.

At three in the morning, Jimmy deposited a penciled note, his iPhone, and a credit card into a manila envelope with Ally's name on it, leaned it against the wall outside the spare bedroom door, slipped out the back of Jen's house so as not to trigger the front porch light. Knew his daughter was in good hands, holy hands he trusted would enfold her in moments of need.

He stopped at home to leave a key for Ally under a brick in the backyard. By four in the morning had entered the freeway on-

ramp past the Metro Express car wash blinking halogens against the night, nobody on the road but Jimmy, full tank of gas, thirty-five hours of driving ahead.

Had three-hundred grand in cash from his floor safe locked inside the under-seat storage console in the rear bench of the truck now. In the glove box were his 9mm and mags, a fifty-round box of ammunition in his go-bag on the passenger side floor. On his belt, a three-inch fixed blade knife and horizontal Kydex sheath, inconspicuous at the small of his back beneath his black tee.

By two in the afternoon on the fourth day of travel, twenty-one hundred miles of sunbaked road behind him in his side mirrors and a multi-unit police task force likely seeking his whereabouts in the States, Jimmy arrived at a small property management company in Puerto Vallarta, laying down three thousand American dollars for a temporary, furnished apartment. Offered quadruple the asking price of the one-month reservation in exchange for bypassing paperwork, an implied request for discretion he highly suspected would be readily ignored—that was the point.

He wanted to call attention to himself.

The apartment was a faded lime green concrete box on a hill overlooking the northern tip of the Malecon's twelve-block tourist district and bent shoreline. The sea beyond it was blue and fluorescent, the apartment fully exposed to salt air. Jimmy parked in the rental unit's sloped driveway, climbed into the back seat, loaded the cash and 9mm into his go-bag, spent ten minutes inside the tile-floored apartment making it look at least mildly lived-in. Scattered his toiletries across the bathroom countertop. Splashed a bath towel with water then draped it over a kitchen chair. Hung a pair of jeans and two tee shirts in the bedroom closet. Messed up the sheets on a queen-sized mattress no firmer than a collapsed soufflé.

If anyone came looking for him now, they'd stick around.

He walked a half-mile downhill with the duffel over his shoulder before grabbing a taxi across town to a thatch-roofed, open-air restaurant overlooking the coastline at Playa Los

Muertos. Devoured a plate of fish tacos, felt the breeze, smelled the salt in the air, looked across the bay to where the world turned downward against a pastel sky. Eventually, he took one pull from a sweating bottle of Modelo beer that'd arrived with his food, paid his bill, crossed the boulevard to a minimart. Purchased another set of toiletries, a liter of water, a prepaid Telcel burner, exchanged three hundred American dollars for pesos.

He walked two blocks uphill to the Hotel Maria, a slanted, worn, three-story stucco complex of weekly apartment rentals whose upper units featured wrought iron and concrete balconies with a view of the water. Traded most of his pesos for a third-floor room then crossed beneath a pair of red brick archways into a courtyard marked by palm trees and broken cobblestone.

Within an hour, Jimmy'd showered and stashed his go-bag. Walked back down to the esplanade for a taxi. At an outdoor bar along the boardwalk, he stopped and drank a small bottle of soda water with a lime wedge crammed into its neck while he watched the American and European tourists in vacation whites, the barmaid in her late twenties with collarbone-length straight hair blacker than shoe polish, a name tag on her blouse that read "Isabella." On her brown shoulder was a tattoo of the Virgin Mary in sepia. The skin on her opposing wrist was inked by a crucifix.

Jimmy paid for his soda water in pesos, gave the bartender a fifty-dollar tip to exchange another three-hundred dollars in currency for him, a proposition she acquiesced to with a raised eyebrow. She set a high stack of pesos in front of Jimmy and asked him, "Can I get you a drink?"

"Imagine you're relaxing beneath a cabana," Jimmy told her. "Then imagine some asshole taking a chainsaw to the corner posts. That's the kind of drinker I am."

"Violent?"

"Just disruptive," Jimmy said.

She leaned her elbows against the bar. Jimmy smelled fruit-scented lotion on her skin and a hint of cigarette smoke from her top when she playfully told him, "I've known people like you. We

have a word for them in Spanish called *estupido*, but I don't think it translates."

Wiping the bar top with a terry cloth rag, she winked at Jimmy through painted eyelashes falling almost to her cheekbones.

Jimmy's eyes traveled downward to the curtsy of an Adam's apple when she swallowed.

I see you, he thought, but no differently than on surveillance jobs when the long lens of his camera, an instrument of objectivity, required no moral barometer.

Wondered how long since she'd transitioned—long enough that she'd grown into who she was, beautiful around the edges. It'd take effort to see otherwise.

Soon the sun began setting in the distance and the shoreline skim was dense with egrets picking for fish. From above the volcanic crags where the shore rounded into forest there were black-plumed frigatebirds approaching with wingspans wide as theater capes. They rode the updrafts as shadows against the darkening sky.

Jimmy remembered the stained-glass lancet windows of the outbuilding on the Sun Valley property and the water birds, so many, dipping above the Big Wood River at dusk, but the memory was not from his recent visit—*at what age had he been there previously, not older than three, same age as his now-remembered first visit to the Flores property?* Jimmy was small back then, the lancet windows behind Gertie's childhood home translucent at sundown. He'd gripped the stone ledge to pull himself up, forearms trembling, sunlight warming the back of his head, his tennis shoes digging for purchase.

What had been inside? The image was displaced by only a dark feeling, after these many years, akin to what a person might perceive after realizing he'd ingested poison.

He remembered his mother had come downhill to retrieve him from the property, her summer dress thin against her legs, a cigarette and cocktail glass in the fingertips of one hand. A breeze came off the river and pushed her hair backward.

“My little wiggle-rat,” she’d said, and with her free arm reached around Jimmy’s stomach, peeling him from the wall, Jimmy counterbalancing her cocktail now, her hip bone grinding.

On her tiptoes, his mother had peeked into the crypt, as Jimmy had—he remembered the sunlight just perfect on her face, instantly gone from its summer flush to a stark, bloodless white.

When the barmaid named Isabella returned to check on Jimmy, he stood upright, said to her, “I noticed the bar closes at midnight. Are you available after that?”

“You’re fit enough,” she smiled.

“I’m flattered.” And he was. “You’re the best looker on this beach, old enough to love who you want—but I’d be wrong to let you waste good looks and youth on a man without either.”

He put one thousand American dollars atop the bar and asked her, “Any chance you have babysitting experience?”



The night had cooled and the multi-colored shops and crowded restaurants lining the cobblestone streets of the “Romantic Zone” pumped music from speakers hidden above their doorways behind palm fronds and waxy, pink bougainvillea.

Jimmy rode a taxi with its windows down, the smell of street food wafting, his legs cramped in the narrow back seat, the 9mm pressed uncomfortably against his ankle. The taxi left the city behind, traveled south along the Río Cuale through forests dense with stranglers, headlights hovering over red dirt.

At a turnoff framed by overhanging philodendrons, he paid the taxi driver a hundred-dollar tip, told him, “Come back for me in twenty minutes but don’t wait here.”

Then he stepped into the darkness, watched the taillights of the taxi as it departed downhill, easing toward the city lights several miles away. Beyond the main road was an archway of nectarine stucco crowded by foliage, beyond that a trail of steps along a forested slope to the two-story, brick and stucco bordello Jimmy

knew from the ledger to be run by Tio Flores. He walked up the trail.

A thin line of electricity traveled over the treetops to a utility pole with a high lumen flood lamp mounted atop, spotlighting a small courtyard of raked dirt with a wrought iron bench and coffee can on the ground beside it for cigarette butts.

From the entryway of the bordello, Jimmy's approach was studied by two security thugs in multicolored, knockoff designer tees, large caliber pistols tucked into the front of their jeans one mistake away from blowing crotch.

The larger of the thugs postured, said to Jimmy, "*Qué deseas?*"

"American," Jimmy shrugged.

"What do you want?"

Jimmy put his hands in his pockets, mimicking a submissive. Grinned and told the man, "What everyone wants. For my country to love me as much as I love it."

A smile from the big man with a chipped front tooth, saying to his smaller partner, "*Creo que está hablando de 'Rambo!' Que raro.*"

Then he said to Jimmy, "Are you here for pussy, Rambo?"

"Si."

"Okay. Pay inside."

The man put his arm around Jimmy's shoulder, led him up two concrete steps, bodyweight flabby and insolent against Jimmy, armpit of the man's shirt discolored by perspiration stinking of aftershave and raw alcohol as Jimmy peeled a two-hundred-peso tip for each of the thugs.

Both men patted Jimmy on his back. Then the smaller one opened the steel-framed front door to allow Jimmy entry, saying, "Only light violence. No bruises."

"Breath play?" Jimmy asked.

"*Solo con permiso.*"

Inside the bordello, Jimmy was confronted by a cloud of cigarette smoke thick as mosquito fumigant, the walls of the dimly lit anteroom unevenly plastered, painted crimson. An elongated couch across the room holding a half-dozen teenaged girls wearing

only panties and dollar store muumuus looking at Jimmy with translucent eyes.

On a padded barstool beside a beaded bamboo curtain, a young woman, maybe twenty years of age and olive-skinned, sat completely naked while scraping the callouses from her feet with a pumice stone, a small security camera mounted in the corner above her.

Jimmy stared at the camera, waited until another security thug came through the beads with an armful of cigarette cartons, a scowl on his face when he said to the young woman, "*Vestirse!* Put some fucking clothes on!"

The security thug waited until she left the room. Then he set the cigarette cartons atop the entertainment bar, opened one of the boxes of Delicados, took a pack for himself, unwrapped it. Shook a cigarette loose, fired it up with a see-through plastic lighter, turned to Jimmy. "English?"

"Yes," Jimmy replied.

"Who do you like?" The thug gestured to the teenagers on the couch, a gold nugget pinky ring on his finger slicing through cigarette smoke, vein the size of an earthworm twitching alongside his forehead when he briefly clenched his jaw.

Jimmy took out the wad of cash from his pocket, peeled off four thousand pesos.

"I was looking for something younger."

The thug's eyes twinkled. "When you walk through the beads, go upstairs right away. There is only one room. At this time of night, you won't be disturbed, but the upstairs becomes very popular when many of the bars close. Good?"

"*Si,*" Jimmy said. "Thank you."

He left the anteroom through the bamboo curtain. Down a cracked plaster hallway painted aquamarine were a large number of bedrooms. From some of them came the sound of unfettered rutting, the staccato of mattresses whimpering from pressure, one of the rooms emitting incense smoke through a separation in its doorway drapery.

Taking a concrete stairwell to the second floor, he stepped through a vinyl strip doorway to a windowless room painted pink, decorated with a hot air balloon mural across one wall. The room was lit by an overhead four-track fixture with three of its bulbs missing.

On a queen-sized bed adorned with a faux chenille, tattered white quilt in obvious need of washing, the pale girl of fourteen appeared to be asleep, curled with her back to Jimmy. Her white tee shirt barely covered her. Her licorice-soft fingers pressed beneath her face like the hands of a garden cherub.

From a small, whitewashed dresser in the corner, Jimmy pulled a set of underpants and bra, the same jean shorts he'd seen the girl wearing above Flores' bar all the way back in Windsor, a navy-blue sweatshirt that seemed to have belonged to an adult male twice her size. Then from his own front pants pocket, he removed a scrap paper with his Telcel number scribbled across. Sat on the edge of the bed and woke the girl. Jimmy could see in her eyes that she was under the influence of opiates, the pupils black pinpoints drifting away in a sea of blue.

"We met this past week back in Canada. Then one of Tio Flores' men sent me down the electric rope slide," Jimmy tried to remind her, hoped she comprehended. "I'd like it if we could get you out of here. Would that be okay?"

The girl nodded her head. Jimmy averted his eyes so she could get dressed. When he finally turned back, she'd pulled the sweatshirt over her torso, was slowly zipping her shorts.

"I couldn't find your shoes," Jimmy told her. Then he pulled the 9mm from his ankle and said to the girl, "Stand up if you can."

He held his weapon in one hand, put the girl over his shoulder with the other. She was no heavier than a saddlebag, Jimmy afraid of hurting her.

He dropped the slip of paper with his burner number onto the bed then added, "Put your fingers in your ears. And try not to look."

TWENTY-TWO

Jimmy carried the girl down the single flight of stairs with his gun extended, her stomach tense against his shoulder, his left arm wrapping her hamstrings. Her head hung to the center of Jimmy's back, how he used to carry Ally to bed some nights during horseplay, her cotton pajamas recently freshened by laundry detergent—*when she was what, seven?*

He could feel the girl's fear in the way she drove her elbows into Jimmy for purchase, the toes on her bare feet curling backward as if reaching.

"Don't stiffen," he told her. "This is going to be fine."

At the bottom of the stairwell, he looked to his left, saw the many rooms down the long, aquamarine hallway, the air reeking of patchouli and fetid musk that'd been steamed into the walls by humidity over the years.

Did not count the rooms in a reconnaissance effort, nor seek their occupants—although he believed that one day he might wish he'd done both, his imagination putting faces to the many other casualties of Flores that might accompany Jimmy on the ghost rail through his remaining years.

Jimmy could see no clearly marked rear exit to the building. He heard a sound like rubber soles on tile, then instinctively pivoted to his right leg and immediately fired one shot through the bamboo beads at the security thug rapidly approaching from the anteroom with a .45 caliber matte black pistol.

Jimmy's bullet hit the man directly in his sternum, clean as the makers of war, thousands of industrialized ammunition profiteers, and Jimmy's own aggression instinct had intended it to do. He stepped through the beaded curtain, looked at the man on his back, arms outstretched like making snow angels in the blood.

The girls on the couch were screaming now.

Jimmy's pulse awkwardly paused, the way a rollercoaster stops at the top before plummeting. Then the floor of his throat fell out, blood raced again, and the adrenaline was like high voltage barbs in his head.

When the two security thugs from outside breached the front doorway with their pistols in hand, Jimmy planted his forward foot and put a hot bullet into each of them, left and then right—and then left again, like checking for traffic.

The way Jimmy'd first figured it, he'd have two days to burn until Tio Flores caught up, two days Jimmy'd been looking forward to since the lights had gone out on Greasley. He'd put the pieces in place to drink hard and without interruption and long—two days Jimmy figured could peel away as easy as hundred-dollar bills from somebody else's roll, because that's the way addicts think; he knew it and didn't care.

He dropped Little Windsor, how he thought of the girl now, not wanting to name her only to lose her somehow, at the apartment with Isabella, who'd watch over the girl while Jimmy waited for Braxton Gooding to track the GPS on his rented F-150. He expected Gooding and maybe even the feds to already be monitoring his travels through Mexico but that didn't seem to be the case.

He needed Gooding, much as he was made vulnerable by the suggestion, or any cop north of the roulette wheel of local graft to bust through the doors looking for him, find Little Windsor instead, get her into custody and back to wherever home was, something Jimmy couldn't do himself without a passport for the girl—get her taken care of, while Jimmy bought himself time for the rest.



He rented a thirty-foot fiberglass sport fishing boat—it bobbed gently over a current while Jimmy cracked his first of many Modelos from inside a portable cooler ladled with chopped ice. Lips cold with the beer, the side of his head hot from the sun. He

turned his face toward the sea, where a school of yellowfin tuna drifted by, each bigger than the tires on his truck.

Jimmy had laid the girl atop the bed beside Isabella, who'd taken Little Windsor into her arms, the girl's eyes wetting with emotion so palpable it seemed she'd never been held by a woman. He'd needed to get back to the Hotel Maria and his bag of money, a chance at Flores, a chance to be alone with the shame over his urge to drink, so he'd left the girl and tried not to look back.

That was three days ago now, and it'd only taken another twelve hours for a swarm of red and blue police lights to descend on the lime green, concrete apartment building. Through a pair of marine binoculars that'd come with his boat rental, Jimmy'd watched from the oscillating waters of the bay as Baxton Gooding, two additional plainclothes American officers, and a contingent of Puerto Vallarta cops in egret-white uniforms interviewed Isabella and the girl in the long driveway beside his truck. Gooding had looked solid. Jimmy thought he'd seen him scan the bay.

All Jimmy'd planned for after that was to make moves toward exchanging the remaining bulk of the three hundred grand to Flores as payment for the girl, something to hold Flores' vengeance at bay—that's what Jimmy would tell Flores, anyway.

It didn't matter that Jimmy'd left two hundred grand in Boise beneath the fridge. He'd had to, in case a sinkhole opened beneath him in Mexico—what would he have bequeathed to his children, otherwise? Only a little cash saved up, the house at market rate, but what would their lives look like when stacked against the professional thieves who owned our banks and skimmed the till? Wasn't it his job to keep providing, even after death?

But if things went right, Flores wouldn't get close enough to count the money, wouldn't see through the fog of dialogue to the hammer-forged steel barrel of Jimmy's piece, Jimmy's real plan simply to bring the man out then put the man down, crater his chest—or Jimmy's family would never be safe, not really, not safe in the way that most families were.

Long ago, Jimmy's mother'd been murdered one eye at a time, and Rudolph Hillcrest had stolen the motel and land that was

Jimmy's home. Everything Jimmy'd touched since then had been genomically imprinted by loss. Ayita Smith was dead, but her bloodshed had felt familiar, an extension of the homicidal dispatch of his mother.

And what had Flores said, *We should talk, Jimmy?*

Jimmy had torched the motel and with it, he'd pretended, the residue of Rudolph Hillcrest from his life, yet the slime behind the slug never fully dissipated. If the body leaves a mark, debosses what it touches, then the truth was Jimmy'd sometimes fetishized the bitter grooves left behind. Hadn't he removed the .22 throwdown revolver from the evidence in his mother's case in hopes of one day creeping along the trail to her doer—with that same pistol in hand and something in his heart that'd felt as passionate as love, only different? He hadn't wanted to let go, even though the motel flames had spoken otherwise, the blackened foundation dozed, the plot graveled over.

His mother had told Jimmy he'd been abandoned. With her death Jimmy'd seemed orphaned to chance and rootlessness again. To survive the pain, he'd nurtured a belief that forward motion could be hindered by nostalgia, so he avoided that when possible. Jimmy's children knew few details about the woman who'd raised him in Garden City, once the cheating side of Boise, the boulevard of grifters, crankheads, and cops. Jimmy saw no reason to mythologize that for his kids.

Now he knew that the ghost of a physical space always existed no matter what. The walls could be disappeared from our four-dimensional realm, but the memories remained. In body, Jimmy could still step across the gravel parking lot that'd held his mother's motel and say, *Here is where I ate my food. Here is where I slept. In this room, I showered. Across the way, I loved.*

Jimmy had often done this in dreams—without effort, going back in time.

But *with* effort, what else could he see?

Long before Grisham Greasley was in politics and Jimmy a cop, Greasley'd been in Jimmy's periphery—every six months or so, Jimmy's mother would snap-open the plastic ligature on a stack of

fresh newspapers in the motel lobby, muttering, “Fuckin’ Gee-Gee.” Or the local news would play Greasley’s face on the little lobby TV—she’d turn it off, Jimmy thinking her enmity politically fueled, a generalized vitriol aimed at the overlords of us all.

Inside the Sun Valley property where Gertie Lev had been cradling an empty wine glass in her kitchen, the dome of Bald Mountain in the distance and the lighting soft against a photograph on the wall showing her as an adolescent stirring the contents of a stock pot over a stove while the members of a cocktail party looked on, Jimmy’d fixated on a pair of eyes he hadn’t recognized as Greasley’s in the black-and-white photo shot thirty years prior.

Now Jimmy could see what’d caused his fixation, understood he’d recognized not Greasley but himself. Jimmy roughly the age today that Greasley’d been in the photo. Greasley with the same jawline as his, same marbled black eyes in their deep pockets, only Greasley’s with more ink to them.

After three days of drinking, the swaths of white beach along the bay were darkened by partygoers who seemed ant-sized when he glassed them in his binoculars from a half mile out. He’d suffered no hangovers, dousing himself with alcohol again as daylight rose across the starboard handrail of the boat, the sea an endless luster and the concrete in Jimmy’s head softened by sugar.

The burner phone had not rung, and so the previous night Jimmy’d grown impatient with Flores and docked the boat after dark. Took a taxi to the bordello again, a black shirt unbuttoned to his chest. The alcohol tunneling his vision.

Borrowed a cigarette lighter from the taxi driver, paid the man to cut his lights and wait a hundred yards downhill. Then Jimmy’d hiked past the nectarine-colored archway, up the forested slope to the small, dirt courtyard with the floodlamp overhead.

Two replacement thugs stared at Jimmy from the steps of the bordello. They might have been cardboard inserts for the thugs before them, same as the thugs who’d surely follow.

Beneath the floodlamp, Jimmy fished through the coffee can of cigarette butts, sat on the wrought iron bench, lit one and smoked

it halfway through the filter, a chemical burn in his throat he hadn't felt in years.

The night was comfortable on his skin. In another world, he might've been relaxing after the senior prom with a lilt of romantic conversation in the air, the future not something in the past.

Jimmy pulled his 9mm, stood up tall, emptied a magazine of potshots in the general direction of the bordello, intentionally shooting aslant but driving the two thugs inside as if they'd been ducking from thundershowers. Then he sprinted back to the taxi and dove in.

And still no calls to his burner, Jimmy continuing to drink at an athletic pace. This morning, he'd awoken on the boat with a shot of warm tequila straight from the bottle, followed by a cold Modelo chaser. Another bottle of tequila, already emptied, leaned in a corner of the rear casting deck with the morning sun painting its carcass of glass golden inside, until a small wave hit the aft of the boat, the bottle toppling and drifting across the deck with a sound like a rolling pin.

By nine a.m. Jimmy'd eaten a breakfast of canned sardines with yellow mustard and pickles, stripped to his underwear and drunkenly somersaulted off the bow. By noon he'd passed out in the shade of the console awning, where he slept until late in the day, his burner showing no calls when he checked it upon waking.

For supper, another can of sardines, plucked with fingers. Drank a liter of water, then another beer from his cooler, married with back-to-back tequila shots from the new bottle he'd begun that morning— tequila or the waves, he couldn't tell which, sloshing him around the boat.

By ten p.m. the sun had set the color of tarnished silver, the big black frigates with their wingspans drifting downward like suicides now replaced by stars. Wearing only his boxer briefs, Jimmy hung his legs over the aft cockpit of the boat, slid into the saltwater, cool and lubricating.

He felt buoyant.

Decided to swim to shore, just to see if he could—No, to prove it to himself. Had swum longer distances, almost thirty years ago now, beyond the shoreline of Lake Michigan in colder waters than these, also at night with a campfire burning in the sand like a lighthouse he'd navigated by. His musculature strong and fluid, winds arriving from a hundred miles across the lake to incite a current.

The body remembers, Jimmy told himself.

Swam in a slow crawl through the black water that glistened with starlight and moonlight on the surface. When he tired, swiveled to his back and floated almost effortlessly, his brain sopping with alcohol and the sky and sea both so much bigger than mankind—Jimmy small and meaningless, drenched in the truth of human existence as a laughable quirk in the continuum, an accidental spill across the countertops of the gods, human beings almost delightfully nothing.

Three hundred yards out from shore, the distance of only a few football fields, Jimmy began to take on water during his crawl, gulps that settled directly behind the crescent-shaped wound on his sternum carved by the fingertip of Sandy Billings.

At first, Jimmy coughed out the water but soon found his shoulders and arms fatiguing to near-failure. Tried saving his energy by simply floating forward with the current. But the tide had already been high, the current unpredictable now, at one point moving Jimmy farther out to sea.

Panicked, he swam as furiously as his strength allowed, traveling half the remaining distance to shore, the lights of the cabana bars little globes that hung like fireflies high above the sand.

Then the water beneath the surface was like a hard-sucking vacuum.

A riptide pulled him downward, Jimmy holding his breath for five, maybe ten seconds with his eyes wide-open to a blackness that was like staring into a rucksack.

Rose with saltwater roaring through his sinuses. He'd swallowed water, a lot of it. Pivoted sideways with the riptide, had

no strength in his arms, only his feet that kicked futilely.

Jimmy was dragged under again, and the water thrashed him.

He felt he was drowning but he did not know what this meant. The water a fat suit, weight he'd never carried in life, pulling him down.

Oh, Jimmy thought, death no different than learning to drive.

Then he felt his toes dragging across a sand bar. Stood, seaweed across his forehead. The shore only thirty feet away and Isabella hurrying down from the bar where she cocktailed, her white cotton blouse catching a breeze.

Jimmy collapsed onto his knees, vomiting enough water to fill a pot.

By midnight, Jimmy and Isabella were asleep in his apartment at the Hotel Maria, Jimmy having obtained a spare key from the perfume-doused lobby attendant, a woman of a certain age who initially flinched, the alcohol on Jimmy's breath heavy as formaldehyde.

Isabella had helped Jimmy into dry clothes, held onto his elbow while guiding him cautiously to bed—Jimmy saying to her, "The universe..." but trailing off.

"Alcoholics do better thinking smaller," she'd told him.

Jimmy'd fallen asleep on his face with the vent on the window-mounted air conditioning unit rattling, Isabella curled beside him, Jimmy in dream seeing his mother's motel floating across the sea.

In sleep he shifted his weight, turning toward Isabella as if subconsciously turning-into the thirty years of hard emptiness since his mother's murder on Chinden Boulevard, Isabella's curvature lenient to his touch, like sea water when he wrapped his arm around the break of her hip, held onto her erection like a wooden oar threatening to float away from him, Jimmy's burner phone and 9mm back on the boat, his chest palpitating with anxiety even as he slept.

Didn't know that he was deep in the shit, but he was.

At daybreak three men in black ski masks bum-rushed Jimmy's apartment and dragged Isabella from bed, Jimmy adrenalized and

reaching for the drawer of his nightstand, forgetting his weapon remained at sea.

When a stun gun zapped Jimmy in his solar plexus, all the nerve endings in his chest constricted as if he'd tumbled into cardiac arrest. Once again Jimmy thought to himself, *Oh...death* an instruction.

Then one of the men turned back into the bedroom on his way out, pointed a .45, fired two shots that crumbled the plaster.

For the second time in days, Jimmy felt he might drown, the world slamming atop him with unexpectedly brutal force, the sun twirling through the apartment window like a police baton across the side of Jimmy's head.

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TWENTY-THREE

Jimmy was angled sloppily across his bed, still reeling from the ambush by Tio Flores' thugs only a moment ago when Flores had entered the apartment holding a twenty-four-inch electric cattle prodder spray painted black at the grip.

Flores wore Juicy Fruit-yellow board shorts splattered in blood, no shirt, brown torso hard from years enjoying labor. Barefooted, his larger toes shaped like cauliflower stubs gripped the tile flooring, shins glassy and dimpled when he stood next to Jimmy and poked him.

"You came all the way to Mexico to loot my *coño*?" Flores asked.

"I came to bring your money back," Jimmy said. Everything hurt, parts of his body gasping like his lungs. "It wasn't fair of me to keep the cash to begin with, and I like to sleep at night, if you catch my drift."

"I do," Flores said. "So where is the money, Jimmy?"

"On a boat, anchored in the bay. I left you my burner on the girl's bed but maybe your men were too busy dying to crawl upstairs and find it."

"I was tarpon fishing all week. Didn't you see my Instagram?"

Flores smiled with an open mouth, laughed, teeth like piano keys Jimmy wanted to tap.

Flores said, "I was twenty miles offshore, Jimmy. There's no cell service that far out. Three times a year, I'm attractively off the grid. I eat only what I can catch and what my men stock in the fridge. Champagne, usually, but also Wagyu ribeyes I get from a guy in Washington State. When you sleep on a boat, that's God dropping a handkerchief over your eyes. To return home, I rely only on the stars and my intuition. If that doesn't work, there's a three-thousand-dollar navigation system."

Flores exhaled softly, as if remembering an old girlfriend. Then he jammed the cattle prod into Jimmy's thigh, didn't remove it until Jimmy'd convulsed and the contact point had thoroughly seared his flesh.

It took several minutes to recover, after which he said to Flores, "People don't eat tarpon, you fuck. There's too much bone and the meat smells like a garbage dumpster."

Flores' eyes lit up. "You're a deep-sea fisherman!"

"On vacation in Cuba once. With my boy," Jimmy admitted. The memory hurt him deep in his chest where he carried so much love it threatened to drown him same as the violence in his heart, same as Flores threatening from overhead.

"I hear the Cuban tap water makes Americans shit their pants," Flores said. "Regardless, I don't eat the tarpon, but I enjoy dragging them into my boat. They are often as big as men and it's pleasurable to hack them into smaller pieces, which I throw overboard."

"And what did you do with Isabella, the woman who was here?"

"That thing you call a woman has very good legs but a cock like a broomstick. Unfortunately for me, also a solid right hook. You're quite a drunk."

"I don't drink," Jimmy said.

"Maybe get some clothes on now."



Flores' cruising yacht was a sixty-foot, three-cabin Bertram with Kevlar-reinforced hull. The stern looked like it'd been splattered by a firehose shooting cherry-red snow cone syrup, fish guts and blood dripping off the gunwales. Half-smudged footprints crossed the deck like a compromised murder scene.

In addition to Flores, three men accompanied Jimmy onto the boat, presumably those who'd donned ski masks and dragged Isabella through the streets—and then to where, Jimmy wondered, a van? And then a room whose only view became the ceiling panels, night after night?

They left the marina, and then at a speed Jimmy guessed was forty knots the saltwater wake off the stern caught sunlight. Jimmy watched the rainbows shooting backward in the spray.

He was barefoot like Flores, wore jeans and a crème-colored linen shirt purchased from an outdoor market in Havana with his son, the wind flapping it now, Jimmy's face warm and his hair wild. When he briefly rested his eyes, he saw concussion spots that were like black butterflies.

The cruiser slowed to where his rental boat bobbed at anchor fifty yards away with the sun across its bow. Flores leaning his elbows on the starboard gunwale, chewing on a hard candy he'd stuffed into his jaw turned to Jimmy and said, "Every master needs a house boy to tell his secrets to, Jimmy. I was Grisham's for a very long time."

"Did you know I was his son?"

"Of course, I did. Used to call you his only 'pure blood' child. He was very proud of that, at first. Then he stopped writing checks when it was easier to write your mother off as a whore. He'd send a car for her sometimes, but it was only about power for him, and about the *coño*—same as anybody else."

"My mother was a good woman."

"All women, even the whores, are better than men. Later in life she held a videotape over Grisham's head. I never saw it but when Grisham did, he stabbed one of his own men with a carving knife just to release steam."

The engine was cut on Flores' cruiser and the boat moved by drift until they were inching beside Jimmy's rental, the big hull of the Bertram dwarfing the starboard gunwale.

Jimmy could see his 9mm on the deck, its barrel nosing out from the pile of clothes he'd shed before almost drowning last night.

"Let's get my money," Flores said.

Jimmy needed to be first onto the boat while he still had strength in his legs. Flores had momentarily turned a blind eye to him as he prepared to disembark.

So Jimmy stood quickly, launched himself, half-dizzy with a headrush, over the cruiser's gunwale. Landed hard on the foredeck of the smaller boat below, the side of his face skidding-across polished planks.

Flores appeared to sense an urgency he hadn't calculated for as Jimmy scurried to the aft cockpit. By the time Flores followed him over the cruiser's side and onto the foredeck, Jimmy had his 9mm gripped firmly in both hands, had taken a knee.

Two of Flores' men drew pistols as they breached the cruiser's gunwales, but Jimmy fired two rounds apiece into them. Each man flowered from his chest, hitting the water with a splash.

Then Jimmy felt the cattle prodder swing like a baseball bat across his jawline and one of his back molars snapped like a splintered door jamb. He dropped his 9mm, wincing.

Flores stepped firmly and jammed the cattle prodder into the side of Jimmy's neck with a sizzle and did not let up, grinding the electrodes hard and deep, puncturing the skin and searing the inner flesh a half-inch deep. Jimmy lost muscle control, collapsing onto himself from the electricity.

Now Flores took him by the hair, pulled Jimmy across the deck to a tipped-over, half-full tequila bottle, unscrewed and jammed it into Jimmy's mouth. The back molar tore-loose, travelled into his throat, lodged with a river of alcohol chasing over it, Jimmy's esophagus sautéing in booze.

Flores' eyes were like bonfires.

He yanked the bottle out of Jimmy's throat then gripped the skin on each side of Jimmy's cheeks and shouted into Jimmy's face, "I want my fucking money!"

"It's in the apartment," Jimmy coughed, the molar caught behind his trachea, interrupting the flow of air.

Flores stood up.

Then he said, "Goddamn you," and he used the calloused heel of his foot to strike the side of Jimmy's head as repeatedly as if stamping out spiders from a nest.



Jimmy awoke on the forward deck, the sky electric blue and the wind picking up. Sunlight burned his retinas with a beam that seemed concentrated, hot as a penlight. Vultures circled the boat high above him, the silence of being at sea otherwise beautiful and calming, the bellies of the oversized birds black as the concussion spots in Jimmy's eyes, black like the shadows from a crossover world.

Small waves knocked lightly at the port side of the hull. Then the knocking grew louder, the waves slightly bigger. When the boat rocked sidelong, Jimmy's head pounded between his ears. His blood tasted metallic in his throat, his tongue drifting to the empty socket of his molar with its torn ligaments, the clots thick as pudding.

The two empty bottles of tequila rolled and spun across the boat with the waves, Jimmy remembering Isabella yanked from his bed and the .45 casings popping from their chamber when the man in the ski mask fired a pair of "stay the fuck down" rounds, their copper discharges breaking across the tiling.

Jimmy tried to stand, discovered his wrists zip-tied to the elevated chrome railing. Both arms had gone numb, his fingers drained of blood and feeling, too.

He got to one knee, could see across the bow all the way to Puerto Vallarta. A cooling shadow crossed his face and Jimmy thought one of the vultures had descended. When he turned, he saw the cauliflower-shaped toes of Tio Flores taking purchase against the deck, the cruiser boat freshly anchoring and Tio in his blood-stained board shorts saying, "Found the money, Jimmy."

"Not all of it," Jimmy said but his words were like the sound of Velcro peeling-away.

Then Tio raised the .32 in his hand like a TV remote, like to turn Jimmy off.

"Most is sometimes enough," Tio said.

Jimmy slumped into himself, the hot sunlight above, the sea rolling harder and he half-wished it'd throw them both into a swell, at least take Flores along, too, if Jimmy was going to die today, not a good day for doing it, most of the desires for his life

still unrequited and nothing ending even marginally as he'd imagined.

"How long are you gonna stand there?" Jimmy poked. *Just fucking get it over with*, he thought, wished he could tackle Flores and choke him with a head butt to the larynx, chew through the popliteal vein at the back of his knee, anything but sit here anticipating the inevitable. Then he saw that Flores had been waiting for the waves to settle so he wouldn't overshoot.

Jimmy choked on thoughts of his son and daughter, the boat dipping suddenly, one of the tequila bottles spinning across the polished deck as fast as the decades of raising his children had spun into the ether of memory.

Two more dips, the bottle rolling backward and forward again until the sea became a cradle. He winked at the sun, hoped his daughter would remember the combination to his floor safe—if she couldn't, his son would crack it, Jimmy knew.

A wisp of cool air crossed the boat. He closed his eyes and saw everything that mattered.

The smell of spring in Boise, the primrose through open windows. His children small again, climbing into his arms on the green grass out front of their home, on the couch before bedtime with their sippy cups, their pajamas. Sprinklers up and down their street, and every sundown melting along the foothills until it dripped over the edges like candle wax.

He opened his eyes again and saw Flores step forward, the man's shorts risen with a terrifying adrenaline erection.

Jimmy said, "Jesus," just before his left armpit burned with the .32 slug that'd found its way inside. The blood seemed to cool him as it wetted through his linen shirt, discharged downward, pooled in the crease along his hipbone.

He stared upward, eyes seeing everything at once in electrifying clarity, the trip to Havana with his son like skywriting in that blue expanse above the boat. The smell of sliced oranges spritzing into a seltzer glass. The smell of his son, a blend of almond butter and evergreens.

Jimmy felt the second shot from the .32 before hearing it, two of his ribs separating now like the sound of a baseball bat cracking against a hardball in summer.

Heard two more shots.

Was drifting now into something like sleep and couldn't tell if the sound of gunfire originated from the .32 or Jimmy's own tennis shoes breaking onto sticks as he ran through a woods in dream, that shadow world that'd paralleled his life.

Someone was guiding Jimmy by the elbow now, the way Isabella'd guided him to bed, Jimmy a blind man led through that darkness called Leaving.

The final shot was followed by a thud on the deck, heavy like a sack of concrete landing beside him. Even with his eyes closed, he sensed another body.

Then like the waves, Jimmy came back, consciousness undulating, eyes opening to see Flores now face-down beside him. Blood leaked from a crater the size of a torn peach in the back of Flores' head. From his gaping mouth toppled a root beer-colored hard candy, shiny with saliva.

Then Jimmy saw a smaller boat, a rigid hull inflatable, shaped like a torpedo with a canvas awning and single outboard engine, carrying three men, each in sand-colored cargo pants, black tee shirts tight with muscle. One of the men had long hair pulled into a knot.

The boat horseshoed, rode onto Jimmy's port side, a loop of foam and spray behind it before the engine cut.

The man with long hair stood with his foot on the bow, one hand gripping the awning for balance, another on the black pistol grip of an AR-15 assault rifle slung across his chest. He was silhouetted in the sunlight, muscles long and thin. The wind swiped a lock of curls across the man's forehead—*But just a boy*, too—black stubble along the man's jawline but the collagen in his cheekbones not yet depleted by life, an Olympian spark in his eyes where the sun hit them.

Jimmy's pain had been too much, the love too overwhelming and hard—the loneliness and heartache over his son's leaving had

cored him to the bone. But now the boat drifted and cornered, and the boy stepped off its bow, onto the gunwale in desert-colored field boots that straddled the chrome railing—he pulled a SOG fixed blade knife from his belt, cut Jimmy’s zip ties away.

Then he hopped down into the boat with purchase, as if born for it.

Jimmy could smell the good health of the boy’s sweat, same as it’d smelled since he was thirteen, his son’s biceps more veined than Jimmy remembered, his center mass thicker and more capable, Jimmy slipping between layers of consciousness when he heard his son say, “Dad, we’re going to move you.”

And after so long, after so many years of missing his boy, Jimmy said the word he’d been searching for—*Adrian*, he said, the sound of the boy’s name like birds taking flight.

Jimmy wept so hard his tongue went into the recesses of his throat. The black birds overhead slid from wing to wing across the sky that was just an upside-down dance floor after all, he realized, daylight and midnight the same when he closed his eyes, felt breathless through the blood pooling in his throat.

Felt his chest pumped by stronger hands than Jimmy’s own, as if the pumping might never stop, even in the hollows where the dead kicked off their shoes to settle in.

TWENTY-FOUR

The first bullet had entered Jimmy through the outer edges of his left pectoral muscle then ricocheted off his ribs, exiting through his armpit with a clean hole that was easy to stitch, although the bone fractures left behind abided no true timeline for healing.

The second bullet entered Jimmy more squarely, lodging in the cartilage between two of his upper ribs like a dog squeezing through fence pickets. The slug was surgically removed in a two-hour procedure that left Jimmy hallucinating from the anesthesia when he awoke in the middle of the night and thought he saw his mother in a hardbacked chair. Her pink sweater draped loosely over her shoulders, a Pall Mall hanging from her lower lip. She'd smiled lovingly at Jimmy with eyes that were like small saucers of rainwater—tears, but joyful ones, pooling in them.

Jimmy'd felt she was wanting him home.

Although the stopping power of Flores' pistol of choice, the .32 caliber, was not always reliable for a kill shot to the torso, Jimmy would've nevertheless bled out quickly if not for his son. The boy's arrival and subsequent chunk of fruit taken out of Flores' head shared a timeline Jimmy feared revisiting; he would have gladly sacrificed his own safety to keep his son from the dangerous consequences of being known by the cartel.

Spent four days hospitalized in Puerto Vallarta under heavy American police oversight as part of an "international investigation," a phrase Braxton Gooding wielded like a shield each time local authorities requested to privately question Jimmy about the death of Flores, who for years had been feeding them slices of money-flavored bread, hand to mouth. They didn't appreciate their sustenance having been scorched at sea by Jimmy's son, wanted to probably bang Jimmy up, he knew, or

disappear him altogether. His son, too, no doubt, but even the cartel wouldn't fuck with an active duty American soldier.

On his second day in the hospital, the medical staff allowed Jimmy personal visits, starting with Gooding, who stood beside Jimmy's bed awash in light from the sterile, overhead halogens, the scent of fried eggs and black coffee and Old Spice aftershave emanating from his clothing.

"Your blood alcohol was high," he told Jimmy. "But I've heard you don't drink. I can imagine the stress you might be feeling. People tend to make poor decisions after they've made other poor decisions. That's why many of them end up in the box. We have three small interrogation rooms in our department—they're always full of people who have a lot on their minds, and there's a waiting line to get in. I have a theory that most people who've committed crimes just wanted somebody to talk to."

"I'm on pain medications," Jimmy told him. "I'd rather not be, so I could trust in the accuracy of my memory."

"I'll believe whatever is said here."

Then Jimmy told him, "Tio Flores shoved a bottle of tequila down my throat and kicked my face inside-out. When I was unconscious, I had no thoughts or dreams. When I awoke, the whole world was bright and the sky was enormous, a color of blue that usually only comes in crayon boxes. Then Flores put two bullets in my chest, Braxton."

"Understood."

Jimmy hesitated then added, "When you're told that a person doesn't partake in alcohol consumption, that's information you're lucky to have. If I told you I was hitting the gym six days a week, but you caught me pawing into a bag of chocolate eclairs on a Sunday, would you call me a fat-ass for the transgression?"

"You make a fair point," Gooding told him. "I'm sorry about that."

Then Gooding said to Jimmy, "Your son's a bit of a hotshot. Seems like a great kid. Can't say I'm pleased to meet him under these circumstances. We're all glad you're alive, but his involvement muddies the waters down here, to say the least."

“You didn’t send him?”

“Of course not. Your son and his mercenary pals are private citizens and I’m a police officer, last I looked at the badge, although that’s been locked in my wallet longer than a teenager’s condom. Maybe I need to look at it again, remind myself what side of the law I’m on, though I recognize that ugliness like Grisham Greasley and Mr. Flores sometimes requires a body scrub like rocks.”

Jimmy felt two steps behind the conversation.

“Is my son actually here in the hospital?”

“Yeah, I’ll send him in.”

“Wait,” Jimmy said. “Don’t talk to him.” Jimmy panic-spoke the words through the fog of opiates, instinctively wanting separation between Gooding and his son, none of that Gooding’s fault.

“Come again?”

“I misspoke,” Jimmy told him.

Gooding raised an eyebrow, told Jimmy, “The PV cops wanted to put charges on him last night. If I were you, I’d have those kids fly back with Ms. Lev before anybody notices. You don’t want your boy in a cinderblock playpen. Get him to Idaho and a month from now we’ll have you over to the house.”

“Back up,” Jimmy said. “Gertie Lev is also down here?”

“You bet. I guess it pays to build trust with billionaires. She’s who got your kid pulled from Afghanistan this week. And I think that lunatic friend of yours from Detroit had something to do with it, too. That’s an odd couple, right there.”

“Gooding,” Jimmy said before the man could leave. “You’re an exceptional police officer, so I want you know that your instincts about me aren’t wrong. It wouldn’t be right of me to cause you to second guess yourself. Do you understand what I’m saying to you?”

“My instincts?”

“Yes,” Jimmy said, hesitant.

“Oh,” Gooding said. “Gotcha.”

Jimmy exhaled then added, “I don’t prioritize that part of my life.”

“And if you did?”

It was a fair question, but one that wasn’t anybody’s business to ask of Jimmy but his own.

“Still wouldn’t be the right time for me,” Jimmy told him.

“Hard world to count on timing,” Gooding said. “But I copy you all the way. Thank you for telling me. Get healthy, Chinden—and we’ll keep the light on for you.”

Braxton left to find Jimmy’s son.

Jimmy’s eyelids felt heavy. Sleep, Jimmy’d once heard, was God’s medicine.

Two hours later, Jimmy awoke to his son in a steel-framed chair beside the bed. On Adrian’s wrist was the black tactical watch Jimmy’d tucked into a cardboard box and mailed to Afghanistan for his birthday almost a year ago. The boy’s hair no longer pulled behind his head but hanging now like beads along each temple, same as in the glossy photo Jimmy’d once kept in his truck, the boy eleven years old and receiving his blackbelt in taekwondo, the darker tones of the world not yet fully known to him—or if known, not synthesized, darkness a plague happening elsewhere.

Jimmy tried to sit up but there was too much pain in his ribs, the strength in his arms replaced by a hangover from the sedatives pumped intravenously overnight. For some reason, maybe vanity, he still wanted to seem strong around his children, wished to portray uprightness and vitality. A fool’s errand now, and possibly in all the years that’d passed—they knew who he was: loving, but imperfect and mortal.

“I can get you food if you’re hungry,” Adrian said.

Jimmy shook his head. “How are you here?”

“Ally found that man Flores’ business ledger in your safe. She pieced together that you went after him, so Jen got a hold of Ms. Lev. The next thing the US Army knew, the Saudis had dropped a private jet into Shindad for me. Chain of command was well-pissed, but since being in the military I’ve noticed that the top and

bottom rungs of the ladder seem most important, while the middle ones are interchangeable. My friends and I made a stop at Flores' brothel right away—it wasn't pretty, but we got what we needed to find you."

"I wish you hadn't been brought into this."

"Honestly, Ally was like a dog on a bone about getting me down here. I don't think Ms. Lev had a choice once Ally sunk her teeth in."

Jimmy's son pursed his lips, breathing through his nose with intention, a trick Jimmy'd taught the boy in childhood to steady his heartrate.

Then he said to Jimmy, "I know you don't approve of this part of my life—but I've seen people die, Dad, and by the time I got onto that boat you looked just like them."

Jimmy reached his hand over. The boy took it, and Jimmy felt callouses and dry skin around his son's fingertips and palms, the hands having done physical work Jimmy'd not been witness to, same as the work the boy's heart had done in Jimmy's absence.

"I made mistakes in how I reacted to your decisions," Jimmy told him. "It wasn't fair of me. It's just that a parent sometimes wants his children alive more than he wants himself to be."

"Mom told me you'd say some shit like that," Adrian smiled. "She says your autism really shines when you're medicated. 'Be prepared,' she said."

"You spoke with your mother?" Jimmy was caught off-guard. *How was she even on the boy's radar after all these years?*

"Only every weekend since I enlisted," Adrian told him. "Here's an idea—Why don't we all try being alive at once?"



Jimmy was flown back to Idaho when well-enough to be moved. Did two days of in-patient rehabilitation at St. Luke's until the insurance company finally kicked him out. Checked himself into The Modern Hotel downtown, detoxing for a week while using the dining area to give statements to BPD about the murders of Bobby

Abbiati and Bartholomew Tall—and about Abbiati's brutal disposal in the Detroit River, which Jimmy rightly claimed to have had no choice but to assist with.

Kootenai County sent deputies, whom Jimmy provided additional statements to about the shootout in Coeur d'Alene. Greasley and Evelyn Hawkstellar had deep ties to North Idaho cops, so the top dogs naturally wanted Jimmy in the box, but the audio recording Jimmy'd sent to Gooding left little room for interpretation. It'd continued to record while sticking out of Greasley's neck.

The Idaho State Police and FBI arrived, and Jimmy repeated his statements for a gaggle of investigators, the lobby of the hotel buzzing like a base camp for a military op. Uniforms and holstered semi-autos crowded the bar—precisely why Jimmy'd gotten a room instead of going home, to keep the attention from his children, both of whom were temporarily staying with Jen while hairdos from the news stations hounded Jimmy for scraps.

For now, Jimmy was told, he would not be taken into custody.

Each evening, Jimmy went to the nine o'clock Alcoholics Anonymous meeting a half mile up the road, traveling on foot beneath a canopy of late summer pollen with the sun deep orange along its edges as night teased in. Walked slowly, in excruciating pain from the trauma to his ribs, his head post-concussive with a sensitivity to noise that'd accompany him for months, maybe longer.

Campbell was staying in town with Gertie Lev at The Grove Hotel while Jimmy got clean, joining Jimmy in the AA room each night. He was a familiar face in a fold-down chair, sometimes the most we can hope for when the world turns sideways and tries to shake us off, or when we've attempted to let go without knowing why.

The room often full of people appearing much worse off than Jimmy, most without any years clean, several with the rotted-away teeth of methamphetamine use or the alcoholic's raspberry, swollen complexion there was no turning back from after thirty years chasing the bottom, yet each person in the room felt as

Jimmy did inside, hollowed-out by the sometimes uncontrollable twister we called addiction for fear of naming it the devil.

Each of them had their blind spots, too. Maybe one of Jimmy's had been his ex-wife, the quietly-building enmity he knew he'd harbored toward her unwarranted after all this time. *Hadn't he been equally responsible for her absence, after all?* If Adrian were in contact with her, Ally must've been, also. Jimmy, he began to understand, hadn't been enough for his children on his own. Scanning the anonymous faces each night, the similarities were striking. Each of them heartbroken, lonely beneath the pain. He didn't want his kids to end up in one of these rooms two decades down the road because he'd forced them to take sides and they'd chosen neither.

Campbell and Jimmy strolled back through Boise's downtown corridor after each meeting. The bars and restaurants on 8th Street vibrated, and the nights were loud with pedestrian chatter. The throttle-hoppers and Japanese lowriders full of drunken teens revved their boutique engines down Bannock Street a block away and the cops parked in their tinted Ford Explorers on every corner, checking plate numbers against dash-mounted laptops that glowed in blue hues. The whole world acting as it always had, yet Jimmy remaining deeply out of sync.

There was still so much he hadn't the time to process. He'd lain with Ayita, developing feelings that her murder had disallowed exploration of—more than the possibility of Greasley being Jimmy's father, his momentary physical and emotional attraction to a woman who'd apparently been his half-sister now seemed an unfathomable transgression.

On a Sunday at the end of August, Jimmy checked out of his air-conditioned room with the stand-alone tub he'd soaked in seven nights running. On foot, cut across parking lots with his duffle over his shoulder, the smell of burnt coffee grounds and old trash emanating from dumpsters in the alleys, sunlight banking off concrete and the temperature a hundred degrees with a dry heat that got into the lungs like burning cedar.

At 11:30 in the morning, he met Gertie Lev in the lobby of the Grove Hotel. The hardwood columns and chocolate-leather armchairs were newly polished, the aroma of fresh croissants wafting in precise timing with the late-morning foot traffic of the rich, the world's pleasantest smells seemingly choreographed to their schedules—*but who was he to complain?* Gertie, despite Jimmy's harsh judgment of her family's wealth, had been nothing but helpful.

She wore jeans and shin-high caramel leather boots that looked custom made. Her blouse open to her sternum, she appeared flush when they sat down for a quick coffee.

"It's possible that we're related," Jimmy told her.

"Said half of Idaho to the other half."

She sipped her coffee from a porcelain cup, and in that momentary silence Jimmy felt he was being shadowed. Looked through big glass windows of the lobby to the Valet roundabout, saw nothing unusual. Monochromatic rental vehicles lined the drive, sunlight sword-hot against their windshields.

Then Gertie said, "I only know what the coppers told me. But I think this soon makes Dr. Campbell your brother-in-law. He proposed, and I may have accepted. I've never met somebody so enjoyably inept at life while remaining so accomplished, not even in Hollywood. Jimmy, I know you and I have a lot to discuss but the math tells me it's taken a short time to lose four members of my family—I have to get through that, first. I've spent the entire week crying into my hands. There is pain, and then there is something I am useless to describe. Your friend has been holding me through all of that. Maybe he's just a set of strong arms right now but what happens if I truly love him?"

"Has he told you he's an addict?"

"He didn't have to. I know what people are, Jimmy—although even addicts deserve love, sometimes more fiercely than others. Try not to forget that."

Campbell had come from the elevator foyer dragging suitcases behind him, a rolled *New York Times* thick as a fire log squeezed beneath the armpit of his seersucker blazer. His tee shirt was an

old The Replacements concert item, purchased probably thirty years ago.

When Jimmy stood to embrace him, Campbell had tears in his eyes.

“Thank you for letting me help you,” he said to Jimmy.

“You don’t have to thank the people you save.”

“Yes, you do,” he said.

Gertie and Campbell departed in an Uber Black for the private air strip at Gowen Field. Jimmy walked unmistakably alone the dozen blocks to St. John’s Cathedral, where Mass was letting out. Parishioners mingled on street corners beside the shrub roses and decorative box elders and a solitary, leafy green Plane tree near the foot of the long series of steps leading to archways in the hundred-year-old church.

St. John’s was long as a city block and nearly as tall. From the sidewalk, Jimmy spotted Jennifer Hope at the top of the stairs, bending at the knees in her Sunday dress to gather bulletin sheets that’d blown from inside. Her hair pushed behind one ear, cheekbones noticeably sun kissed even from a distance. She disappeared back into the air conditioning.

Jimmy found her tidying the altar and the liturgical furnishings in the sanctuary. Several parishioners were still seated among the many rows of pews, the nave high and rounded and its ceiling ornate above them, Jimmy with his duffel still slung.

“Are you hopping a train?” she asked, gesturing to his bag.

They sat on the marbled steps together, Jimmy noticeably solemn.

“You’re still thinking about Ayita,” Jen acknowledged. “But the human being is just a species, Jimmy. In the absence of ‘good intel,’ as you call it, we act on instinct and don’t always know why. Only God has 360 radar, so whatever happened is completely understandable.”

“Nothing happened. Not technically.”

“Then don’t go seeking high ledges because of this, yeah?”

The weight in his heart lifted slightly. Jen’s presence had always grounded him. For Jimmy, uncertainties in life had often

presented as shame, but he didn't feel that around Jen.

"How would you like a nice dinner?" he asked her.

"Let's wait a few weeks. But yes."

The final stragglers were leaving their pews, shuffling quietly.

Jimmy's gaze lifted to the vestibule and its three open doors beyond it, from where sunlight funneled almost languidly into the cathedral, as if softly pouring from an overhead pitcher.

There, highlighted against a wall, was the figure of Sandy Billings, his wrist in a cast from where Jimmy'd snapped it and a scowl on his face long enough to run a bus line across.

By the time Jimmy stood, Billings had pivoted and gone.

TWENTY-FIVE

That afternoon, Jimmy moved back into his home and opened the windows to the fecund scent of late summer in the North End, the garden plots in the Craftsman style houses to either side of Jimmy's bungalow puffy with red tomatoes on the vine. There was dust in the air from the foothills and the taste of smoke from a fire burning in the northeast, toward the old mining town of Idaho City. The sky was the color of washed-out teak when the sun moved behind it.

By early evening, he'd lit the barbecue and lay skirt steaks, cobs of corn, and long, peeled sweet potato wedges doused in olive oil and salt and pepper across the flames while Ally and Adrian pulled the patio table from the shade of their covered backyard porch into the last hours of sunlight.

It had been several years since they'd all sat together like this.

Jimmy drank sweet tea over crushed ice and his son and daughter split a bottled beer in two jelly glasses between them, their eyes speaking of entire lives lived but the words not yet on their lips, the whole family introverted by nature, Ally without meat on her plate—she'd been vegetarian since she was three years old, excluding the occasional Hebrew National hotdog Jimmy'd forced her to eat during the lean times between grocery runs when she was a kid.

Honeybees visited the purple clematis flowers growing along the fence line, seemed to spritz the yard with a perfume they carried back to their small hive in a soffit behind the gutters of the house. Jimmy wondered if he could ever hold his children again in the ways he wanted to, like holding onto the branches of a tree if you were falling. Maybe the time for physical closeness had ended, too soon for him.

"I've always felt very lost," Jimmy said with trepidation, not wanting to disrupt the evening but sensing an opportunity to

connect. “As each of you got older and needed me less, I transferred that pain onto you. When you love someone but hold too tightly, they hurt from it. I did that to both of you, I think.”

His children exchanged looks with each other. They stopped eating and Ally drank from her glass of beer to swish down a mouthful of corn.

Then she wiped her hands on a cloth napkin and asked, “This self-pity you’ve concocted—it’s why your suicide mission ended with a bender?”

“I guess so,” Jimmy said.

Then his son told him, “Overseas, our Detachment Commander told us from day one, ‘It’s tempting to stand over a whirling fan—but try not to piss on it.’”

“Point taken,” Jimmy nodded.

His nerves were still slightly trembling at the edges from coming off alcohol and he felt a subsequent depression but also the outline for happiness, blooms of joy he knew would open wider in time, when his son added, “You know we love you, right?”

“I do,” Jimmy told him.

After a lingering silence, Jimmy added, “I’ve been doing things solo, far too long. Loneliness starts as bravery but continues as selfishness. That’s a place alcoholics can’t live inside forever. Conveniently, the disease avoids reminding you of that.”

“So, you should go out with Jen,” Ally said. “I’m pretty sure she spent all week pretending not to think about you.”

“I’m already ahead of you,” Jimmy confessed.

Both kids smiled. Then Ally said, “Well it’s a good thing I found Flores’ ledger in your safe, because Jennifer Hope deserves a lot better than fish bait. I also noticed a festive amount of cash, a .22 revolver, and a stack of old DVDs as tall as a birthday cake.”

The DVDs. Adrenaline pulsed up Jimmy’s neck like a puck dinging a strongman’s bell.

Twenty-seven years ago, on the night he’d set his mother’s motel aflame, Jimmy’d stopped inside the lobby, vacant for remodeling after Hillcrest took ownership. Out the big front

windows had been traffic on Chinden Boulevard, headlights momentarily flashing the lobby's asbestos ceiling.

Jimmy's mother had been dead for a month, but the lobby still smelled of her over the gasoline on his clothing.

When she'd passed, he suffered such shock he'd forgotten to recover the contents of her safe before vacating the property for Hillcrest, although he'd always known the combination—she'd even said to him, Jimmy no older than thirteen at the time, “If one day I die, you take whatever you can dig up. What's mine ain't mine.”

On the night he came to burn it all to the ground, Jimmy first pulled back her foam anti-fatigue mat, then carpet-covered, hinged trap door in the floorboards over her safe—Jimmy's inspiration for his own, much later. Loaded the bottom of his backpack with the twenty-six VHS tapes filled for her during Jimmy's years of capturing men at some of their weakest moments.

While still a cop, he'd paid a local filmmaker working as a Confidential Informant against a high-level coke dealer in Ketchum to transfer the VHS footage to DVDs. Six months later, the CI took mortal crossfire during a State Police sting at a Self-Storage. Jimmy had burned the originals but kept the DVDs.

After supper, Jimmy cleaned the table, washed the dishes looking out the rear window above the sink, the neighbor's orange Calico cat, Toby, staring back at him from her haunches in Jimmy's yard. Ally and Adrian had gone to a movie at The Flicks, planned to hit Pengilly's afterward for a few beers, Uber home. Jimmy knew they'd be gone late, bubbling with reconnection.

The house echoed with their absence. He'd never get used to that but was glad for the few hours alone tonight.

With the dishes put away, Jimmy pulled back his refrigerator, opened the safe in his kitchen floor. Removed the stack of unmarked DVDs. An industrial rubber band held them in place, the footage ironically Jimmy's only version of family photos from a childhood drizzled in neon.

He sat on the edge of his bed with a small remote he'd put fresh batteries into, then spent much of the night with his bedroom door

shut and the television on his bureau tethered to an old Sony DVD player he'd pulled from the laundry room.

Each DVD contained several hours of footage depicting many men, their silhouettes grainy in the shadows but halogens from the parking lot flaring against their facial structure when Jimmy occasionally paused the player. One man with a V-neck tee, another in a polo and Member's Only jacket, one in a necktie, one wearing khakis, his ass wider than a fifty-pound sack of corn meal. The variety colorful but the look on each man's face similarly shellacked by depravity and unhappiness.

He fast-forwarded through the injection molded disks fanned like spilt casino chips across his bureau, paused them when he heard Ally and Adrian come in around 2:00 AM. Heard them brush their teeth. Heard their doors shut quietly. Resumed when he guessed they'd gone to sleep.

Men in ballcaps, often-enough, with work boots coated in drywall dust, or men in sport coats crossed from their cars and timidly knocked on the numbered motel doors. Jimmy's memories of what he now watched on DVD were as clear as if he'd lived that long-ago life just this week. He could smell the juniper bushes he'd hid within, could feel the auto fumes in his throat from diesel trucks rolling down Chinden Boulevard. Heard the car doors in the motel parking lot shutting with a metal-on-metal friction that reverberated from across the street, vibrating in his body to this day.

Fifteen disks into the pile, Jimmy watched the footage of Tio Flores and Grisham Greasley, Flores behind the steering wheel of a black sedan he pulled into the parking lot. Maybe in his thirties at the time but unmistakable. Then Greasley stepped out of the vehicle, wingtip shoes shiny on the pavement, the night warmly lit and his suit tailored to fit his athletic body, two cufflinks catching light from the headlamps before Flores dimmed them.

In one hand, Greasley held a legal-sized manila envelope folded in half around what could only have been a brick of cash, rectangular and wide as the claw of Greasley's fingers but malleable where he gripped it.

Greasley went into the lobby and Flores lit a cigarette, waiting.

Jimmy could remember that night, meaningless to him as a child, but now in the playback saw that Grisham Greasley had been the seed-partner in Jimmy's life. Jimmy not abandoned, after all, not a sex worker's son but his mother's. The woman protecting him from knowing Greasley's cruelty all those years.

Yet she'd also kept Gee-Gee on a permanent hook. Maybe, Jimmy thought, even baited Gee-Gee from the go.

At the end of the disk was another ten-minute segment.

Filmed inside his mother's bedroom, the footage showed Gee-Gee and Jimmy's mother in black and white. They smoked cigarettes. They each did a shot of vodka poured into a water glass from the bathroom. They kissed briefly, but Jimmy refused to watch the rest.

There was still an hour of hard dark before sun-up. His children long asleep in bedrooms they'd grown too tall for now, the entire home with ghosts of their childhoods anguishing Jimmy but beautiful ghosts as well, scampering shadows that were his memories flooding the rooms whenever the two were home at once.

Jimmy made a strong coffee, took two hot gulps, dumped the rest in the kitchen sink.

He buttoned up the house, drove his daughter's rented Ford Explorer, secured with Jimmy's credit card a week ago, thirteen miles to the east of town, first down Warm Springs Avenue and its mansions primarily built from ancestral money, land grab cash amassed in trickles from the slaughter of the Indigenous, then further out to where the road followed against the flow of the Boise River.

Jimmy swiped the wipers to wash the condensation from his windshield, unrolled the windows, let the dew-covered sage and rabbitbrush waft through. The road out front of his high beams was a heartbreak of condominiums, the world seemingly godless where asphalt paved it.

There were foothills to the left, flatland and scrub trees and the evergreen-colored river to the right, a set of headlights tailing

Jimmy a quarter mile back.

He knew this would be Sandy Billings but what did it matter?

Jimmy could vaguely feel Ayita's purpose in his life but without language or cognitive grasp, the memory of her simply another of the ghosts, too soon joining his mother in a world no mortal can perceive without the penalty of traveling to it. Perhaps the brief urges he'd felt toward Ayita would be forgiven, even by himself. He had not known her, and in time mankind's failings were trivial against the magnificence of the universe, always.

Miles from town the road veered into a gravel turnoff where Jimmy parked his vehicle, cut his lights against the silhouette of massive Lucky Peak Dam. Its gigantic spillways were open, the sun just-then breaching with a burnt orange crease over the foothills as millions of gallons of water released into the river, wide and green-deep and turbulent with spray.

Jimmy stepped out of his vehicle, the gravel crunching beneath his tactical shoes, the old .22 in his hand but nobody to kill with it anymore. After all these years, vengeance was meted out by higher than man. Perhaps this was a lesson Jimmy'd have been luckier to learn years ago.

He stood on the rocky scarp overlooking the river. The immense rooster tail of water from the spillways shot a hundred feet into the air, arcing and loud. A water that'd come from the mountains was corralled to power air conditioning units and TVs, the excess spurting through flip buckets with unfathomable strength. Diverted snowmelt could flood civilizations, fire eat across thousand-mile ranges, mere wind destroy the entirety of mankind's constructions while our desire for similar control over the minutia of daily life foolishly, sanctimoniously dictated our decisions in the face of overwhelming evidence of humanity's insignificance.

From his elevated footing, he hurled the .22 with a good arm and shoulder behind it, the left side of his body throbbing with pain from his still-healing wounds. The steel barrel and cylinder of the pistol flashed with new sunlight at its high point over the

river, twirling. Then the .22 disappeared into the deep, black shadows of the water with a flump.

He turned back to his vehicle, where Billings cut the headlights on his Chevy Silverado. Stepped onto the gravel, calmly shut his door. Spit tobacco juice that grazed his work boot. Held what looked like a Ruger .45 in the half-dark along his leg.

"I've been shadowing you for a week, trying to decide if I was going to kill you or not," Billings told him.

"You'd have every right to," Jimmy said. "Grisham Greasley had my mother executed and you suffered for that."

Even in the low, dusty light of dawn, the scar tissue rising from Billings's neck looked rugged as ancient tree bark.

Then Jimmy added, "Braxton Gooding pulled the Garden City arson report for me. I suppose he mentioned that to you and something clicked?"

Sandy Billings said nothing to that, so Jimmy continued, "You were a rookie when my mother's motel went up, and you with it. There's no good apology for the type of pain you must have endured."

"The first nine months, I chewed sandwiches with my tongue instead of my teeth," Billings told him, his voice like crushed granite in a tumbler. "I routinely woke up screaming from nightmares that God was pouring a bucket of red ants down my throat. I got addicted to Oxy, and I went seven years not getting laid without money on the nightstand. Oh, and my firefighting career was done quicker than a high school hand job."

He spit black juice out of his mouth again, blotting the stones. His fingers tightened around the .45 and his body looked spring-loaded.

Jimmy said, "I'm thinking a man down on his luck gets put on a pad pretty easily. Suddenly you're the arson inspector out in Eastern Idaho, Greasley's burn pattern catching a blind eye. Is that how it worked?"

"Who cares how anything works," Billings told him. "It's a fucking animal kingdom. The only thing half-good in that desert

was Ayita Smith. I gave her shit, but the woman never looked at me like I had a tampon tracheotomy sticking out of my neck.”

Daylight seemed to arrive like a dinner napkin turned onto its clean side, the creases beneath Billings’ eyes containing softened orbs that revealed no true blood lust to match the man’s weapon.

Then Billings added, “I haven’t been on a pad for Gee-Gee in ten years. If I had, my intel on your fucking Impala would’ve been better and I wouldn’t’ve called you to the site—you’d have never met Ayita, and she wouldn’t have been blowed-up so easy. Maybe a goon creeps her house instead but then there’s odds Ayita gets the first shot. All manner of things can upend a stupid man’s plans. God makes us believe the promise we’re invincible, but you know what they say about promises: The bigger they are, the more holes you can shoot in ‘em.”

Billings took a step closer, the gravel crunching under his boots.

Jimmy put a hand up and said, “I’m going to reach into my back pocket. There’s two pieces of paper here, one of them the deed to Greasley’s stadium parcel, worth at least four million. What I have is called a ‘wild deed,’ meaning it wasn’t recorded after signing but it’s perfectly legal and it happens to supersede the current deed of record—only myself and Gertie Lev have true claim to the property right now. The other sheet of paper is a Quit Claim deed giving you my half of ownership. I signed it a week ago, right after I got the motel’s fire report from Gooding.”

“You bribing me with bullshit?”

“A bribe would mean I fear you, but the swastikas on your arms show weakness to me. Maybe my actions as a young man caused your moral decline, but it’s my belief that if you didn’t deserve those scars beforehand, you’ve done something along the way that justifies them now.”

“Ain’t we all,” Billings told him. “Like you tossing that piece in the river.”

“That was the weapon Tio Flores murdered my mother with.”

“How do you know it was Flores?” Billings asked, a flicker in his eyes revealing he’d already known, perhaps for years, who’d

put Jimmy's mother down. Just hadn't known she'd been Jimmy's mother, was all.

"I guess God told me," Jimmy responded.

"Did God also tell you what's under that land your mother's shithole used to occupy?"

"No," Jimmy said. Thought he saw deflection in Billings' eyes. Then he saw something more familiar, an opening to the recesses of the man's heart^{3/4}behind the anger was hurt, and behind the hurt a young man with desires and dreams not yet subordinated by collective sin. Billings, Jimmy saw, had carried even Jimmy's suffering all these years, the usual way violence took hold.

"If you have information about my mother's property," Jimmy added, "Maybe we could get a soda and talk about it."

Billings tucked the .45 into his rear waistband. Stepped forward and took the paperwork from Jimmy's hand. Jimmy smelled chewing tobacco from the man's lower lip, the stale sweat of his armpits when Billings said, "I know what you are, Chinden. There's more of you than flies." Then he added, "Fucker."

He got into his truck and sprayed gravel at Jimmy's shins when he turned it.

A week later, the RV lot was cleared of vehicles and a yellow CAT-branded backhoe with an adjustable bucket and shovel moved dirt and gravel for ninety minutes while Jimmy watched from the cab of his truck across the street, his front windows down and the engine off, the temperature ninety-seven degrees in waves across Chinden Boulevard.

The sky was bright blue, the sun a white-hot ember as Braxton Gooding and several Garden City and Idaho State Police detectives traipsed around the property that'd underwritten Jimmy's childhood memories—and that eventually cradled his mother's body, for lack of other arms to do so, while she awaited discovery, a bullet in each of her eyes as if tapping them for syrup.

The cops were three hours into their dig when the large backhoe teeth pulled up a patchwork of human bones, a dirt-smeared ulna and hand breaching the bucket as casually as a woman's arm hanging over the side of a bath.

Jimmy got out of his truck, shut the door, stood in the shadow of a juniper scrub, watching across traffic. Could clearly see the outline of his mother's motel and not see it at the same time, not knowing which world he lived in was the ghost of the other.

By sundown, the remains of six young women had been excavated, their pieces laid across polyethylene tarps and covered by industrial canopies then lit overnight by large halogens connected to a pair of generators brought in by ISP for cataloguing the bone fragments.

The victims would later be identified as ranging in age from fifteen to twenty-three, all missing from Indigenous lands and presumably murdered by Grisham Greasley. The rumors from early in his life seemingly true, a posthumous case was now being built. Greasley'd thought so little of his prey he'd leased their burial grounds to a salesman of recreational vehicles with aging oil pans and cracked septic tanks leaking sewage residue into their gravel-covered, haphazard tombs.

Deep in Jimmy's heart, he hoped Gee-Gee's fate was a similarly defiled, pitch-black bed allowing only restlessness, the air thick as pine tar, the only sound a contaminated, eternal howl from the cask of his open mouth.



September was hotter than August had been. There were back-to-back hundred-degree days that wilted the foliage in Jimmy's yard for two weeks straight. Even the fox squirrels seemed to be napping through most afternoons, stretched face down like exhausted cats along the thicker branches of the large oak trees lining the street.

Ally and Adrian remained in Boise longer than Jimmy expected, so as Adrian's thirty-day, special circumstance leave from Afghanistan began to run out Jimmy indulged in spending most of his own afternoons watching the boy lift weights in the garage with the roll-up door open to the heat, or Adrian would lounge for hours in the grass under the baking sun, an animal who

now felt better outdoors than inside—a “man animal,” Jimmy thought, his boy grown into a thing no longer to be harnessed, Jimmy no longer wishing for that, and the pain of letting go not without reward.

To witness beauty like his son was worth the heartbreak of dispossession.

Ally worked continuously on her new piece for the *Times*, slaving on her laptop at the yellow Formica table Jimmy’d bought at a yard sale fifteen years earlier for forty bucks, his daughter now in the same vinyl chair she’d occupied since she was ten years old, the seat with the good view of the garden out the back window.

Jimmy left her alone with her work but each time he crossed the kitchen remembered Ally as the little gay girl with red Converse high-tops and skintight jeans, retro T-Rex and Joan Jett pins along the straps of her school backpack, the route she walked to Boise High not always populated by the likes of Brody Hawkstellar, the world offering brilliance and possibility and moral truths, things Jimmy believed his daughter still fought for today, guideposts that on good days he still believed in, himself.

A fire ripped through the foothills behind Table Rock on the morning of Jennifer Hope’s birthday, and by mid-afternoon the sky was the texture of sandstone. The two patio light stringers twinkled against a smoky haze that’d sunk into the valley.

Jimmy lit the barbecue, opened the outdoor faucet that fed into a thirty-foot strand of misting rope looped along the awning. He set out a cooler of crushed ice and bottled beers and flavored soda water, put ribs on the grill that he’d pre-boiled in a stock pot.

The buttons of his linen shirt were splayed to just below Jimmy’s sternum, where on clear days direct sunlight warmed the edges of the tiniest of crescent-shaped scars, an inherited totem, hot sometimes even when he slept.

He didn’t know half of what he’d hoped to know by now in his life, how to at least hold joy as close to the chest as we held our pain, but knew his son and daughter were together in the house

they'd been raised within—in the world Jimmy'd come from, this was as close to touching brilliance as he possibly deserved.

There was also hope in letting go. Not forever, but in exchange for moments of peace. The Greyhound station, he'd heard, was shutting down, hipsters renovating it. The restaurant Txikiteo becoming a coffee shop soon. All of Idaho changing in a blink, new money clogging the highways with out of state Teslas. Somehow, there might be angels in this, too. Certainly grace, an order to life we only saw when releasing our grip. Or if not order, life at least, which was something beautiful.

The ribs would cook down for an hour over low heat, lathered in a molasses sauce Jimmy learned to make from his mother those few times she'd dragged a portable grill into the lot, the meat charring atop red-hot briquettes from the filling station and the smell of lighter fluid and cigarette smoke and sunscreen smeared across her hands all at once.

Ally would shuck a bag of corn between her legs, Adrian would drink a beer and set the patio table, and Jen would arrive just as the ribs needed turning, Jimmy predicted—just as the flames lifted beneath his tongs, the misters overhead like a sea breeze shoring against the heat and smoke from the fires.

Jen had a way of showing up that was clean as a kiss leaning in, the way a memory sometimes slides into that part of our brain that's been patiently awaiting it, the sun across our skin a million times but never with such fluidity, the moon never quite as soft as now, the whole damned world cracking apart and we wouldn't even know it.

THE END

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J. Reuben Appelman's crime writing has received “best of” awards by the *NYT Book Review*, *Newsweek*, *People Magazine*, *Oprah Daily*, *Elle*, *Bustle*, *USA Today*, and dozens of other media outlets. He has written and produced multiple feature documentaries, and executive produced *Children of the Snow*, the docuseries based on ten years of research for his true-crime memoir, *The Kill Jar*, about the Oakland County Child Killings. Appelman is a two-time State of Idaho Literature Fellow, and works as a private investigator.

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